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Dedication

For my Family

Establishing Glory

The Praise and Worship Handbook

Dedication

This book is dedicated to the woman who showed me how to stand firm in my convictions, learn from every situation, and see God in the midst of it all: my mother, Permelia Ann Smith.

Preface

Before I type a single word about how to be the most significant worship leader, the most fantastic minstrel, or a phenomenal psalmist, let's address some pertinent and sobering questions.

I've been a Minister of Music, Director of Worship and Arts, Musical Director, Worship Leader, and a myriad of other "titles" in the church for over 30 years. But contrary to popular belief, none of these titles mean a thing if you can't honestly answer "Yes" to the questions later in this chapter. Otherwise, this complete manual will be just another book added to the collection gathering dust next to Jakes, Bevere, and Price.

Some are already wondering, "Why did this dude start this book with such a serious tone?" So, here's the answer, and it's simple: Praise and Worship is serious.

Over the years, we've glamorized the positions. People want to sing on a stage or perform live streamed on the internet, with millions of views and thousands of followers, world-renowned, and let's not forget, paid. But Luke 12:48 (MSG) says plainly: "Great gifts mean great responsibilities; greater gifts, greater responsibilities!"

The first question to ask yourself is, "Are you ready for the responsibility?"

In this manual, we will discuss the responsibility and the preparation needed to fulfill this formidable task of praise and worship.

Secondly, "Are you equipped?"

As a musician/singer, do you practice your craft? Are you skillful? How much time are you currently spending on bettering yourself?

Finally, "Are you committed?"

I may have just lost half of my potential readers with this one. But it is what it is. We need to be committed to the task. Every gathering isn't going to be a stellar performance. There will be some less-than-stellar "YouTube" moments or failures, some that may make you laugh, and quite a few that may make you cringe and cry. There may even be some WorldStar moments (and we pray that there won't be). But the reality is that we must be committed to the task.

I'm not one to linger, so let's jump right in.

Chapter 1: What Does It Mean To Be A Lead Worshipper?

This manual is not designed to boost your ego or make you into something you're not intended to be. As with stereo instructions, some concepts may be stated plainly, but the real meaning can be missed.

Praise and worship aren't just about the worship team being called at the beginning of service, singing a few songs, making everyone jump for a spell, and returning to their seats after "having a good time."

Nor is it about singing the latest and greatest Top 40 “church” songs or seeing how many runs you can accomplish vocally or instrumentally.

It is about getting into the presence of Almighty God and presenting an offering to Him that will be accepted while leading the congregation into that same place. We aren’t “worship leavers” but “worship leaders.”

Worship leaders are those who have prepared themselves in song and spirit. They have a relationship with God outside of the four walls of the church, and they are at the helm of the ship called worship.

Simply put, “You can’t take others somewhere you haven’t been.”

Worship is a lifestyle. It isn’t like being on a crash diet to drop a bunch of pounds to fit into a specific dress or suit. It is continual. It is every day. It is nonstop. We eat, live, and breathe worship.

But wait. I am not saying that you need to be a super Christian (one who speaks in KJV, has never sinned, and every third phrase is, “the Lord told me to tell you....” No, no, no. A difference must occur in you to manifest the purpose God wants to flow through you.

Being a worshipper is not a solo venture. Check out 1 Chronicles 25. Did you know that when David selected the musicians, there were 288 chosen (with their families)? And “They were well-trained in the sacred music, all of them masters” (1 Chronicles 25:7, MSG).

A part of the responsibility isn’t just leading the church congregation. You also must lead your home.

As I write this, I am reflecting on my childhood. My father was (and still is) a Minister of Music. My mother was a choir director and a songwriter. So, music was always in the house. We went to every service, practice, and performance. Even family gatherings would end up with everyone around that upright piano, singing songs and praising God. But you may be surprised that my parents never forced us to make music.

We didn’t make music; we were music, and we were always learning to focus on the purpose of the music in us. So that separated us from the many whose worship is casual.

Purpose doesn’t just jump out at you and - BAM - you’ve arrived. Discovering the potential of your purpose is a lifelong journey.

When my brother was consecrated as an infant, the pastor spoke a special blessing over his hands. He has been a musician since he was big enough to hold two spoons and beat on the table. Others have had to learn what their purpose is: aggressively. His was thrust upon him at birth.

God has a purpose for each of us.

The key is finding out what it is and learning how to walk in it. The only way you will honestly find your purpose is to seek God more and more deeply. Jeremiah 29:11 (NIV) says, “For I know the plans I have for you....”

Establishing a relationship with God sets you on course for realizing your purpose. Maintaining a relationship with Him keeps you on the path.

So, how do we establish and maintain a relationship with God?

“Prayer, fasting, and study.” It’s just that simple.

Each day of being a worshipper should begin and end with God. God should fill every moment. Again, how can you lead people into a place you haven’t gone?

Unfortunately, most congregants only think about God when they are in the worship service. Still, many think about what they will do after service while sitting there. We must break past all that “stuff” and help them enter His presence; if we don’t, we’ve failed.

Yes, we’ve failed. It wouldn’t be the congregations’ fault if the praise and worship bombed. It isn’t the musicians’ fault because they forgot how to play the verse. It would not be the singers’ fault if they didn’t know the vamp. We failed as worship leaders to lead the people into God’s presence. It is our fault!

Praise and worship aren’t just a filler in service until the announcements and offerings are done. Preparing people’s hearts and minds to receive God’s spoken Word is vital. Almost half of us would miss the message if every service started with the preacher, not just because we arrived late but because our minds weren’t focused on Jesus yet.

The Word of God is our living bread. You can’t just open the oven and grab the rolls. You’d burn yourself and wouldn’t want another piece. The table must be prepared. The table is your heart. Once your heart is ready, receiving the bread of life is easy and beneficial.

So, as lead worshippers, we are helping to set the table by creating an atmosphere that God will saturate. This leaves us in a place ready to receive.

We have a tremendous responsibility, starting with prayer, fasting, and study.

Chapter 2: Skilled Worker

Worship leaders must become skilled in their craft.

All too often, we live by Psalm 100:1 (KJV), “Make a joyful noise unto the Lord, all ye lands.” But the problem with this is that making a “joyful noise” needs to become a mindset.

We are reminded in Proverbs 23:7, “For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he.”

We set ourselves up for mediocrity when God wants better. And not just better, He wants the best. But settling to be “joyful noisers” opens us up to a spirit of slothfulness.

When we relegate ourselves to being “joyful noisers,” not only do we not study the music, but often we haven’t even listened to it before practice. We come to practice with our minds all over the place. We are unfocused. Teaching a new song becomes impossible, and reviewing old songs is a strain. We present the songs to God before the congregation half-heartedly. Then, we wonder why the song (s) didn’t go over and the people didn’t “get with us.”

Instead of making a joyful noise, we should have a mindset of perfected praise. Matthew 21:16 (NKJV) clarifies that even “out of the mouth of babes and nursing infants, you have perfected praise.”

What is ‘perfected praise,’ and what does it have to do with being a skilled worker? The simple answer is that perfected praise comes from the heart. It’s true worship.

One of my favorite worship songs is “The Anthem” by Planet Shakers. One of my worship team leaders suggested this song. When I first heard it, it was a “nice song.” Being in an “Apostolic” house (more to come on that), the song matched the sound of the house. So, we started to learn it. As I began playing this song at home, the Spirit of the Lord consumed me, and I couldn’t stop playing it. I played and played. Time was no longer a factor. And God Himself was in the studio with me. When I finally ended my practice time, almost two hours had passed, and I had only practiced this ONE song!

My spirit connected with this song. So, whenever this song is presented, it immediately connects with me, and what is in me naturally comes out.

And that’s perfected praise.

The key here is we must open ourselves up, eat the whole fruit, and allow it to nourish us spiritually. You see, perfected praise is ministry. So, just as the preacher prepares their mind, body, and spirit to preach, the same applies to the worshipper. The difference here is that the preacher is preparing to minister to the congregation, but the worshipper is preparing to minister to God.

I remember when my younger brother was growing up. His appetite for music was insatiable. I’ve never seen anything like it. He would wake up and begin practicing on the piano/keyboard. He would take breaks only when he had no choice. Then, he’d go right back to practicing. Sometimes, he would play for 8-10 hours each day. And he did it because that was his passion and desire. That’s what naturally came out of him: a need to improve his musical skills. No wonder he has “perfect pitch;” he can teach 5- & 6-part harmonies on the fly. He is continually sought after. Why? Because he worked his craft and honed his skills.

Compared to my brother, the 2-3 hours I would practice seemed like nothing. But everyone has their purpose, calling, and destiny. We should never compare ourselves to others because we don’t know what God intends for them versus what He plans for us. What is important is that we perfect what God has given us individually.

And, as we continue perfecting our gifts, the praise comes more naturally. So, Matthew 11:29-30 KJV says, "Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light."

In this example, the yoke is the praise, and the burden is the practice. When we begin this journey of perfected praise, it may seem impossible.

I remember when the worship completely sucked three Sundays in a row. The band was off. The singers sang the wrong words and parts. The people were disengaged. The pastor had to rescue the service again. But as you continue to fight past the distractions of everyday life, disappointments, and troubles and learn how to get into that place of praise, the praise (the yoke) becomes easy. The more you do it in your personal practice (the burden), the lighter it becomes. To create perfected praise corporately, we must perfect our praise individually.

Again, how can you take people to a place you don't go to?

Another thing must be addressed: when it comes to being a skillful worker, what exactly are we perfecting?

For the singers...

To be clear, praying, fasting, living a Godly life, and seeking the Kingdom have to be a given.

- Learn the music.

The singer's version of learning the music is knowing the words and your part. Missing either of these two can destroy the flow of worship.

- Spend time singing to God.

Occasionally, during worship service, a "River" of the Spirit's presence draws the congregation to sing to the Lord. People will sing things like, "Lord, you are good," "Lord, we worship You," and "We extol you, God." This is good, but our worship should be even more in-depth as lead worshippers. And we increase our depth in spiritual songs by singing to God privately.

Of course, you may need help to start. So, how about we sing His Word? There's an entire book of songs called Psalms. Sing your favorite scriptures. While studying the Word, sing what God reveals to you. The more you do this, the easier it becomes when the service calls for it.

- Make the songs personal.

Search each song as it relates to the Bible and apply your OWN testimony. There's nothing more BORING than hearing people sing the notes with no character or feeling. On the other side, there's nothing more disengaging than hearing someone run a vocal marathon throughout an entire song without any connection to what they're singing.

When we search out a song in the Bible, we connect that song to God. But we may need another song if we can't compare that song to the Word. So, what is the purpose of singing a song that doesn't connect with Yeshua?

After we've connected that song to Him, we need to apply our testimony to that song.

Our focus here is on the congregation. We are to lead the listener to the Father. So, how much we are engaged and connected or disengaged with and disconnected from a song, the listener will follow suit. Unfortunately, people focus on the negative or what's most like them. So, if I'm singing, "God, You Reign forever, and I worship you," and I'm disconnected from the song, the listener will often be detached from the music.

They are following your lead. And this doesn't just happen with solos. It happens with devotional and worship teams, quartets, and choirs.

By nature, people seek what's most like them. That's why it's so important to be engaged in the music and have a relationship with God. If everyone on stage is connected and engaged, then the people more naturally follow our lead.

For the musicians...

As with singers, your spirit man must be fed and strengthened daily. There's no excuse for anyone not praying, fasting, seeking Kingdom things, and living Godly.

- Learn the music.

Drummers, you should know not only the music's rhythms and the changes needed throughout the song (s), but you should also know and be able to control the tempo, or speed, of the song. Keyboardists naturally play songs differently than it's supposed to. So, the drummers keep the original rhythm locked down.

Keyboardists and guitarists should know the chords, progressions, and phrases within a song and the song in multiple keys. The reason is simple. What happens when the pastor requests a song that Sister Jane leads, but she is recovering from a cold and can't hit that high C? We, as musicians, need to adjust the song to accommodate the voices. Also, many songwriters write for specific groups or choirs. Some worship teams cannot perform all the vocal acrobatics or reach all the notes in a Hezekiah Walker song. So, we change the key to one that is comfortable for them.

- Practice in every key

If my 'favorite' key is C, I will practice in C whenever I sit down at the keyboard. But not every song is in the key of C. What happens when Bro. John sings in the key of G? I just heard a group of musicians say, "Just hit the transpose button!" No way. That's just lazy.

The better question is, what happens when you are forced to play the piano or an "old-school" Hammond organ? There is no transpose button and forcing people to sing in your

“comfort keys” is wrong. Plus, some people won’t move from the key they’re singing in. So, will you then blame the singer for not adjusting to your key? Or will you continue playing in the wrong key for the whole song? We need to practice in EVERY key; it’s as simple as that.

- Respect your instrument

This one should have been first. When you respect your instrument, you spend time with it. I can’t even number the times I’ve spoken with musicians who don’t practice. They will listen to the music once or twice. Then, try to perform that music on Sunday morning. Or worse, they spend the choir/worship team’s practice time learning the songs while the singers are supposed to be cleaning up their parts. It’s a travesty. Not only are you disrespecting your instrument and your craft, but you are also disrespecting the singers, the songwriter, the listeners, and ultimately, God. You’re putting your talent under a rock. And if you remember, the fellow who failed to grow and strengthen the gift he had been given was called a “wicked and slothful servant” (Jesus’ words, not mine).

- Know your role.

The role of the musician is to accompany the singer (s). I’m going to reveal a secret. Did you know that musicians have a more prominent voice than singers? Well, they do. That’s why we have microphones for the SINGERS. Their voices must be amplified to clarify the words and parts and lessen the strain on the singers’ voices. But microphones were NOT created so the voices could be heard over the music. If the voices are at 10, the music should be at 7. But all too often, the music is on 10 with the singers, and the musicians still ask for more volume because they “can’t hear themselves.” The answer is NOT louder music. It’s quite the opposite.

The answer is bringing the music down. The volume on your keyboard should never be all the way up while there are singers at the mic. Have we considered what happens to the listener during these volume battles on stage?

Therefore, during our practices, things like a soundcheck, communicating the levels on each song, and having a sound engineer present at practices are essential. Don’t forget; the Kingdom’s goal is for the message to be heard, and the music enhances the message, not drown it out.

Chapter 3: Pastoral Relationship

The first step in building the pastoral relationship is respect. Over the years, I have played with some of the most amazing pastors. Please note that I played “with” these pastors. I did not play “for” them.

As musicians, we must understand our role within the ministry. We indeed enhance the worship experience. We take charge of and create an atmosphere for the glory of God. And we certainly make going to church more enjoyable for the congregants. But our role is to accompany the pastor.

To accompany means to “go somewhere with (someone) as a companion or escort;” it also means to “be present or occur at the same time as (something else).”

My question is: How can you go somewhere with someone, and you don’t know where they’re going? To understand where pastors are going, you must spend time with them. First, you need to learn about who they are. Then you need to know their ministry goals and overall goals in life. Finally, you need to “date” your pastor (not literally, figuratively).

Once it’s determined where we’re going, we will know whether we are headed in the same direction. Let’s not forget that we are traveling together. If you’re going one way and the pastor is going another way, there will be problems. It is best to part ways when this happens, just as Abram and Lot did.

But all too often, we get wrapped up in the “business” of the church. When there’s a need, churches are posting positions, using social media to search for musicians, and even using referral services to look for candidates for these openings. Musicians then send in their resumes, credentials, referrals, etc. The church will then schedule interviews with the prospects, and the hiring process continues.

Don’t get me wrong; I don’t disagree with the process of weeding out folks. Some people just aren’t qualified to be salaried musicians. But where do we draw the line between being a hireling (John 10:12-13) and being a “laborer worthy of his hire” (1 Timothy 5:18)?

The difference between a hireling and a laborer is the expectation. Of course, the pastor respects the musicians and their gifts or talents in both cases. But there is a difference in the level of expectation that needs to focus beyond the skills and even more on the heart for the ministry the musician brings to the relationship.

I have known musicians who play for three or more services on Sunday mornings. While sitting on the organ in church number one, they watch the clock because they must leave by 8:15 a.m. to get to the next church service, which starts at 9:00 a.m. Once they reach church number two, they watch the clock because they must leave by 10:00 am for the next church service, which starts at 10:30 am. And the cycle goes on and on.

Some churches will even delay their service because the musician is running late from his other church. The only common denominator between these churches is that they pay this musician. If they didn’t pay him, then he wouldn’t come. But sad to say, the church knows that if they can’t pay him, for whatever reason, he won’t be there.

This hireling doesn’t care for the sheep, the ministry, the pastoral vision, or anything other than the money. And when everyone knows this, then expectations are established.

When the pastor and musician labor together, the expectations are different. Because they understand co-laboring, the pastor can ask that the musician not only come to rehearsals and services but also attend Bible study, where there is no music and no additional pay. The kicker is that the laborer will come and will not complain. Why? Because the musician

accompanies the pastor, the more time they spend together, the tighter the bond between them, and the further they can take the ministry.

Earlier, I stated that the pastor and musician should 'date' one another. Well, after dating comes the union. There's nothing more potent than a pastor and musician who walk together in unity.

I once played with a pastor for six months without discussing getting a salary or compensation. I came to services and rehearsals 15-30 minutes early every time. I started attending Bible study. And the pastor and I met weekly to discuss the direction of the music department and other ministry items. This was an actual labor of love.

During this time, the pastor chose all the music. This was different for me, but it was cool; that was one less thing I had to do (or so I thought).

What happened is I learned who my pastor was, what his expectations were, where I fit into the ministry, when I was needed in the various areas of ministry (not just music-related), how to respond and react to different scenarios, and why I, as an individual and not just a musician, should be a part of this ministry. As a result, he and I became friends. I would compare our relationship with Jonathan and David. There IS nothing that will come between the love that we have for each other.

Then, one day after a Sunday service, the church secretary called me into the office. She said the pastor wanted to ensure that I was taken care of, and she had a check for me. So, my commitment to the ministry was established long before I ever talked about or received any money.

Proverbs 18:16 (AMP) says, "A man's gift [given in love or courtesy] makes room for him and brings him before great men." We can miss out on the greater blessing by "charging" for our services. We miss out on the relationship and the covenant partnership.

That is what the pastoral relationship is about. It's a covenant. And we walk in agreement, speak the same thing, walk the same way, and move through ministry in lockstep. But, once that happens, we run into the power of this union and the experience of "delegated authority" from a Divine perspective. In the spirit realm, God delegated His authority to the pastor to speak on His behalf. The same holds true for the pastor and the lead worshipper. Pastors transfer their power to the lead worshipper to speak on their behalf, just as God gives the pastors His authority. Unfortunately, the problem with many churches is that this authority is too often mishandled, abused, and sometimes wielded like a child playing with his toys.

This covenant can be volatile because we don't truly understand what we're dealing with or the ramifications of the worship team and the individuals surrounding us.

The most powerful example of this bond can be seen between God and Lucifer. We can imagine God, as the Pastor, sets Lucifer up as Minister of Music. They worked very well

together for some time. Unfortunately, Lucifer got beside himself and felt he needed a bigger office than the Pastor. He felt everyone was coming to the service to hear him do his thing. He felt like the Pastor should retire so that he could take over the church. Why? Because he had a voice just like the Pastor did.

So, like many pastors have to do today, God had to fire his Minister of Music. I know He fired Lucifer because Luke 10:18 (AMP) says, "I watched Satan fall from heaven like [a flash of] lightning." God had to put him out. And just like today's churches, all those who followed the Minister of Music went with him. So, a third of the church fell when they followed the wrong leader.

We need to know our roles.

This point must be established during the initial phases of building the pastoral relationship. Then, as we become more intimate with our leader, we must understand and navigate these fixed boundaries. The church secretary gave one of the most influential pieces of advice. She said, "You need to know when you're dealing with the Bishop and when you're dealing with 'James' because they are two different people." And that is true.

As musicians, we can be cool. We can laugh and talk. We can even be friends. But don't ever get casual and treat God's gifts as "common." Ephesians 4:11 (NLT) says, "Now these are the gifts Christ gave to the church: the apostles, the prophets, the evangelists, and the pastors and teachers." When we get casual about the gifts, we devalue, diminish, and dilute the purpose of those gifts.

So, when we first started serving, the pastors could say nothing wrong. They were one of the most profound blessings God ever gave the church. They were the greatest!

But as time passes, we cannot help but see Noah in his nakedness. We may be there when Moses smites the rock instead of speaking to it as God wanted.

"Man, the pastor is just rambling again." "That's the same message that he preached last week." "Doesn't he have any fresh revelations?" "I can preach better than that." Sound familiar? It's the same thing Lucifer said when he was Minister of Music.

We are out of alignment with the pastor.

When we know our roles, the established boundaries within our pastoral-musician union become clear. As the musician, I am here to do a job: to lead the music department into a mindset of bringing God's glory to every event we're involved in. We are the Cherubim who carry the Glory of God. Since we know our role, we aren't offended when only the pastor is invited to a special dinner after service while we still need to break down the equipment. Even though I'm in the room with the pastor, I don't need to be "in" on every conversation. We understand that every word spoken behind closed doors is spoken in confidence. We don't "uncover" our leaders, leaving them exposed.

We are partners. We have our own identities, but we speak from the same script. We walk the same paths. Our destinies are intertwined. And most importantly, God is guiding us, both of us.

The most successful and impactful ministries have strong pastoral and lead worshipper relationships. God guides ministries through these single-minded pairs and groups.

Chapter 4: The Sound of the House

This chapter expresses the importance of attending Bible Class, a truth inspired by a lesson taught by my former pastor, Apostle Brian Keith Williams.

Before we can address the “Sound of the House,” we need to understand what “type” of a house that church is. It’s funny because I’ve gone into churches and felt like I stepped into a time warp. I walked in and was transported back into the 1960s. They had an organ and drums, but no one to play them. However, they had tambourines and a solid foot stomp.

And they had church!

Then, again, I’ve stepped into what we call Mega-Churches. They had closed-circuit televisions scattered throughout the building, the big screens hanging in the sanctuary. The band was filled with accomplished musicians, and the music was so tight that it sounded like a recording.

And they enjoyed the Lord.

In these two examples, the sound was incredibly different. But the spirit was the same. How can this be? It’s simple. The Spirit of God doesn’t change. He is the same wherever you go. The only difference is the presentation of God.

How we present God matters; because we, as people, are different. And when we genuinely break it down, every church falls into one of three categories: Priestly, Prophetic, or Apostolic.

Many would say they know their church is Apostolic because it’s written on the sign out front. Churches in this category are not affiliated with any particular doctrine. And many Apostolic churches flow in different styles. These types of churches are a significant subject on their own, But I’ll briefly talk about each one now.

The Priestly Church

This church flows from a perspective of Truth. The foundation is solidly based on tradition, the King James way, and the teaching speaks of where God was and what Jesus has done.

I grew up in a Priestly Church. We had services, or church events, 6-7 days a week. On Sundays, we arrived at 9:30 a.m. for Sunday School and wouldn’t leave until 9:00 p.m. because we had services scheduled throughout the entire day.

We were taught holiness or hell. The Word of God is the “end all—be all” of any matter. So, we don’t argue about the Word of God.

We devote our lives to studying the Word of God. And we live our lives according to the scripture.

The key here is that we focused on loving Jesus and being with God.

How does that affect the worship?

These churches are considered “old school.” There was always a printed program with the “Order of Service.” There was little deviation from that order. The song list will contain.... Wait, there were no song lists for the worship. There were plenty of choruses, hymns, and songs from yesteryear; they may have a choir or two, and they may still have a devotional service where the congregation randomly leads the songs.

The real focus of the worship is not worship itself. The actual center is on the Word and what comes after the worship. Therefore, congregational involvement during worship was expected but not encouraged.

We went from one song to the next. Unless God “took over.”

As I stated earlier, I grew up in this type of church. I don’t know where I would be had it not been for the teaching at this church. We all need a foundation.

The Prophetic Church

This church flows in the Spirit of Truth. The approach is progressive. King James is the fallback, but you’re more likely to see NIV, NLT, or even the Message bible being used. The teaching speaks of where God is.

I played with a Prophetic Church. This ministry moved in the revelation of God’s Word. It’s one thing to know God’s Word, but another to see how it applies to your life today. The same scripture that has been read over and over now has a new understanding. The Word became a living and breathing part of my life.

The key here is to focus on hearing Jesus and moving with God.

How does that affect the worship?

There is more preparation for worship. There is a printed program, but the “service is subject to change.” There is a worship team that is dedicated to worship, not only in singing but in prayer and fasting. Worship isn’t just a steppingstone to God’s spoken Word. The song list will include Top 40 music from several genres (Gospel, CCM, etc.). Congregational involvement is encouraged but not expected.

The proper focus here is setting the atmosphere or preparing the way for the Lord. It's not uncommon for the worship service to go long, and the placement/timing of the sermon change because of the atmosphere that has been set.

We pause between songs to allow the message to simmer.

I loved being in this environment. Of course, there is always a plan, but you must be on your toes.

The Apostolic Church

This church flows in Spirit and Truth. The approach is restorative. King James is used, but so is the Amplified. The teaching is about where God will be.

As members of an Apostolic Church, we move in the revelation of God's Word and the declaration of things to come. We don't just speak of where Jesus was and where He is, but we walk in the authority of God and declare the next step— "in the name of Jesus Christ, rise up and walk!"

We move into the "I AM." "I am the head and not the tail." "I am more than a conqueror," "I may be going thru the valley, but I am healed."

The key here is to focus on being like Jesus and governing with God. The stance is positional instead of conditional, sitting at the right hand of the Father, not simply focusing on our current situation.

I must be honest; as I started this section, I felt a quickening in my spirit. I could preach this. But I'll refrain. I must pause for a 'praise break.'

Ok... I'm back.

How does this affect the worship?

Simple. It becomes relational. Worship is a part of the Word. They are no longer separate parts of worship. To prepare for the worship, the preacher and the praiser fast, pray, and communicate with each other. The song list may include full hymns, i.e., all the verses, top 40 from multiple genres, songs from yesteryear, and spontaneous worship songs of the Lord. The service is focused on one message, one central truth, and the printed program is apt to be discarded.

We may arrive for the service, and the order is changed entirely. Instead of beginning the service in worship and ending with the Word, the Word may come first. The worship may be so engulfed in the Spirit of God that the preacher may join the worship and end the worship with an altar appeal.

Spontaneous worship is liable to break out at any moment.

I love this environment because it's always charged. An unmistakable feeling of unity allows more freedom for the Spirit of God.

So, why go through all these diverse types of churches when this chapter is called "The Sound of the House?"

Everyone has a sound that they align with spiritually. God has blessed me to experience these different churches, glean from them, and share with you the differences. But when it came to the church I felt aligned with, there was a leap in my spirit.

The problem is that musicians often don't follow the leading of the Lord when selecting a church to play with. Instead, they are playing for a church to get paid. But what happens to your soul, your ministry, and your calling?

The reason that I established the types of churches is so that you could relate to the church that you align with. The size of the church is immaterial. I've played at churches with less than 20 people and churches with over 10,000 people. It honestly doesn't matter how many people are in the congregation. I want you to be where God wants you.

Proverbs 18:16 says that your gift will make room for you. When you are correctly connected, you'll get paid. God will take care of you in ways that seem impossible.

Musically, each house has a requirement that needs to be met. Luke 12:48 AMP says, "From everyone to whom much has been given, much will be required; and to whom they entrusted much, of him they will ask all the more." How does this apply musically?

I've been to churches where the pastor and the congregation were okay with the musician playing every song in the key of C. Every chord progression was the same. All the runs were the same. They were even performed at the same volume.

The music selection was the same music from when granddaddy was the pastor. Nothing has changed.

You're in a Priestly house. The requirement is smaller. So, the expectations and the work match the demand. And so does the pay. I know a young man who plays for a church and is excited about the \$50 they give him every Sunday. He is in the right place. His sound matches the sound of the house.

I was at a church once, and the pastor asked me to study Benny Hinn's music. He then gave me a Benny Hinn Ministries (BHM) compilation of 3 or 4 CDs. And, quite honestly, it was hard!

That music was not appealing to me. I listened and listened. I spent hours, days, and weeks absorbing this music. Then, I began to understand something.

I see the patterns in the flow of the music. I saw why Benny Hinn has such an anointing for healing and restoration. He found the path and tapped into something we weren't doing in

our services. And my pastor, being a true Apostolic, wanted our worship to tap in. This new expectation required that I do more work and do work that I didn't like.

But it worked. Our worship excelled by applying what I had learned by listening to music I didn't care for. How many would have received those CDs and politely never listened to them?

Our level of work ethic will help to determine what type of church is the right fit for us. For example, if you're comfortable learning three new songs a month, you may be comfortable in a Prophetic church.

As musicians and worshippers, we must keep our ears open and attentive to what God has for the house, whatever your house may be.

You learn what is in the church by observing. Whenever I've started playing with a new house, I refrain from making song list suggestions for the first 3–6 months of my tenure. Instead, I receive recommendations from the pastor and the worship team. This way, I am learning what 'type' of pastor and 'type' of worshippers are in the house. During service, I observe the 'type' of congregation in the house. And you really can't make judgments until after at least three months.

Once we understand that the sound of the house reflects the type of house and the type of pastor, we can know if we are a good fit for this house long term.

Now that we've discussed the sound of the house, let's talk about the various methods used for establishing that sound.

Chapter 5: Tabernacle Worship

The tabernacle, or tent of meeting, was the dwelling place of the Spirit of God. God meticulously described how it was built, its décor, how things were to be managed, the preparation before entering, and so much more.

So, my question is, if God was so purposeful regarding His dwelling place, why aren't we just as persistent when we desire His presence?

All too often, worshippers come to service without a worship clue. There is an expectation of God's presence, but there has been no preparation. No prayer, no fasting, no seeking God, and unfortunately... NO SONGS.

And we've all been there. Unfortunately, this week was busy, and I didn't have much time. But as I drove to service this morning, these songs "dropped in my spirit."

So, everyone gets in the "pre-service huddle" around someone's smartphone, scratchpad, sticky note, or back of an offering envelope, and this is what we're singing today.

The problem is that only a few often know the music, including the musicians. The rhythm is incorrect. The key is too high or too low. Oh, and let's not forget the words! But God is expected to show up and show out.

God doesn't dwell in confusion, which is why many churches experience a 'visitation' so infrequently.

Worship is a lifestyle. In 1 Chronicles 25:7 (NET), we find an important reference to the worship musicians: "They and their relatives, all of them skilled and trained to make music to the LORD." Not only was the worshipper trained and skillful, but so was their family. They lived their music!

So, we must follow suit. We must bring our best before the Lord.

One of the most effective methods for building the Worship Song List is what I call Tabernacle Worship.

Three defined parts of the Tabernacle (Outer Court, Inner Court, and Holy of Holies) make Tabernacle Worship.

* * *

Outer Court

Most people aren't prepared for the worship experience when the worship service begins. So, as worship leaders, it is our responsibility to help draw the people in and guide them into the presence of God.

In the Outer Court, this is where we sing songs directed to the people.

Songs like "Come on and bless the Lord with me," "Let It Rise," and "Friend of God" are all directed at the person in the pew.

These songs also help people to become more involved in worship and get them out of their seats.

We, as worship leaders, must never forget to include the congregants in the worship. Worship isn't a spectator sport. We must consciously do certain things, like singing songs that include our audience and asking them to stand. Keyword: ASK.

Be mindful not to become agitated when the audience isn't doing what you expect. Yelling at the people to stand to their feet or to sing with you isn't engaging. The people aren't robots, and it takes time for them to unload their stuff. So, walk in patience and wisdom.

One other thing about the Outer Court is simplicity and repetition.

Notice in the song examples above there are very few words, and those few words are repeated a lot. This is particularly important. It's easier for me to sing with you and unload my stuff when I don't have to read the screens.

One quick note.

What does it mean to "unload your stuff?" If we want people to be engaged in what we're doing, we must help them shift their focus. Unfortunately, focusing on worship is tough when the average person has a thousand other things on their mind. We all deal with struggles from one service to the next. Things happen on the job, at home, and sometimes, in the car on the way to service. As worshippers, we must help people "unload their stuff" and shift their focus to worshipping our Great and Mighty God.

So, keeping the Outer Court songs lively, simple, and repetitive helps to move the congregant from listener or watcher to active participant. Remember, the worshipper's focus in the Outer Court is on the people.

Inner Court

Now that we've helped the congregants unload their stuff, it's time to enter the Inner Court. This is where we sing songs that are about God.

Songs like "He Is Lord," "How Great Is Our God," and "Shout to the Lord" are still conversational with the congregant, but the subject is no longer about the person. We are now describing God's attributes.

The Inner Court music needs to reflect the focus of Matthew 6:9, which says, "...Our Father, who is in heaven." That is the beginning of the prayer. Well, this is the same place worship needs to begin.

So, just as described in the Lord's Prayer, we start the actual worship by talking about God: who He is, what He is like, how great He is, how marvelous He is, etc.

The Inner Court is transitional. We are transitioning our minds from us and the stuff of this life and this world to begin focusing on God and heavenly reality. This transition isn't always smooth because we're accustomed to talking about ourselves and our stuff. It isn't natural for us to focus on someone other than ourselves.

We recently went out to eat with some friends. Unfortunately, the service at the restaurant was terrible. When we brought the service to management's attention, the manager began discussing their lousy service experiences. This is relevant because we do the same regarding God and His service. This is a real example of how misdirected and self-focused our attention can be.

This is also why keeping the music "tight" in the Inner Court is imperative. Tight in this respect means to keep it Godward. It's way too easy to internalize songs that speak of His attributes and mentally apply them to someone other than God. This is especially evident

when it comes to Godly love. His love is undeniable, unforgettable, and unending. But when you start thinking of your girlfriend, spouse, or someone else, you are tainting the music.

During the transition into the Inner Court, musicians stick to the script. Just because the melody from Fantasy by Earth, Wind, and Fire “fits” into that song does not mean it’s acceptable to play it.

I’ve been in services where the transition was being made into the Inner Court, and God was entering the building. The congregation was fully participating in the worship. The worship team was on one accord, and the spirit was flowing. Then, the musicians started playing “I Wish” by Carl Thomas at the center of this move.

The problem with playing secular music during worship isn’t that the music is worldly. The problem is that the music is “familiar.” The music no longer accompanies the worship but is now distracting because the listener is trying to figure out where they’ve heard that melody.

People also have memories associated with music. For example, playing “You Make Me Wanna” by Usher or “Flashlight” by Parliament during service can transport people back to a particular moment or season in their lives that can remove them mentally from the service entirely. And, once a person has disconnected from the service, there’s no telling if they will reconnect and be able to receive what they need from God.

Relative to time, this portion of the worship should be more significant than the Outer Court portion. Remember, it’s about transitioning our attention from ourselves to God. The Outer Court experience includes everything from the moment service begins until we move into the Inner Court of worship. So, the Outer Court is more preparatory in its structure, including scripture reading and opening prayer, whereas the Inner Court is more purposeful and transitional.

Holy of Holies

Now that we’ve transitioned from the Outer Court to the Inner Court, it’s time to shift our focus from singing about God to singing songs to God.

Songs like “Give Me You,” performed by Shana Wilson, “What a Beautiful Name,” performed by Hillsong Worship, and “Trust in You” by Anthony Brown are directed to God.

This section of the worship is much more intimate. Where the Outer Court is preparatory, the Inner Court is more purposeful in its transitory state. The Holy of Holies is personal and relational.

It’s easy to sing to each other about God, but it’s a different story when we peel back the layers and reveal our relationship with our Lord, Savior, and Creator. So, you see, this is the Love section.

We tell HIM how much we love Him, how we feel about Him, what we think about Him, and what we will do for Him. It’s ALL directed to Him and how He influences us.

Keep the journey in mind, and don't blow it.

One of the most significant errors in this section is shifting the focus away from God because of the nature of the songs. It is easy to slip into sensuality and carnality in our minds during worship. This shift away from God shifts the entire worship, and once the worship ends, the service is no higher than when we started in the Outer Court.

I've seen singers and musicians focus on that cutie on the second row and sing about letting 'the rivers of my worship flow to you.' Or sing about taking me 'to that secret place, where I can be with You,' and the real message of "Wrap Me in Your Arms" is lost in the singer's delivery and sometimes even sensual motions.

When effectively done, Tabernacle Worship strips down the listener by helping them get rid of all their stuff, let down their guards, and open their hearts to receive from God. But when we take advantage of the listener's vulnerabilities, we are not only doing a disservice to them but acting on the same level as Lucifer. We are taking what belongs to God and using it for our own glory and benefit. And that's what happens whenever we do things to shift the listener's focus to us instead of to God.

Psalm 22:3 KJV says, "But thou art holy, O thou that inhabitest the praises of Israel." The purpose of the Holy of Holies section of Tabernacle Worship is to present the praises to God because He inhabits our praise! So, as we shine the light on our Father in heaven and worship Him, He is bound by His Word to show up!

Chapter 6: Thematic Worship - Echoes of the House

In 1 Corinthians 14:33 (MSG), the apostle tells us, "When we worship the right way, God doesn't stir us up into confusion; he brings us into harmony. This goes for all the churches - no exceptions."

This is the most appropriate scripture for Thematic Worship that I could find. Simply stated, "God doesn't dwell in confusion," and when the worship and the Word are saying different things, a genuine visitation from God can be hindered.

The premise behind Thematic Worship is to echo the messages taught in the house, which involves coordinating the pastor and the worship leader. This is especially powerful when there is a series being given.

Let's say that the series will be about the Love of God. Therefore, the music selected for the worship will have a particular and purposeful message that speaks to God's Love. i.e., "Oh How He Loves You and Me," "No Greater Love," and "Glorious Day (Living He Loved Me)."

The second part is to continue this theme after the spoken Word has ended. So, during the altar appeal or dismissal, continue worshipping with songs directly related to the last part of the message, i.e., the pastor is ending the word with a theme of "flowing in the spirit, so songs like "Let the River Flow," "Fresh Flow from Heaven," or "Flow to You" would all be appropriate to continue that message in song.

The entire service is now saturated with one message or theme, instead of the worship service going down one road and the pastor going down another. So, when the congregation leaves, they most likely remember what was taught. And that is the crucial part.

When the worship sets the atmosphere in a single theme, the pastor continues in that same theme; the ground of our hearts doesn't have to be re-tilled. The worship breaks the soil and plants the seed. The pastor then fertilizes and waters that seed. When the altar appeal is made, and the theme is continued further, then that seed has no choice but to SPROUT. Result: changed lives!

But again, the tricky part of Thematic Worship is the coordination between the pastor and the worship leader. This works better with ministry leaders who plan out the messages in advance. If the pastor is more 'random' in delivering the messages, then this method of worship is not the best for your service regularly. Plan to use this method during consistent times of the year, like conferences, special ceremonies, and holidays, where the theme is established and less likely to change.

Chapter 7: Collaborative Worship - The Heart of the Lead Worshippers

Psalms 34:3 KJV says, "O magnify the Lord with me, and let us exalt his name together."

One of the worst places to be, especially in worship, is alone and out on an island. As lead worshippers, sometimes we aren't connected to God. Life is happening to us: family, work, school, and many other distractions. We don't have time to pray. We haven't listened to any music. Everything comes simultaneously, and the songs must be selected for service. So, what do we do?

For many years, I would look over our current music library and pick a few songs. Two things would happen when I did this.

1. I always seemed to lean towards songs that spoke to my issues and made me feel better about what I was dealing with. Or...
2. I was merely out of sync with where God indeed was. As a result, I ended up having abusive practices, lots of agitation amongst the worshippers, and the worship service bombed.

Missing the move of God is a travesty.

Missing God during worship to God is an even greater disaster because this is the time of service dedicated to Him.

Then enters Collaborative Worship.

The premise behind this type of worship is to include the rest of the lead worshippers in the song selection process. So, instead of scanning the song library for songs that jump out at me, I ask the other lead worshippers, "What song (s) has God placed in your spirit this

week?” “What have you been singing in your prayer time?” or “What scriptures has God been giving you this week?”

Some of the most powerful worship services I’ve ever experienced have used Collaborative Worship. Why?

We must never forget that the worship team, or choir, is a sampling of the congregation. The same things the ‘people’ are experiencing are the same things that the worshippers are experiencing. The difference is that the worshippers should be in a better position to receive direction from God and share what He is saying.

The crazy thing is that when the people are indeed on one accord, you will see an overlap in the submitted songs, and an overwhelming theme will rise out of those songs.

For instance, after having a very trying week, the songs that I wanted to sing were “Overcome” by Jeremy Camp, the chorus “Greater is He that liveth in me,” and “How Great is Our God” by Chris Tomlin. So, my focus would be on God’s power and defeating the enemy. This is not a bad lineup. But the suggested songs from the lead worshippers were... “Welcome into This Place” by Bruce Ballinger, “Fill Me Up” by Will Reagan, and “I Give Myself Away” by William McDowell. The music focused on God coming in and filling our hearts. Then we are being used by Him, which is ENTIRELY different from where I was coming from.

The only ‘trick’ to using Collaborative Worship is where the suggestions are coming from and the order of the songs.

When my worship teams have been over ten people, I’ve only asked for suggestions from the lead worshippers and select band members. Very rarely have I asked for suggestions from the entire worship team. The Bible tells us in 1 Thessalonians 5:12 (KJV) to “...know them which labour among you.” So, we know who is spending time with God and who may be struggling like you are that week.

Setting the order of the songs can be a trial because the right music at the wrong moment can shift the service in the wrong direction. So, I will combine the previous worship methods, i.e., Tabernacle Worship or Thematic Worship. I’ll present the songs to the pastor and ask them what order to offer the worship.

Chapter 8: The Flow - Heart of God

One genuinely helpful way of presenting the worship set is to allow God to flow through the music. This may sound like a simple statement, but unfortunately, many of us have let the clock determine the flow instead of God.

What I mean is that we, in today’s generation, expect that everything that we experience needs to happen quickly. We live life fast and, in a hurry, so we bring that same mentality into the worship service.

I'm guilty of not wanting to spend 4-6 hours in service. So, I petitioned the pastor to shorten the worship service from 45 to 30 minutes. His response was classic: he was looking for ways to extend the worship to a full hour!

But how many churches have the clock hanging on the back wall, sitting on the first row, or even positioned underneath the podium? Why is this clock there? It reminds those in leadership that we must be out of service at a particular time. So, don't go over your allotted time.

Before going further, let me define what the 'flow' is.

When entering the 'flow' or 'spontaneous worship,' we allow the song we just sang a moment to "simmer." We often rush from one song to the next without letting the message in each song settle in the listener's heart. Instead, we abruptly switch from one message to another. We're yanking the listeners from one movement and stuffing a new move down their spiritual throats without providing time for them to digest anything.

So, the flow is that space between the songs where there is only music, a time to allow the voice of the Lord to speak through the lead worshippers or just the flow of the music itself. Many call this "spontaneous worship" because it is not practiced or prepared. Instead, it's a shadow of the previous song (meaning that the music may be a continuation of the song). The message is usually a word of knowledge or a prophetic word for the listeners through song.

Transitioning into the flow can be challenging when worshippers aren't accustomed to it. The reason is that many singers think that if the music is still playing, then they're supposed to keep singing. However, with training, this can easily be overcome.

The flow itself is birthed out of the worshippers' relationship with God. When the lead worshippers are praying, studying their Bible, and spending time in the presence of God (outside of the worship service), that time spent will flow out of their spirit, bringing to life Ephesians 5:19 (NIV), "speaking to one another with psalms, hymns, and songs from the Spirit. Sing and make music from your heart to the Lord,"

One word of warning. The flow, or spontaneous worship, is not an opportunity for preaching worshippers to have a "mini-sermon" and take a text. God may move the worshippers to minister, but it will be in order. Remember that the role of the worshipper is the same as that of the cherubim who carries the Glory of the Lord. They go where the spirit says. Period!

Chapter 9: Practicing His Presence

As a recap, we have discussed being a skilled worker, an individual, and having a good work ethic. We talked about the importance of the worshipper/pastoral relationship and the sounds of the house. Finally, we briefly looked into a few different methods of worship.

Authoring this book has challenged me in every area I've discussed.

One important thing about all these areas is how vital they are to worship leaders individually. But even more essential is the unity of doing these things corporately.

Unless you are a one-man band with no accompanying instruments or singers, you will fall short of consistently attaining your objective of entering the Glory of God.

And that leads us into the next part of worship: practicing His presence.

One definition of a rehearsal is a “trial performance of a play or other work for later public performance.” The key here is the first two words: trial performance. We often call this a practice session, meaning an “actual application or use of an idea, belief, or method as opposed to theories about such application or use.”

However, the difference between rehearsing and practicing is a performance mindset versus an application mentality. As worship leaders, we have the stage. We have the mic. We have the attention of the audience. And we have been given a substantial chunk of time in the service. But if we are not careful, we can turn from worshippers into performers, and that’s not God’s intention for us as Lead Worshipers. Why? Because quite honestly, when we become performers, the attention is no longer on God. It’s on us.

As individuals within the worship experience, when we have handled our business up front, sought God in prayer and fasting, learned our music, learned our parts, learned the words, etc., all that is necessary is the corporate application of all that we’ve learned.

Ezekiel 1:9 KJV says, “Their wings were joined one to another; they turned not when they went; they went every one straight forward.”

The purpose of practice is applying the methods we’ve discussed throughout this manual and not just reading about them, not just saying that we have a good idea, but putting those ideas in motion. For example, James 2:17 (MSG) says, “Isn’t it obvious that God-talk without God-acts is outrageous nonsense?”

So, practicing His presence as a worship team is just that, taking time out of our busy schedules and devoting that time as a corporate body of worshippers to get into the presence of the Almighty while presenting Him with our gifts of worship in song. When we do that sincerely, God will show up. This now gives us a different expectation regarding leading the congregation into His presence because we’ve already been there together.

It’s like getting in your car and going to the grocery store. Once you’ve gone there, it’s easier to go there repeatedly. Then, when you need to take someone else there, you can show them the way to go because you’ve been where you’re taking them.

I can’t take you into a place of Glory if I’ve never been there. I, the lead worshiper, must find my way into that place. Then, I need to go there over and over. After that, the worship team and I will go there repeatedly. Now, we can lead the church into a place that we have been, and the cycle continues.

But it starts at home in my quiet, secret place.

I must establish an atmosphere of Glory in my house. You must Establish Glory in your home. Then we come together and set the atmosphere of Glory in the church during practice... Then, when it's time for service, we'll have no problem leading God's people into His Presence.

Chapter 10: The Next Level of Praise and Worship... The Glory

Earlier, I mentioned Benny Hinn and how his worship music changed my life when I realized how he found that path to Glory and has tapped in. The music itself may not always excite my flesh at all. We often go into services with the mindset of having a "good time." So, we sing three fast and two slow songs, then call that worship. Whether or not we say it out loud, we expect to see the people "get with us," lift their hands at the right moment, and even "shout."

For all of those who believe that this is it, I apologize. The Glory is not a physical experience. The Glory is not, "We had a good service today." The Glory is not, "We danced so hard that there was no preaching."

So, what is the Glory?

According to Wikipedia, "Glory" is one of the most frequently used words in scripture. In the Old Testament, the word is used to translate several Hebrew words, including Hod (הוד) and kabod; and in the New Testament, it is used to translate the Greek word doxa (δόξα). The Hebrew word kabod (K-B-D) originally means "weight" or "heaviness." The same word is used to express importance, honor, and majesty. Greek versions of the Hebrew Bible translated this concept with the word δόξα, which was then used extensively in the New Testament as well. Doxa originally meant "judgment, opinion," and by extension, "good reputation, honor."

Wikipedia, Webster's, and Google say a lot, but in short, the Glory is the presence of God as real as anything tangible.

The exciting part is that conditions need to be met for God to show Himself to us.

First, we must come prepared with our sacrificial offerings. Leviticus 9 talks about how Moses called Aaron, his sons, and the elders, and he commanded them to bring various offerings to sacrifice before the Lord. Leviticus 9:6 says, "And Moses said, This is the thing which the Lord commanded that ye should do: and the glory of the Lord shall appear unto you."

Today, we no longer sacrifice calves, rams, lambs, and bulls. Instead, we surrender ourselves as living sacrifices.

Romans 12:1-2 (AMP) says it best:

Therefore I urge you, brothers and sisters, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies [dedicating all of yourselves, set apart] as a living sacrifice, holy and well-pleasing to God, which is your rational (logical, intelligent) act of worship. And do not be conformed to this world [any longer with its superficial values and customs], but be]transformed and progressively changed [as you mature spiritually] by the renewing of your mind [focusing on godly values and ethical attitudes], so that you may prove [for yourselves] what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect [in His plan and purpose for you].”

Several parts of that scripture jump out at me. But I’ll only briefly address two.

First, “as a living sacrifice, holy and well-pleasing to God, which is”—are you ready? Here it comes— “your rational, logical, intelligent act of worship.” When we truly recognize who God is, it just makes sense that we should worship Him. It doesn’t take a brain surgeon to understand this. So, here’s a worship exercise I love that shows the greatness of God.

Sometimes, worship leaders will ask the congregation to think about one thing God has done for them and begin to worship Him for that one thing. We often see the congregation with glazed eyes, staring at the ceiling, looking for that significant thing God has done. The problem is that everyone assumes they must have something powerful in mind, life-altering, or a most unusual event.

What God showed me was to make worship simpler. We’re always looking for that last, most fabulous thing He has done. But what about the little things? Do we worship Him for each breath that we take? So, let’s say, “Thank you, Lord, for the breath I just took.” Now, you must say thank you again because you had to take another breath to say, “thank you.” But when you say thank you for the third time, guess what? You just took another breath and are mandated by this exercise to thank Him again because you just took another breath. And this exercise is unending because you can never run out of reasons to thank God. Every time we give Him the fruit of our lips, He’s given us another reason to worship Him...

Secondly, “...that, you may prove for yourselves what the will of God is....” How often have we worshiped with our stuff weighing on our hearts and minds? We pray and ask God to do this or that, take this away, give me that, handle this situation, change that person, move this mountain, but there’s a song that says, “Give me you. Everything else can wait.” If God’s will be that we “prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospers” (3 John 1:2,) why would we think He’s not already fully aware of our issues? The key to success in the Kingdom is to handle His business, and He will handle ours. He’s already given us the keys, but we need to prove that these keys unlock the door.

After we bring our sacrificial offerings, we must lay them at the altar. Leviticus 9:7 (MSG) says, “Approach the Altar and sacrifice...” your offerings. One part is going to the physical altar and casting your cares. All too often, we bring our sacrifices to the church, but we don’t release them. Instead, we allow our concerns, issues, and problems to lead and guide us. In 1 Peter 5:7 TLB, we read, “Let him have all your worries and cares, for he is always thinking about you and watching everything that concerns you.”

The other part is the altar of your heart, where the actual participation in the worship service itself comes into play. John 4:24 says, "God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth." "In spirit" is from the heart. "In truth" is in Jesus (John 14:6, "I am the way, the truth..."). So, when we worship him in spirit and truth, in our hearts offering praise and honor, God sees His own reflection as the center of our lives. But to do that, we must participate in worship.

Participation isn't like the Blues Brothers, where the service is going on, and there's a light from heaven. Then, suddenly, they're doing cartwheels, flips, and spins down the aisle. Instead, participation is being engaged in worship. Sing, clap your hands, and even stand sometimes. Take in the entire worship experience. Allow the words of the songs to penetrate your heart and mind. Let the melodies resonate in your spirit. Don't fight it.

We've brought our sacrificial offerings and placed them on the altar. Now, we should expect that God will come, and we wait. Each time that Moses gave a command, in Leviticus 9, he ended that command with a promise: Lev 9:4 (KJV), "...for today the Lord will appear unto you." and Lev 9:6 (KJV), "...the glory of the Lord shall appear unto you." When we follow the process, a promise is fulfilled in the end.

Luke 24:49 (KJV) says, "And, behold, I send the promise of my Father upon you: but tarry ye in the city of Jerusalem, until ye be endued with power from on high." Jesus set their expectations. All they had to do was go there and wait.

Acts 2:1-3 (KJV), "And when the day of Pentecost was fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. And suddenly there came a sound from heaven as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled all the house where they were sitting. And there appeared to them cloven tongues like fire, and it sat upon each of them."

What makes this scripture pop is two words... one accord. Establishing Glory isn't just for the individual. The power comes in agreement and unity. Matthew 18:20 says, "For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them." When we share the Good News, we create an atmosphere of expectancy; this atmosphere is charged even higher when we raise our voices in unity, worshipping the Almighty God, the King of Kings, the Lord of Lords. We worship, watch, and wait together, expecting to receive power from on high.

This is what happens when a well-known evangelist comes to town. Believers come together from far and wide to be in the service. The environment is electrical. There's tension in the air. People are seeking a move of God, and they are waiting to see what's going to happen. The crazy part is that everyone in attendance is waiting for the same thing. They are seeking the same thing. So, it's only a matter of time before what they expect from God will come to pass.

Ezekiel 10:4: "Then the glory of the LORD went up from the cherub, and stood over the threshold of the house, and the house was filled with the cloud, and the court was full of the brightness of the LORD'S glory."

Acknowledgments

I want to thank God for giving me this vision in writing. I pray every reader will be blessed tremendously. I'd also like to thank all the pastors, worship teams/choirs, and churches that endured the journey with me and helped me grow naturally, spiritually, and musically. I want to thank my friends and family for encouraging me to pursue what God has for me. Finally, I'd like to thank my wife for the prayers and understanding that God has put a fire in me that can only be subdued by long hours of praying, playing, and writing.

My love to you all!!

Establishing Glory 2

The Relationship Handbook

Preface

The purpose of this book is to provide balance. I grew up as a young man in the 1970s in the United States, specifically in Ohio, in a two-parent home and a church. I've learned that people yearn for relationships, yet nobody, especially the church, addresses what that means.

The church taught us we couldn't love one another successfully until we learned to love God. To this, I wholeheartedly agree. However, can anyone tell me how to love God? What does it mean to be in a relationship with Him? How does divine love and relationship translate to being in a relationship with a woman?

For years, I was confounded by that analogy. When I see an attractive woman in yoga pants, my thoughts aren't on God but on how to get closer to her.

Oh, wait—I forgot to mention something. If you have read my first book, "Establishing Glory: The Praise and Worship Handbook," understand that this book is not an extension of that.

One issue today is the refusal to be authentic in our lives. We have been coaxed into adopting an approach marked by political correctness, reticent grace, and accepting "that's just how the world is" philosophies.

As stated in the first line of this book, the aim is to provide balance.

The unsettling reality is that when we go to church, we don't hear about relationships, sex, and sexuality until a high-profile televangelist is caught cheating, someone is accused of molestation, or we notice openly gay individuals participating in the choir or band.

My question is, why?

If sex and sexuality are among the most pressing challenges that people—not just the church—face, then why isn't the church more consistent in its message and stance on these subjects?

It's easy to criticize Bishop Eddie L. Long for his history of child molestation, sexual misconduct, and homosexuality. However, similar issues are rampant worldwide in the Catholic Church! Who is consistently teaching us that this is the wrong path? Who is sounding the alarm that God is displeased? Who is discussing these issues with our children?

If we can't have an open dialogue about relationships, sex, and sexuality among adults, how can we extend this conversation to the next generation? We aren't having these conversations with our children.

Our children are learning from our silence and YouTube videos. They converse about these topics while playing video games and are influenced by a curriculum that promotes alternative lifestyles, all while we remain silent for fear of offending.

So where is the balance?

In the past, we had church mothers and deacons who, in their own way, taught us to be men and women of standard, unashamed of it. Time has passed, and those mentors are gone. We are the ones who need to uphold those standards and guide the next generation, yet we are losing them because we're too focused on imitating their lifestyle.

That's why I'm writing this book.

If you're easily offended by real talk, I apologize in advance.

Chapter 1: Single and Satisfied

"You complete me." "My better half." These are phrases that imply imperfection, insufficiency, and, quite honestly, defectiveness.

To discuss relationships with others, we first must explore the relationship with ourselves. Understanding who you are encompasses your desires, needs, ambitions, drive, triggers, and what you dislike, don't need, or don't want.

Relationships become complex because we create ever-changing rules. The goalposts keep shifting.

In my youth, I had an insatiable thirst for life. I loved simply doing something—anything. As a church-going kid, I attended most services and had a rich social life outside the church. I loved God, and I cherished the diversity of His creation.

I found a balance in my life early on. While I did date, I was a late bloomer by today's standards, becoming sexually active around the ages of sixteen or seventeen. So, spending time with friends didn't imply sexual activity, though it happened occasionally.

My focus was on life itself—free from the constraints of dating, relationships, or societal rules.

Then came the United States Air Force. I was slated for deployment to Desert Storm but got injured during Security Police training. I ended up at Yokota Air Base in Tokyo, Japan, for over two years, where I had a myriad of experiences that shook my world.

Imagine a twenty-one-year-old, reasonably handsome churchgoer dropped in the middle of the “Land of the Rising Sun.” When I received my orders, my mother, an open-minded individual, warned me against bringing home a Japanese woman. Her comment shook me to my core.

In Japan, my focus initially remained on work, church, and maintaining relationships with African American women. However, the latter became increasingly challenging, as many had reservations because of the behaviors of other servicemen.

Navigating this complex social landscape, I engaged in short-term relationships with Japanese nationals. Interestingly, these relationships were mutually understood to be temporary, keeping things straightforward.

But sex doesn’t equate to happiness. Eventually, even in Japan, I craved solitude over the company of multiple women. I found solace in being single and content with my own being, free from external validation.

One of the most significant challenges people face is internal—self-esteem, self-confidence, and self-validation. If you’re struggling with yourself, how can you be a fulfilling partner to someone else? As my pastor used to say, “It’s a poor frog that won’t croak in his own pond.”

To genuinely embrace singlehood, we must first be content and satisfied with ourselves. What obstacles are you facing that prevent you from being genuinely single and satisfied? And what needs to happen for you to overcome those obstacles?

Chapter 2: Who Are You

One of the most complicated questions to answer concerns identity. All too often, we succumb to generalizations, categorizations, and classifications based on gender, age, ethnicity, religion, socioeconomics, creed, and color. But none of this can genuinely answer the fundamental question: Who are you?

I am an African American, middle-class man in my late forties living in the Midwest. I work every day at a Fortune 100 company, live in a decent home, pay bills and taxes, attend church every week, and consider myself a good and kind person.

These attributes describe aspects of who I am, but they don’t answer the question. Who you are isn’t determined by what you have; it’s defined by how you think. The Bible says in Proverbs 23:7 (NKJV), “For as he thinks in his heart, so is he.”

The items on the list help to describe how I think, but those are merely things. In relationships, I must genuinely know who I am to be the best me I can be. Once I'm in touch with who I am, I can accommodate you.

A common issue is that women are with you, but aim to mold you into someone else, their ideal man. This is evident when women talk about how they will change their men. It tells me that his identity isn't set. Soft clay is pliable; once hardened, it can only be broken.

This divergence leads to conflict. She wants one thing, but he's not that. She's trying to "break" him. Men often say, "She's just tripping." No, bro; she's trying to break a wild stallion—a stallion unaware that he's wild.

So, how do we begin the journey of self-actualization?

As a Christian man, my first answer is always to ask God. Through a journey with God, He can answer these questions for you. Matthew 7:7 (NIV) advises, "Ask and it will be given to you; seek and you will find; knock and the door will be opened to you."

But not everyone reading this book is on a faith journey.

According to Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs¹, the journey begins with basic needs like food, water, warmth, and rest. Then comes safety and security. These form the foundation upon which we build psychological needs like belonging and esteem. Finally, we enter into self-fulfillment needs, including self-actualization.

I say all this to make a point: it's a process. When we truly begin to love ourselves, we take the time to understand ourselves.

It's a sad state of affairs when men's only association with themselves is media representation. As a Black man, I must be an athlete, an artist, or some sort of gangster to be deemed extraordinary. Why? Because that's how we're portrayed in the media.

LeBron James is larger than life—an athlete.

Kevin Hart is larger than life—an artist.

Snoop Dogg is larger than life—an artist and gangster.

For years, I aspired to be what I saw in the media, but I didn't fit the mold. I started looking within and found myself. I discovered that I love writing, playing musical instruments, spending time in nature, and seeking truth. I love handholding, hugs, kisses, and undivided attention. All these are things I learned about myself, separate from any external influence.

So, what makes you unique?

What do you love about yourself?

What do you love?

1. <https://www.simplypsychology.org/maslow.html>

Chapter 3: What Do You Want

The title of this chapter poses a trick question because there is no definitive answer. To clarify, I think the question should be, “What do you want today?”

As we mature, our perspectives and desires evolve. Earlier in life, I was thrilled at the prospect of getting my diaper changed. As I grew, my focus shifted to gaining throwback Chuck Taylors or Air Jordans. The same evolution applies to our relational desires.

During my late teens and early twenties, I dated several young women. I didn’t realize it then, but I had established a pattern. I specifically remember Ava, a young woman who stood out for two reasons: she was an excellent cook and loved intimacy.

My mother noticed Ava didn’t fit the mold of the women I’d previously dated. Naturally, she questioned my interest in her. And being the dutiful son that I was, I evaded the truth. The real reason I spent time with Ava was her ease of intimacy—followed by a satisfying meal.

This focus on Ava came at the expense of my relationship with Madison, a woman who genuinely loved me. Madison was reserved and self-respectful. In hindsight, I should have focused on building a future with her rather than chasing after Ava, a fleeting pleasure.

As men mature, so do our desires. In the early 1990s, I wanted different things than I did in 2018. Therefore, the answer to what one truly desires isn’t constant; it changes as we evolve.

Here’s an exercise: List what you don’t want in your relationship. Here are a few things I absolutely don’t want:

- A man. In today’s society, clarity is paramount. I believe in heterosexual relationships.
- A weak woman. A relationship is a partnership; there’s no room for dominance and submissiveness.
- A religious woman. Being scrupulously faithful isn’t the same as showing evidence of godly fruit or communion.

As you compile your list, your preferences will become clear. Remember, your desires will evolve, so this exercise requires immediate application to avoid being held hostage by emotional shifts.

Take your time on this exercise. When you’re purposeful in your steps forward, you can expect more favorable results. Trust me, there are few things worse than realizing you’ve moved in the wrong direction—I speak from experience.

Chapter 4: Dating

I'm the first to admit that I don't have all the answers, but I will find them.

Since I had been married to my ex-wife for over twenty-two years, I wasn't prepared for the dating scene. Why? Because in the late 1990s, people were different, expectations were different, and, quite honestly, everything was different.

So, as an analyst, I did what I knew: I conducted tests.

* * *

Let's Do Lunch

For close to a year, I took time to learn what women in the 2010s were looking for, what they wanted, and where their heads were regarding dating, relationships, and men in general. I started going out to lunch with the women from my job. To be fair and balanced, I went on a lot of lunches with a wide variety of women.

During these lunches, we visited several restaurants around the job—from Chipotle to Max & Erma's, from Chinese to Greek, from food courts to fine dining. Sometimes, I paid; sometimes, we split the bill. But the key to these lunches was that there were no preconceived notions that these were dates or preludes to some intimate relationship. These were meals with friends.

One thing everyone knew was that I was dealing with divorce and that I wasn't interested in kindling any new flames. Other than that, the gloves were off.

Most of the time, once we sat down, I didn't have to say much at all.

Fellas: Women love to talk. So, if you want to know something about them, allow them to be themselves. You'll learn everything you need to know!

Again, most times, I didn't have to say much at all.

I had lunch with Charlotte. I asked, "Hey, how are things going with you?"

When these words floated from my mouth, I found out her current living situation, relationship status, random things about her family, how much money certain people owed her, who her friends were, who hated her, and how many men she was currently sleeping with. But wait—I learned all of this in less than forty-five minutes!

I went to lunch with Sofia and asked a similar icebreaker question.

I learned she was reserved regarding men because she had been hurt several times. She didn't like being single, but the surrounding options were limited. She was content taking care of her teenage child. Another thing about her was that she was dealing with some genuine health concerns. When she had flare-ups, it wasn't pretty. And, finally, the guy she was seeing was not being a man of his word and was being a plain old jerk.

Then there was Chloe.

Chloe was cool. She was reluctant even to have lunch because “she didn’t do that kind of thing.” But we did, and I learned about the difficulty of single-parenting and raising two children. She loved talking about her dreams. She wanted to live on a particular side of town, in a specific type of house, with a certain number of bedrooms and bathrooms. And I can’t forget: IKEA would fully furnish the home. What made Chloe cool was not only that she was a dreamer, but also a hard worker. She worked toward attaining those dreams. The guy she was dating was mistreating her children.

After only a few lunches, I saw a theme.

These women were crazy!

But they were crazy for a reason. The men in their lives weren’t good. Each of these women had a history of men problems. Each settled for their guy, and the guy knew she was settling.

The good part for the latter two women is that they moved on from the uncool situations. Thank God!

Now, I can’t wholly blame the men, though. Women also have roles to play in these foul situations. Like, if a man is mistreating your children, he needs to go. You managed your bills and home before he moved into your place. So, forget the financial gain he brings; for the sake of the children, he needs to be evicted, at a minimum.

The good thing about these lunches is that not every woman I shared the table with was a basket case.

Victoria was amazing. She was a fitness consultant with Weight Watchers who had lost over two hundred pounds, if I remember correctly. She loved running and frequently took part in various marathons. She is a happily married woman, and the love of her life is her grandson, whom we’ll call Andrew.

Andrew is genuinely her love. I smile, even now, thinking about all the Andrew stories and pictures she shared.

One thing Victoria recommended was that I take a vacation to Jamaica before getting into another meaningful relationship. The reason is that when she completed her divorce, she took that vacation, and it did her a world of good. She wasn’t Stella but was released from the bondage of her past during this trip.

* * *

Moving on to Hannah... She was a beautiful, intelligent, God-fearing woman who knew what she wanted, where she wanted to be, and had a plan to get there. When we first went to lunch, she focused on work and raising her child. Our lunch was refreshing; we spoke on an

intellectual level, comparing thoughts about church, God's role in people's lives, and fulfilling one's destiny. The most remarkable thing about her was that, as time passed, a gentleman found her, and they eventually married.

We must never forget that there are several "someones" out there for everyone. We often don't meet these unique individuals because we don't make ourselves accessible; we live in a bubble.

I grew up in a family church where I was related to everyone. Consequently, the only time I met any eligible young women was when other churches visited or when we visited other churches. Could I expect to meet my future spouse at my family church? It's possible, but maybe I need to broaden my horizons.

* * *

Would You Like to Hang Out Sometime?

There are several reasons people date: one, sex; two, appearance; three, companionship; four, all of the above.

Let's Talk about Hooking Up

How often have you heard the phrase "We all have our needs"? In such cases, the speaker is usually justifying their sexual activities. Sometimes we hook up with people we'd never otherwise consider, fueled by either lust or the simple passage of time since our "last time."

My first roommate in Japan was indifferent about whom he slept with. Any woman who paid him the slightest attention was fair game. As his roommate, I had to endure his late-night escapades.

Hooking up often leads to emotional damage. Emotions get involved, and someone ends up getting hurt. Take Felicia, for example. She loved to cook and often sent plates my way. One day, I arrived to find her answering the door in nothing but a T-shirt. I was faced with a moral dilemma, and, regrettably, my baser instincts won. I stayed for dinner—and dessert.

* * *

Appearance Over Substance

Have you ever heard statements like, "Honey, you're not getting any younger. You need to find somebody"? Sometimes, people date to keep others off their backs.

In Hollywood, for instance, a handsome man might be seen with a beautiful woman one day and another the next. Eventually, we discover he's gay.

Then there was Aria. I loved hanging out with her, not because sex was the objective, but because we genuinely enjoyed each other's company. She liked the appearance of having a man in her life but didn't want the commitment that came with it.

The Search for Companionship

“It is not good that the man should be alone” (Genesis 2:18, King James Version).
Companionship requires mutual goals and intentions.

Take Monica, for instance. We met in the cereal aisle at Kroger and talked for nearly ninety minutes. Although we enjoyed each other’s company, we eventually discovered that we were too similar for a romantic relationship.

* * *

When companionship is the goal, life becomes more evident. You’re not concerned with what others think or jumping into bed; you’re focused on building a relationship. Option four is the perfect combination: I reconnected with a lifelong friend and found an excellent addition to my life.

So, what are your reasons for dating a particular person? What makes you dateable?

Chapter 5: He That Findeth...

For just a moment, I want to speak to the men.

Until now, it has been all fun and games. We’ve learned a bit about the single life and some of its aspects—understanding ourselves and navigating the dating scene. We’ve experienced both success and failure. However, when it all boils down, the immediate impact involves only two people: her and me.

This is the point at which we need to elevate our game. We’re in the big leagues now. No more child’s play; this is serious business.

The first question to ask is, “What are you looking for?”

“He that findeth a wife findeth a good thing, and obtaineth favour of the LORD,”

(Proverbs 18:22, KJV)

Finding a woman is easy. In the United States, women make up more than half of the population. So, sheer numbers show that there are many options if you’re looking for a woman. Women come in all shapes, sizes, ages, economic backgrounds, and education levels. This array might seem like a buffet at first glance.

However, a real man is not just looking for a woman; he’s searching for a wife. Proverbs 31:10 declares, “Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies” (KJV).

A man with proper self-esteem will recognize the value that a good wife adds to his life.

Now, let’s shift the focus to the ladies.

If you've had enough of casual and temporary relationships and yearn for something more enduring, know that God places high value on you. He directs your future husband to build a relationship that mirrors this divine view.

Proverbs 31:10 reiterates, "Who can find a virtuous woman? for her price is far above rubies." The man who becomes your husband should see your worth, not merely his perception of your value to him. He should love you "as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it" (Ephesians 5:25, KJV).

This image is not of a man who merely provides financial security and a place to live. While men like that abound, many are so self-centered that they desire a spouse who will focus solely on them. Such an environment will starve you of the affection that fosters growth.

In Ephesians 5, the Bible speaks of mutual submission within marriage. Marriage is not a 50-50 arrangement: it's 100-100. As God loves His church, so should you be loved. As the Church reflects God's grace, so should you, as a priceless pearl, illuminate your husband's life.

Strength and power come from being this priceless pearl. If your husband hasn't yet discovered his divine role, your commitment to God can guide him toward "a life of real love" (1 Corinthians 7:13-14, KJV).

However, those same verses clarify that if an unbelieving spouse is unwilling to stay in the relationship without causing harm, this is unacceptable. Such a circumstance is not life together but mere cohabitation; you must not endure such abuse.

The key to your happiness lies first in self-respect and then in bestowing that respect upon others. If you struggle with poor self-esteem, begin with your mindset. As mentioned earlier, as you think, so you shall become.

This is a message to both men and women.

One simple thing I learned while having those lunches is that when a man shows genuine interest, even partially, a woman can quickly become a candidate for a long-term relationship.

Women are tired of sorry men. They're frustrated with the games, the lying, the cheating, and the misrepresentations. Women are done with it!

Some have chosen to become players, like the men who hurt them. Others are choosing alternative lifestyles, assuming they can avoid the heartbreak they've experienced, only to discover that unhealthy relationships come from all directions.

Finally, many women respond to men by isolating themselves. This response is incredibly hurtful to me. So many outstanding women have chosen 'nothing' to avoid the potential pain of being in a relationship. I know a woman who wanted this life and still ended up being stalked, her home broken into, and almost raped—each event by different men.

To be more than honest, my heart goes out to women. You are incredible creatures! There's nothing on this earth more amazing than a woman! And this is one reason I drafted this book.

Some might compare our search for the right husband or wife to being a coal miner. Coal is plentiful and accessible. But without it, there's a lot we would not enjoy.

But let me be clear: I'm not a coal miner but a diamond miner.

Diamonds are more precious than coal. They've been formed under extreme temperatures and pressures. Diamonds have taken the most challenging situations and transformed into something of greater value. The diamonds that can best complement our lives are those that have not just reacted to life but have responded to it.

When searching for a diamond, I look for the Four Cs: cut, color, clarity, and carat weight. These are the essential elements of any diamond. Let me explain.

Cut

The first thing any man or woman notices is what they can see. The "cut" refers to someone's appearance: Is it pleasing to the eye? Is there a special glimmer in their eyes?

Men are visual, and women know this. So, don't be fooled. When she puts on those yoga pants, she knows we're going to look. She was aware we were paying attention when she wore that dress and high heels.

Women are visual, too. They notice the guy who knows his way around a gym and has that chiseled look. But they are also watching for character and inner strength.

When men wear trendy business suits or the latest hip-hop outfits, they know they will not go unnoticed. They may adopt an attitude, hoping to catch the ladies' eyes.

Just like women, men can't help but advertise. Both are shoppers, and both expect to be shopped.

If you know what Christian Louboutin is, you know everyone is looking for that one person who has "the cut."

Every Thursday, I go to lunch with my all-male team. One of the recurring conversations is about the women who pass by our table or the window outside the restaurant.

And when women get together for coffee, they watch the parade of guys passing by.

Everyone can't help but notice those who appear to have it "all together."

Color

One promise I've made to myself is always to be honest when I write.

We humans can be very racist. We Black people can be even more racist than any other group. Why? Because we exhibit racist tendencies within our own race.

I am a dark-skinned Black man. Growing up in the 1970s, being dark-skinned was unpopular. Over the years, I've had to overcome the stereotypes placed on me because of my skin color. The name-calling and teasing—Blackie Jackie, Blackjack—were painful periods in my life. Worse, I perpetuated that pain onto others.

For many years, I wouldn't give a second glance at a dark-skinned Black woman. Despite her beauty, her skin tone was a turnoff. I'd use phrases like, "She's cute, but two dark-skinned people can't get together. The kids will come out blurple." I projected my insecurities onto others who felt the same pain.

Consequently, I gravitated toward women who were brown-skinned, red-boned, or high-yellow. I avoided women of other races and ethnicities.

But one day, I broke the color barrier and hung out with a mixed-race young woman—Black and Japanese. From that day forward, I was a free man.

We all have preferences for diamond colors: pink, blue, white, or even chocolate. Preferences need not become prejudices. Yet, when it comes to skin color, prejudices can be not only real but also limiting.

Clarity

Clarity focuses on the psyche of the diamonds around us.

Picture this: someone who looks striking enters the room. Everyone notices she is dynamite or that he's a real hunk. Miss Dynamite opens her mouth, or Mr. Hunk speaks up, and the dumbest things are released into the air.

Simply stated, water seeks its own level.

I'm not a street guy, so a "hood chick" wouldn't be a fit for me; there are certain things that I don't think about or perceive.

A woman who is not a sports fan wouldn't be a good fit for the handsome jock at the center of the room.

Now, I am a thinker. So, someone who can engage my thoughts is a good fit.

I am an educated man, so someone with a particular level of education or thought is a good fit.

I love God and family, so someone who genuinely loves God and family is an excellent fit for me.

Clarity is also about speaking the same language. We often fall for the package. She's extraordinarily attractive; she can cook and is excellent in bed. Or he's a gentleman and drives a sports car. But those things are shallow.

There are over 125 million women in the United States. At least half of them are attractive, can cook, and can satisfy your sexual urges—but can you have a meaningful conversation with her? There are men everywhere with fancy cars and a certain attractive suaveness, but can the conversation go beyond him or his vehicle?

Clarity is crucial because the mind will last long after looks have faded.

Carat Weight

Carat weight is character. I could complete this entire book just by defining this one quality.

According to Merriam-Webster, character is:

- One of the attributes or features that make up and distinguish an individual
- The complex of mental and ethical traits marking and often individualizing a person, group, or nation
- Moral excellence and firmness

In short, character is who you are when no one is looking. It's what separates and distinguishes you from everyone else. It's the mark of a diamond.

A person's character can and will be displayed in many ways.

I had a conversation with my friend about the fact that I don't open the car door for her. After I proposed, she told her father I didn't open the car door for her. Naturally, as a father, he wanted to know why.

My answer was straightforward and true to my character: "Her hands aren't broken."

That is me. If I suddenly started opening the car door for her, I wouldn't be true to myself. I would be trying to be someone else, which I don't do.

When we're together, she never has to worry about being cared for. There's nothing I don't offer or do within my means. That's my character.

Character also encompasses expectations, wants, wishes, and desires. Notice that needs are not a part of character but a separate subject altogether.

Since character deals with mentality and ethics, expectations differ from person to person. For some, the expectation of opening the car door might be a deal-breaker because they view it as a sign of disrespect or lack of courtesy. Others might see it as condescending or a slight against femininity and equality.

The thing to remember about finding a spouse is that it's a choice. While we might be diamond miners, we see many diamonds. The task we all face is deciding which diamond to stick with.

This is my third marriage. Before I got married the first time, there were several candidates; the same was true before this marriage.

I had to make a choice: which diamond would be mine? But how do you distinguish one diamond from another?

Chapter 6: Celibacy

Celibacy: "The state of abstaining from marriage and sexual relations."

Translation: Keep your stuff to yourself.

Any questions?

* * *

I tried to leave this topic out, but I couldn't resist. Celibacy and abstinence are touchy subjects, both figuratively and literally. Abstinence represents temporary avoidance of sex, whereas celibacy is a lifestyle.

As you may have noticed in previous chapters, I haven't been a shining example of either. I could easily rely on the rhetoric that says, "I'm a man, and I need to get some," or "The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak" (Matthew 26:41, KJV). However, I won't.

The reason I can write this book is that I have experienced everything about which I write. This book serves as a cleansing process for me. I've had sex outside of marriage multiple times with various women. When they weren't around, I engaged in solo sexual activities (more on that shortly).

I take full responsibility for my sexual escapades. The devil didn't make me do it. Though he may have played a role, quite honestly, I wanted it each time. Here's the deal: Once certain doors open, only an act of God can close them. However, God doesn't close doors we wish to remain open.

I've abstained from sex when it was convenient. When between relationships, I didn't always desire the whole dinner-movie-sex routine. I was uncertain whether I wanted to engage in the conversations that came before and after sex. There were also times when I earnestly sought God and didn't want to be distracted.

There were reasons I abstained. But remember, abstinence is temporary.

I know a woman—let's call her Mary—who lives a celibate lifestyle. Mary isn't who you'd expect to be celibate. She's not a shy, homely woman wearing sackcloth. Quite the contrary, Mary is attractive and lively. She is reserved in her dress, but she is no slouch. She doesn't

advertise because she's not selling. Her home revolves around her faith in God. She mostly watches faith-based or family-oriented television.

Some might think Mary is boring, but she is anything but. She knows what she wants and creates an environment that is controlled. Last I heard, she had been celibate for over ten years, and for that, I applaud her.

When I was single, my environment wasn't as virtuous. I was a free spirit and dressed accordingly. I leaned toward business-casual attire but suited up when necessary. My TV watching was eclectic, ranging from horror movies to cartoons to pornography.

Quick pause: Be honest—what does your TV-viewing habit say about you?

My viewing choices reflected my lifestyle. I sought thrills, loved to laugh, and, frankly, loved sex.

Let's get real: Seeking sex with multiple partners is defined as "being a hoe" in the Urban Dictionary. The term refers to someone who sleeps with multiple people simultaneously, thinking that's okay.

Let's explore why this isn't good.

* * *

Physical Health

It's called disease. According to the CDC,

"Breaking news from the 2018 National STD Prevention Conference: New CDC data find that nearly 2.3 million cases of chlamydia, gonorrhea, and syphilis were diagnosed in the United States in 2017. Public health leaders, including those from the Association of State and Territorial Health Officials (ASTHO), National Coalition of STD Directors (NCSDD), and the University of Alabama's School of Medicine, join CDC onsite to discuss the new findings and how to counter the country's STD epidemic."

(August 28, 2018)

There are 2.3 million cases of chlamydia, gonorrhea, and syphilis. However, this number does not include herpes, HIV, and AIDS.

I was recently listening to a radio show, and one of the co-hosts said, "After I've gone through six or seven condoms, then I'm going raw; because by then, we've established trust between each other." What?

Keep in mind, he said, "six or seven condoms." In a subsequent statement, he clarified that these might be used during six or seven visits or six or seven times in one visit. How in the world are you establishing trust?

No, sir. You are rolling the dice with your life.

My thinking regarding condom use was solely based on the individual's history. Why? Because I was not too fond of condoms. While "interviewing" the candidate, I listened for critical phrases regarding abstinence—e.g., "It's been a year since I've had sex," or "I haven't been with anyone since 2016."

Considering my health, I judged a woman's suitability as a sexual partner based on the time since she last had sex. I knew I was healthy—I had been tested, and my results were clear.

However, how many of us know that people lie?

Just as I was interviewing candidates, they were interviewing me. And people are proficient at telling their version of a story.

Having sex, for some people, only means vaginal penetration. They don't count oral or anal sex, nor the multiple people they've kissed. Many diseases are transmitted through bodily fluids, such as saliva. And then you wonder why you have sores in your mouth.

Let's move on.

Mental / Spiritual Health

"The mind is a terrible thing to waste" is often said in the context of education, but it's also true concerning relationships. If my aim was a one-night stand, once I achieved that, I moved on. The thrill was in the chase, and the excitement was in the conquest.

I know a notably abstinent woman. She had a knack for crushing a man's spirit by rejecting his advances. We became friends and shared a lot. Initially, I was interested in her, mainly for sexual reasons, but we connected on a deeper level. The problem was I was also involved with another woman, complicating my emotional and spiritual state.

These connections are called "soul ties." They don't just vanish—you must be cleansed and delivered from them.

Pornography is another issue. Jeremiah 17:9 (KJV) says, "The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked: who can know it?" Pornography is addictive and, left unchecked, can lead you down a dark path. If you find yourself in such a place, seek licensed counseling and spiritual guidance.

We risk more than just a good time when we fail to practice abstinence or celibacy. Our very lives and souls are at stake.

I don't have specific questions at the end of this chapter. However, I'd like you to ponder your sexual choices and the potential consequences.

For more information on STDs, visit the CDC's website.

Chapter 7: The Big Day

Just for the fellas, the “big day” is the Wedding Day—the day your lady has been waiting for since she was born.

Young girls dream about finding their Prince Charming, being swept off their feet, and being carried away by the man of their dreams.

Since this is already their mindset, one of the best pieces of advice I can offer is to keep your head down, agree to everything, and smile.

The end!

Now, if you believe any of those opening paragraphs, then keep reading for the actual story.

We’ve been trained to believe that the day a man and woman get married is “Her Day.” We see wedding shows like “Say Yes to the Dress,” “Bridezillas,” and “Married at First Sight.” Then we have movies like “My Best Friend’s Wedding,” “Runaway Bride,” and “My Big Fat Greek Wedding.” Everything we see points us in the direction that it’s all about the woman.

But that kind of thinking is totally out of balance. The marriage relationship is a moment that is shared. Is it a special moment for the bride? Yes. She expected that this would be the pinnacle of her life, and it is, even without the hype of social and cultural media. But the groom also experiences a special moment. His life is changing. This time is to be equally shared between the two of them and less as a fairy-tale social occasion for the entertainment of others.

After all, without each other, where would they be?

Quick answer? Single.

Everything from the proposal to the honeymoon is about the two becoming one. It’s about us.

* * *

The Proposal

It’s every woman’s dream to be loved and have that love sealed with that romantic moment of the proposal. And every man faces the possibility that this anticipated moment might not have a happy ending.

We know how this works. We’re out to dinner at our favorite restaurant. We had a fantastic time. The service was excellent. The food was terrific. And the conversation was pleasant, as usual.

And then, the couple's favorite song is playing out of the blue? The guy gets all nervous. His throat is suddenly dry, and he can barely speak. She watches as he reaches into his pocket and pulls out a little box. He stands up, only long enough to get down on one knee.

She is watching his lips move and realizes that words are coming out of his mouth that sound like, "Will you marry me?"

The universe explodes because this is the pivotal moment in life. People celebrate. The screams of excitement fill the air. And everything in life pauses for a moment, waiting for her answer.

Then, there it is: "Yes." And the cheering begins all over again.

We might be tempted to think the "yes" is the most significant moment. Still, in all the celebrations, we quickly forget that another feature of the event is just as pivotal: the moment this guy risks it all by asking in the first place.

Now, both of them have made a life-changing decision. They have committed to a life with each other and with no one else. The other suitors are history. The flings are over. Both have turned in their playing card and taken themselves off the market. In the words of Michael Jackson, "This is it!"

This decision is not a light one. It solidifies your choice to be with one woman. When I proposed to my wife, the part in the vows that says, "Forsaking all others," flashed like breaking news before my eyes. It was a reminder and a warning.

But I am not a hopeless romantic. My proposal went something like this. My friend called me. She was going to the emergency room because she was experiencing a lot of pain. It was around 7 a.m.

So, I contacted my job to inform them I'd be late because my friend was in the ER.

I proceeded to the hospital to be by her side because I hated seeing someone in the ER alone. It's bad enough that they are there, but to be there without support isn't cool to me.

When I arrived, the medical staff was doing their thing: running tests, taking her blood pressure, and so forth. The doctor had been in the room to tell us what was happening and to set our expectations.

Quick note: Notice how I switched from going to see her to how the doctor was talking to us.

As often happens in the ER, we were left in the room for a long time. The TV was on, but we weren't watching it. Every so often, we'd update the family with our current status.

Then, suddenly, I heard someone talking—and it was me.

Me: "Do you want to go ahead and do this?"

Her: "Sure."

Me: "When?"

Her: "Don't play, Jackie."

Me: "Okay, let's start over. Do you really want to go ahead and do this? Yes or no because I don't know what 'sure' means."

Her: "Yes," (long pause) "as long as you're not playing."

Me: "Okay, cool. I don't have the ring right now. We can get it later. And I'm sorry, but I'm not getting on this dirty floor."

Her: "Okay." (Pauses) "Are you really serious?"

I then pulled out my cell phone and texted our immediate families. About an hour later, I went through my contacts and sent a message to every woman with whom I was close, hanging out, friends, had any feelings for, and any woman my new fiancée had a problem with. I let them know individually that I'd just proposed, and she said yes.

The crazy part is that I'd been thinking about asking her for over a month. But something always stopped me; I couldn't pull the trigger. It was never the right moment; something else always took over our conversations.

But sitting in silence in the ER, I knew that was the moment. Was it romantic? No. Was it the perfect scenario? No. Was it memorable? Yes.

And that's what we men want.

We want that unforgettable moment. We want to see that look of surprise. We want to make our ladies the happiest women on the planet.

Now, about those texts, they were also for us. I wanted to seal the deal. "Forsaking all others" started right then. Some of these women were remarkably close friends, so I wanted them to know personally that our friendship was changing. Not everyone needs to know about your engagement through "Facebook Official."

The responses varied greatly. Some were extremely excited that I'd found my wife-to-be. They asked for details, wanted to meet her, and some asked for invitations to the wedding. Some were indifferent to the news, with responses like "I'm glad to hear that" and "Congratulations to her."

Then there was the final group: the doubters. Their responses included, "Are you sure?" "I thought y'all were just friends," and "Are you really sure? Maybe you need to think about that."

Categorically speaking, the excited people were my real friends, the indifferent ones were candidates, and the doubters were close family and friends. But here's one thing to remember about responses: no one loves you more than your close friends and family. While their answers may catch you off guard, they come from a good place. So don't trip unless they get out of hand.

Chapter 8: Till Death?

Marriage isn't just the joining of a man and woman in the union of holy matrimony; it's the fusion of two separate lives into one cohesive unit. However, when you start blending lives replete with individual habits, divergent opinions, and unique preferences, the adjustment might feel more like a collision than a union.

Yet marriage is a commitment.

I adore married life—it's a beautiful thing. Choosing to forsake singledom, settle down with one woman, and share my existence with her for the rest of my life is a testament to the transformative power of marriage. I am committed to this one woman, no matter what happens.

Here's the crux: we both must be fully committed to each other—one man, one woman, period.

The cracks in our resolve often surface when our commitment faces trials. Tests of commitment aren't solely about covenant violations, such as cheating or adultery. We face trials in various forms. For a reason, traditional vows include the phrase, "for better, for worse, for richer, for poorer, in sickness and in health, to love and to cherish, till death do us part." Each scenario separated by a comma serves as a test of our commitment.

Like life itself, marriage is a roller coaster. You will confront all those "commas." We relish the positive ones: better, richer, health. But what transpires when we face the negatives: worse, poorer, sickness?

Take my parents' marriage, for example. They weathered all these commas, but one thing remained constant: my dad was steadfast till the very end. My mother passed away from lung cancer. Throughout her illness, and until her final moments, my father was ever-present. Remarkably, before succumbing to lung cancer, my mother had survived two distinct forms of breast cancer, prolonging her years of illness.

My father's test lay in whether he would continue supporting her despite his unease around hospitals, doctors, needles, and medical tubes. He passed that test with excellence.

Again, expect to face all these commas.

The key to overcoming such trials is setting ground rules and expectations for your marriage. Without expectations, you surrender control, reacting to life's vicissitudes instead of responding thoughtfully. You end up like a dinghy tossed around by ocean waves.

Personally, I aim to be a ship, purposefully navigating through the waves, moving toward a specific goal. And here are some suggestions on how to do that.

* * *

Other People Don't Matter

When it comes to my marriage, the only person I aim to please is my wife. I firmly believe in the "Leave and Cleave" philosophy. The Bible states in Matthew 19:5 (KJV), "For this cause shall a man leave father and mother, and shall cleave to his wife: and they twain shall be one flesh."

While I remain my parents' son and wish to please them, they can no longer be my priority. I have taken a wife; she is now my primary focus. I cover her, and she covers me. She's the friend for whom I would lay down my life. This woman—my wife!

If I prioritize my wife over my parents, where does anyone else stand?

In this era of blurred values and misplaced priorities, our mistake often lies in allowing ourselves to be overwhelmed by an excess of "stuff," obscuring what's right and who's wrong. Social media bombard us with a range of images and thoughts, and news outlets inundate us with a continuous stream of negativity. There's no standard anymore; everyone's opinion seems to matter.

That shouldn't be the case. If you're not in my inner circle, you're irrelevant to me and my circle. While that might sound harsh, it's the truth.

We frequently become ensnared in debates about others' opinions on our domestic lives or parenting styles. I even rewrote the preface and the first two chapters of this book because of concerns over public perception and whether my words might be too abrasive for churchgoers. Yet, churchgoers make up one of the highest percentages of divorcees in the United States.

Our marriages often fail because we're overly concerned with others' opinions. Mary and Mark's thirty-year relationship doesn't grant Mary any right to advise my wife. Why? Because I'm not married to Mary; our lives and marriages are distinct.

Social media's accessibility is its curse. Posting about marital spats exposes the one you should be protecting. Public comments, when you've invited them, can be vexing.

Another arena where others don't matter is within blended families. When I married my first wife, she had a fifteen-year-old son, a seven-year-old daughter, and a three-month-old son. We became one family because I engaged purposefully with each member. I handled night-time cries and supported our daughter and oldest son in their needs. My wife took on the role of disciplinarian. We didn't let others invade our space, even when one of the biological fathers lived nearby.

My guiding principle is, “If they don’t matter, they don’t matter, period.” So why discuss the irrelevant? This leads me to my next point.

* * *

Leave the Past in the Past

When dealing with the past, men and women can differ significantly. To one spouse, the past might become irrelevant within less than five seconds, while the other may cling to the past as if it’s still a part of the present.

Some of the most invaluable advice I ever received came from my stepmother. When she married Joe, he told her, “If you don’t inquire about the past, I won’t discuss it. I won’t ask about your past, either. What matters is what we share right now.” Remarkably, they never discussed people or events from their previous lives and enjoyed an extraordinary marriage.

Regrettably, I received this advice only after I’d got the “run-offs” with my fiancée. I had given her an overview of my previous life, believing that understanding my history would enable her to better comprehend my feelings and decisions. However, the issue was not that I was sharing, but that I failed to consider her capacity to process this information. I inundated her with names and details, unintentionally giving her reasons to dislike people she had never met. My past became fodder for disagreements, and she used it against me. In my attempt to be transparent, I unwittingly introduced negativity into her present and mine.

Here’s what I learned: God designed us to be givers, and couples should reciprocate that giving, even prioritizing the other’s needs. Yet, what we share should build up each other. In my eagerness to be transparent, I failed to recognize that I was planting negative seeds rather than strengthening her as a partner.

The act of giving always involves receiving, and what is received is carried forward, whether it is constructive or not. Our words and actions have the power to strengthen or weaken others. For instance, if a man like Daniel is unfaithful to Margaret, he sows a seed of mistrust that will affect her future relationships. As a result, if I marry Margaret, I may have to contend with the trust issues Daniel instilled in her, possibly even needing to uproot a deeply entrenched tree of mistrust for our relationship to thrive.

Sharing is caring, but we must be judicious in what we share, how much we share, and how we share it. Some aspects of the past should remain there; they don’t improve our present lives.

And that leads me to another thought.

* * *

If Something Matters to That Special Person in Your Life, Then It Should Matter to You

Over the years, I've matured and developed a specific quality: emotional detachment toward things I don't care about. This is a development because, for many years, my emotional investment was disproportionately high in something that had no impact on my family or me.

A news event could unfold, and I'd be distraught. The Raiders losing another game would infuriate me. I was overly empathetic toward other people's problems. It got so bad that my wife once asked me if I was menstruating. Yes, it was that bad!

So, I learned to distance myself from situations that didn't directly affect me. The problem is, I'm analytical by nature. I pull away just enough to analyze a situation, which then morphs into unsolicited feedback. In a marriage, emotional detachment is not always the right approach, especially when my wife feels strongly about a situation.

Now, I'm speaking directly to the men. One of the worst things we can do is oversimplify a situation that our wives are going through. We've all been guilty of it.

Imagine coming home from work to find your wife upset. Your first thought is, "What did I do?" Then follows an investigative period that ranges from fifteen minutes to an hour, depending on the severity of the issue at hand. The bigger the problem, the longer the conversation and the apology—and possibly, the more lavish the make-up gift. However, focusing on the potential rewards may be premature. Sometimes gratification must be postponed.

Eventually, she reveals the issue: Johnny left his muddy shoes on the freshly cleaned carpet instead of in the mudroom.

You mentally check off:

- Awesome, it wasn't me.
- I'll talk to Johnny.
- Now, Mommy will be happy.
- Make-up time!

You then say, "Don't worry about it. I'll take care of it," thus stepping into a new realm of trouble. You've minimized the issue because it didn't matter to you—but it mattered to her.

The saying "Happy Wife, Happy Life" isn't about treating her like royalty. It's about acknowledging her concerns and prioritizing them accordingly.

Men seek peace and often look for the quickest route to it. Women want peace too, but they value respect more. By offering a curt response, you don't show respect for her feelings. What she needs to hear is your genuine concern, something beyond a dismissive "Don't worry about it."

Many men are reticent about expressing their feelings. Had you articulated your thoughts more thoroughly, you might have reached the make-up stage sooner. But by reducing your response to one-liners, she feels disrespected and not valued. Phase two of this episode will then shift to how you didn't grasp the gravity of the situation, questioning your respect for her.

It's a continual struggle to find this balance, but it's achievable. It just takes time.

Speaking of balance...

* * *

Take Plenty of Vacations

I passionately believe in taking a break from our normal day-to-day operations, especially when we're married.

One of the most significant mistakes couples make is ignoring vacations. The average worker in the United States receives fifteen days of paid leave each year. However, a recent survey revealed that fifty-two percent of Americans did not use all their paid vacation days in 2017.

Did you know that in Austria, citizens receive thirty-eight mandatory paid days off, consisting of thirteen public holidays and twenty-five days of annual leave?

Did you know that the top ten reasons marriages fail all point to one central problem? Stress!

We are stressing each other out. Regardless of whether the problems are related to finances, communication, or general family issues, we acknowledge that time should be allotted for breaks.

When I say "vacation," I don't mean booking a seven-day family package to Disney World or embarking on a ten-day cruise to some faraway land. According to Merriam-Webster, vacation is defined as (1) a period spent away from home or business in travel or recreation, and (2) a respite or time of respite from something.

In short, an intermission.

We need to take an intermission from our daily lives, whether it's something as simple as going to a local water park and renting an on-site room for the night, securing a cabin at one of your state's national parks for a weekend getaway, or taking a day trip to visit a winery. The key here is a departure from our regular routines.

For married people, I recommend taking at least three vacations each year.

The "Everybody" Vacation

As the name suggests, this vacation includes the whole family. Depending on the ages of your children, major amusement parks like Six Flags, Universal Studios, Cedar Point, or Disney World are options.

Amusement parks are designed with family in mind, although the cost may be prohibitive. Some parks charge as much as seventy dollars per person just for admission, which doesn't include rides or food. An alternative would be local festivals and county or state fairs, where admission is more affordable, yet families can still enjoy rides and food.

National parks such as Yellowstone, the Grand Canyon, and Yosemite are awe-inspiring destinations. However, local metro or state reserve parks offer a cheaper way to appreciate nature's beauty.

Have you ever considered visiting another city, like Washington, D.C., Gatlinburg, or Ocean City? Or perhaps Myrtle Beach, the Outer Banks, or South Beach? These trips can offer diverse experiences for you and your family.

Being a history buff, I like to point out historical landmarks when traveling. This way, vacations offer a bit of educational value as well.

The "Our" Vacation

The second type of vacation that we should take is the "Our Vacation." We often reserve these vacations for special events such as anniversaries, birthdays, and other meaningful moments. But regardless of the reason, an "Our Vacation" is our time to disconnect from our jobs, homes, and families and enjoy each other's company.

All of the above destinations are fine, but this is when we need to shift into romantic gear. Let's embark on a three-day cruise to the Bahamas, indulge in a couples' massage, and relax in our room. Alternatively, let's book a suite at the Four Seasons downtown, lounge by the pool for a bit, and then order room service.

It's not about where you go or what you're doing. It's about relaxing. We confront life's challenges every day: the morning commute, work deadlines, and then the evening commute back home to cook, clean, and care for the children. And then we repeat the cycle the following day and the day after that.

So, when we go on "Our Vacation," the objective is to disconnect. No phone calls home. Stay off Facebook and Instagram. Simply enjoy the company of the person to whom you've pledged your life and your love. Why? Because it's "Our Vacation."

The "My" Vacation

The third type of vacation is the "My Vacation." Just because you're married doesn't mean you have to be in each other's company constantly. Women need time with other women, and the same holds true for men.

Some of the best vacations I've had while married were the ones I took without my spouse and children. Sometimes, I went alone; at other times, I joined or met up with some of my guy friends.

The shortest "My Vacation" I ever took lasted approximately four and a half hours. I left home and went to my church for a men-only event. We watched the Super Bowl on big screens, ordered food from Hooters, and ate directly from the trays. Hardly anyone used napkins. There was a lot of joking, burping, and laughing—pure goofing off.

One comment I frequently heard was, "If my wife saw me doing this..." It was a memorable time that I'll never forget.

Regardless of the type of vacation you choose—whether it's an "Everybody Vacation," an "Our Vacation," or a "My Vacation"—take one. Vacations are healing.

Chapter 9: Death

How do you transition from the joy, excitement, and exhilaration of vacationing to the subject of death? For readers, a smooth transition from one topic to another is ideal. But, alas, death plays by no one's rules.

It's like a game of "Hide and Seek." Death has covered its eyes and is counting down. Once the count ends—ready or not — here it comes.

So, here we are.

Earlier, we discussed the concept that "He that findeth a wife findeth a good thing" (Proverbs 18:22, KJV). While that may be true, all things, even good ones, must come to an end.

The Three Ds: Death, Divorce, and Desertion

All marriages, like any other relationships, eventually end. In this chapter, we focus on the one termination over which we have no control: death. Whether your marriage is good, bad, or something in between, death will eventually knock on your door.

Hebrews 9:27 (KJV) states, "...it is appointed unto men once to die..." It's inescapable. This is one appointment that will not be missed.

When a loved one dies, those who remain experience grief.

I remember when my mother passed away. Watching her take her final breath was one of the most horrifying events of my life. My calmness was eerie; I was in a trance. I couldn't believe it had happened.

Whether we called 911 or hospice is a blur. But what I vividly recall is the gentle care they took with her body. They moved her from the bed to the gurney with the utmost respect. Her face remained uncovered until they placed her in the back of the hearse.

Chasing after the hearse as it drove away, I was finally broken when the car turned the corner.

Children in a marriage are affected perhaps as much, or even more, than the husband and wife. Why? Because we are a family. We are married. We are all part of this union.

The Loss

Losing a spouse is a harsh transition. You lose your life partner, your “better half,” your best friend, and your closest confidant—all simultaneously. Your life seems to grind to a halt, and the idea of moving on initially feels almost disrespectful to the one who has passed.

Every loss brings grief, but losing a spouse brings anguish, one of the most challenging experiences to navigate. Attempting to avoid the grieving process only hinders the healing that you need. With each of the Three Ds, loss and inevitable grief occur.

The Five Stages of Grief

Understanding the Five Stages of Grief—how to recognize them and how to respond—is vital. This applies both to the grieving individual and those who are trying to help. The grieving process is both real and intensely personal, whether you’re seven or seventy.

* * *

DENIAL

When I chased that car down the street, I was in denial. I couldn’t believe my mom was dead. I didn’t want to believe it; I couldn’t stand the thought that she was gone. When we are in denial, we neglect or deny the truth. We try to get a handle on life but can’t make heads or tails of what’s happening to us.

Our minds are filled with a billion questions: Why her? Or “Why him?” “Why now?” “How am I going to make it alone?”

Children wonder what their father or mother will do next. “What about my brother? My sister?”

Often, those who are left behind start thinking things like, “Maybe she’s not really dead,” or, “Maybe someone didn’t check her pulse correctly,” or, “He’ll wake up, and everything will be okay, the way it’s supposed to be.”

And then there’s the denial that keeps saying, “This isn’t real; maybe we’re just in a bad episode of The Twilight Zone.”

Denial, in whatever form, is a coping mechanism to make the current situation more bearable. It is a natural and temporary step in the process.

My only concern with denial is when it isn't temporary. We must move forward through grief and not let it become a lifestyle.

Being stuck is unhealthy. Living in grief will affect every aspect of your life. I know a guy who genuinely relives the emotions of death every time he passes a specific restaurant, hears a song on the radio, or engages in conversations about the deceased.

When we recognize people aren't moving on, we need to assist them in getting help.

* * *

ANGER

The next stage in the grieving process is anger.

My world was crushed in more ways than one. Not only did I grapple with the denial questions, but I also questioned my faith.

I was angry with God! How could He take her? Why didn't He heal her just as He did all those other times? Why did He let those other people live? She was far better than they were, but they're still here.

I served my church, but my heart was on fire. I played the organ every Sunday, yet my spirit was elsewhere. I ministered in song and even preached to the people, but the message was blocked from my heart because of my anger toward God.

This is where support plays a crucial role. Unchecked anger will continue to grow and fester. People do crazy things when they're angry. Some even black out and don't remember their actions or words due to anger. Therefore, if you are part of a community and recognize that someone is struggling with this anger, please be present for them. Make your presence felt.

I have a friend who randomly sends me encouraging emails and text messages. She's been doing this for over twenty years. Why? Because, at one time, I sent her encouraging and uplifting emails. My messages helped her so much that she turned around and began doing it herself.

Interestingly, I don't always read the messages the moment they're sent. It may be hours or even days later. But when I read them, they are helpful at that very moment!

* * *

BARGAINING

Whether occurring before or after death, bargaining is real. This is where we negotiate with God, and all the "what if" questions flow. "What if I started paying my tithes correctly? What if I started driving homeless people to their appointments? What if I...? What if I...?"

The good thing about bargaining is that at least we're moving on from anger, and even those around us can notice a change. But many of our thoughts and ideas are irrational.

This is where guilt rears its head. Phrases like "If I would have...", "If I could have...", and "If only..." become staples in our conversations.

We've come to grips with the fact that the loss is real. But we're searching for ways we could have fixed things. "Once I pay penance for whatever, I'll wake up tomorrow, and things will return to normal." But tomorrow never comes.

It's my fault they died because I wore my white sneakers after Labor Day. If only I could go back and wear my Timbs, then I might have prevented it from happening. And then there's self-blame: "If I had been a better person, God would not have taken them."

As supporters, we must understand that the person is in a time warp. The death may have occurred forty years ago, but this person is still there. They've been trying to negotiate the best deal with fate, but fate isn't cooperating. Understanding and concern are essential traits to possess. The person also needs occasional reality checks.

* * *

DEPRESSION

When we realize that our bargaining isn't working, the emotion of the situation returns vigorously. And here comes depression.

Depression is that sense of hopelessness, abandonment, and total emptiness. Nothing you say or do matters. Food loses its taste, and everything is blah. You're trapped in the prison of your mind and feelings. The only reality you experience is the bubble of numbness you inhabit.

I'm keeping these stages brief because I'm reliving some challenging times in my life, even as I type.

Here's some real talk: I was diagnosed with situational depression over ten years after my mom passed away. I thought I was doing okay. I was married with children and had a pretty good job. Bills were getting paid. But a particular scenario played out in my life, revealing that I was still mourning my mom. I was literally curled up on my couch. I didn't want to eat or hang out with my children; I wanted nothing to do with life.

But I sought help. I spent the next four years in counseling. It's not an overnight success sort of thing; it takes time. Think of it like weight loss: if it took several years for you to gain the weight, would it be reasonable to expect to lose it in a week?

The role of support at this stage is availability, listening, and finally, asking relevant questions: "You have counseling today. What time are you going?" "Did you go to counseling

today?” “How was your visit?” “Did you learn anything new?” “Is there anything you’d like to share?”

Don’t badger the person. Just ask general questions and listen to the responses. One of the most aggravating things is answering a question only to have the person ask it again—or worse, getting the details wrong, indicating they weren’t listening and didn’t really care.

Case in point: my counselor’s name was Casey. When I first started seeing her, I went twice a week for nearly a year. So, Casey was a significant person in my life. If you were part of my support team and I’d been seeing a counselor for almost two years, why wouldn’t you know who Casey is?

Depression is no joke and should not be taken lightly. At this stage, love is the most essential tool you have at your disposal. When I can feel your love and care, it helps break the hold depression has on me. Add that to the tools I’m receiving from my counselor, and things will move in the right direction.

* * *

ACCEPTANCE

Acceptance, as defined by Merriam-Webster, is “the act of accepting something or someone; the fact of being accepted.” Note that nowhere in this definition does it state that acceptance means everything is okay.

Acceptance signifies acknowledging that “it is what it is,” and there’s nothing I can do about it. To this day, when I think about certain loved ones who have passed away, I cry. The emotions are overwhelming; I feel a pounding in my chest and grieve all over again.

The “Five Stages of Grief” is not akin to running a four-hundred-meter dash. You don’t merely begin at the starting line and run until you cross the finish line. No, we oscillate within this healing process, sometimes even between stages. You may have crossed off denial and anger but find yourself reverting to denial while bargaining. The process starts anew.

So, even though I’ve reached acceptance, it doesn’t mean the grieving is “over.” As part of a support team, your goal should be to be there for one another as needed.

Chapter 10: The Second of the Three Ds: Divorce

Unlike death, divorce is a decision made by at least one party. Divorce is difficult because it declares that, for whatever reason or reasons, the marriage is not worth saving, maintaining, or fighting for.

I’m no angel—I’ve never claimed to be. I wasn’t born with angel wings already attached. I accept full responsibility for my part in the failure of my two marriages. However, neither were my ex-wives angels.

A common misconception many people hold is that the other individual must be a terrible person. Well, I can't subscribe to that view, and if you are a divorcee and honest with yourself, your ex probably wasn't that bad either. Exceptions exist, of course, such as cases involving abuse or addiction.

My ex-wives were beautiful, strong, independent, intelligent, and loving women. At one point, we failed the "for worse" test.

Marriage: More Than a Social Contract

Marriage is an incredible institution! Out of my forty-seven years of life, I've been married for nearly twenty-three. To say that marriage is all sunshine and daisies would be a bald-faced lie.

Marriage is HARD. It's an adjustment of two lives with the mutual intent of blending, although sometimes it feels more like a collision than a merger.

The Ultimate Social Experiment

We're akin to lab rats in the experiment of marriage. The first part of our lives is spent under our parents' guidance, adhering to specific rules for our safety and development. At a certain point, we wish to establish our rules.

So, we strike out on our own, living "perfect" lives—until we meet that special someone. Now, we must reset our rules because we're no longer single individuals: we're a couple.

Although we've exchanged vows before God and witnesses, we're not truly prepared for marriage until we recognize that our previous rules are no longer applicable. Both parties must create new rules together. That moment marks genuine maturity and readiness for a successful marriage.

The Complexity of Life

Life, however, isn't that simple. For some, rules are meant to be broken. Poor decisions can lead to an unharmonious union.

I've been unfaithful and engaged in extramarital relationships, which led to the demise of our marriage. Even when this betrayal came to light, we stayed married and pick up the pieces—at least, that was the plan.

Fellas, when we breach trust with our wives, we've damaged the most critical aspect of our relationship. Women will tolerate a lack of money if your hustle is solid. Men are no different. Infidelity is painful for everyone involved. In fact, we men might even handle it worse than women.

I had a girlfriend whom I deeply loved, and she cheated on me. What compounded the pain was that I knew the guy involved. I felt shattered and didn't want to talk or be around her. I

insisted she get medical tests, and even after she received an “all clear,” I still couldn’t bear to be with her—despite loving her.

Imagine experiencing such betrayal with someone you live with, someone to whom you’ve committed your life. That, I believe, is the ultimate test of “for worse.”

When life’s complexities arise, decisions must be made. Do we stay together and attempt to mend what’s broken? Do we separate and try to move on? Or do we work on resolving issues even if we’ve opted for separate lives? The imperative to fix the relationship remains; otherwise, we risk repeating the same mistakes.

There’s no room for dilly-dallying; resolve the issues as they appear to avoid a pile-up of problems that will eventually doom the marriage.

What Are Marriage Killers?

According to a September 18, 2018, article by Shellie Warren on Marriage.com, the ten most common reasons for divorce are:

1. Infidelity
2. Money
3. Lack of Communication
4. Constant Arguing
5. Weight Gain
6. Unrealistic Expectations
7. Lack of Intimacy
8. Lack of Equality
9. Unpreparedness for Marriage
10. Abuse

For more information, I suggest visiting Marriage.com.

How to Fix It

Your marriage isn’t over until it’s over. Several effective methods can save a marriage, but the linchpin is personal responsibility and diligent effort.

First and foremost, God needs to be at the center of your marriage. Without divine guidance, we can accomplish nothing. Prayer, attending services, and faith-based counseling for both partners are crucial steps to healing.

For further guidance, consider self-help books like “The Love Dare” by Eric Wilson. Initially, a devotional for one partner, the book has evolved into a series beneficial for couples and families alike.

Don’t let problems fester. Your marriage is too valuable to be abandoned or neglected.

So, here are Seven Strong Steps to Stop a Divorce, according to Susan Heitler, Ph.D., as written for Psychology Today.¹

1. Prepare for Action

Don’t let it ride. Failing to plan is planning to fail. Create an action plan to save your marriage.

2. Smother the Urge to Play the Victim

Skip the “poor me” and switch to “proud me.” There are a myriad of reasons you are married. Remind yourself of your outstanding qualities. Be the vibrant, enjoyable person you truly are. Don’t boast about your efforts; let your actions speak for themselves.

3. Clarify What You Need to Change

We often tell our spouses what we dislike about them. Create a list of these points, share it with your spouse for verification, and then embark on a personal journey to identify the roots of these behaviors. Your upbringing—whether in a two-parent or single-parent home—could influence your actions. Once realized, work to fix these foundational issues.

4. Look Your Best

When vying for someone’s affection, we go the extra mile. Apply the same effort in saving your marriage. Ladies, apply a little makeup; men, groom yourselves. A few new outfits can refresh your appearance and boost your self-esteem.

5. Clean Up Old Hurts

This step isn’t easy. Create a list of marital hurts, angers, and resentments with your spouse. Go through each item to identify mistakes, miscommunications, and misunderstandings. Apologize and plan to do better in the future.

6. Believe in Yourself

Self-love is key. If you want your spouse to love you, you must first love yourself. For those who struggle with this, Dr. Heitler recommends a technique called “temporal tapping” to aid in reprogramming your mindset.

7. Learn Essential Skills for Marriage

Marriage isn't about perfection; it's about working with our individual flaws. Unfortunately, there's no college course titled "Marriage 101." We learn by trial and error. Now that you're aware of these skills, you have two options: ignore them or start the learning process.

Divorce doesn't have to be the inevitable outcome, though it may unfortunately be the end result for some.

Things to Think About

Sometimes divorce will occur, irrespective of the number of tools we employ, counselors we consult, flowers we send, or conversations we engage in.

I grappled with these elements, and the harder I tried to salvage our marriage, the more difficulties arose.

One day, while visiting my brother John, I found myself tearful over my marital woes. John listened patiently as I poured out my concerns.

After listening for about thirty minutes, John posed a series of questions.

John: Does God show favoritism?

Me: (I knew John was referring to Romans 2:11, which in the King James Version states, "For there is no respect of persons with God.") So, I replied, "No."

John: Whom does God answer when two people pray for different outcomes in the same situation?

Me: He answers neither, as He shows no favoritism.

John: Have you ever considered that perhaps you and your wife are not praying for the same thing?

Me: [Stunned silence]

The thought had never crossed my mind that our marriage might be beyond repair. I spent the next several days contemplating that last question.

Eventually, my wife and I had a crucial conversation and agreed that it was best to proceed separately. Nevertheless, it was a long and challenging journey.

My Advice

If you and your spouse can resolve matters without attorneys, then do so. Coming to an agreement and filing for a dissolution of marriage is much simpler than undergoing a divorce.

The key to either dissolving or divorcing lies in reaching an agreement. There will be give-and-take from both parties. If one person opts only to take, the process becomes lengthy

and costly. This process can consume both parties; not only will your marriage end, but your livelihood could be severely compromised as well.

If children are involved in the divorce, don't place them in the middle. They aren't playing cards, sources of income, or tools for vengeance against the other parent. They are the future.

Our children adopt behaviors from us. So, men, treat your women properly, even if they are currently challenging. And women, treat your men with respect—perhaps even more than they deserve. As your children observe, you shape their understanding of how to behave and react as adults. Do them and yourselves a favor: demonstrate grace and civility, even when disagreements make life challenging.

If both of you are at each other's throats during this process, your children will take sides, which benefits no one.

As a father, I fought for my children and had custody of them. Men, if you want your children, fight for them. Don't automatically assume that the court will award custody to the mother, leaving you paying child support for the next eighteen years.

Conclusion

Although our marriages may fail, we are not failures. You loved this woman; you married her; you had children with her. There's no reason you can't maintain a cordial—if not friendly—relationship, especially when children are involved.

Divorce doesn't signify the end of life with that person. That individual remains your children's mother or father, with an ongoing role in their lives. You have a duty to instill respect for the other parent in your children.

1. Psychology Today: 7 Strong Steps to Stop a Divorce

Chapter 11: Desertion: The Final "D"

The last of the Three Ds is desertion, alternatively termed abandonment, dereliction, or forsaking. Regardless of the label or form, there are two primary reasons desertion is invoked to end a marriage: safety and cowardice.

Safety First

If a person's safety is at risk, exiting the relationship by any means necessary is imperative. There is never a justification for domestic abuse. The instant violence enters the equation; the marriage should be considered over. This doesn't mean arguments, disagreements, or heated conversations won't occur; I'm specifically addressing physical and mental abuse. According to Wikipedia, physical abuse is "any intentional act causing injury or trauma to another person."

Changing Gender Dynamics in Abuse

In days past, the focus was often on men who raised their hands to women. However, today's reality shows a rising number of victimized men. Regrettably, men generally don't report abuse, fearing it will diminish their perceived masculinity. Let me clarify unequivocally: any form of domestic abuse is unacceptable, regardless of who commits it or in what form it manifests.

Personal Lessons on Handling Conflict

My parents taught me the mantra, "Be the man." That means when a situation becomes volatile, I walk away. I've learned that when things escalate, it's prudent to call the police. I am no less a man for doing so.

In one of my relationships, a heated conversation turned dangerous when a glass jar full of coins was hurled at me as I descended the stairs. The jar shattered above my head, raining down change and shards of glass. While angry, I exercised restraint. Retaliating would have only worsened the situation and likely resulted in my arrest. Instead, I dialed 911.

A Call to Men: Protect Yourself

By the time law enforcement arrived, the atmosphere had calmed significantly. My partner had started cleaning up, and I met the officers at the door. From this experience, I learned men should not hesitate to contact the authorities; we are not automatically assumed to be the aggressors. Police are there for our protection, just as they are for women.

But immediate change is imperative when either person feels that their only recourse is more abuse. I know individuals who have been assaulted with baseball bats, frying pans, and television remotes. Their spouses have even hospitalized some. I know a woman who fired a gun at her daughter's boyfriend. These incidents are not mere stories; they are happening. When your life is at stake, leave.

In some situations, departure under cover of darkness may be advisable for your safety. Lingering for a conversation about divorce might only exacerbate the situation.

Cowardice as Another Form of Desertion

The other cause of desertion is cowardice. As previously mentioned, marriage is work. Like any job, there will be times when you don't feel like working. That doesn't mean you should quit.

Consider a couple experiencing marital difficulties. They argued, but divorce was never part of their dialogue. One evening, the husband left for a midweek church service at seven o'clock while his under-the-weather wife stayed home. He returned at nine o'clock to discover she had moved out. In less than two and a half hours, she had emptied the house of all her belongings. And when I say, "her belongings," I mean she took everything she had ever purchased during their marriage—right down to the carpet padding and wall plates for light switches and electrical outlets.

In another example, a couple couldn't come to a final agreement on their divorce. After six months of negotiation, the wife planned a weekend getaway with their children—only she had no intention of returning. She had already filed for divorce a month prior and updated her address with the court the day before her departure.

These actions represent forms of cowardice. Neither party was willing to have the tough conversations necessary for a graceful exit. From the outside looking in, these men were not violent, so abuse was not the issue. The crux of the problem was the immaturity of all parties involved.

There comes a time when men must “put on your big-boy pants,” and women must “put on their big-girl panties.” Even if the conversation is awkward, if you need to leave, that's your prerogative. But avoiding the conversation is a sign of immaturity, irrespective of age.

Fortunately, the men in these scenarios had robust support systems, which isn't the case for everyone. Desertion is unnecessary when there's no threat of abuse. If the marriage is faltering, talk it out and find an equitable solution—don't just walk away.

Chapter 12: Embracing Singlehood Again

No matter which of the “Three Ds” brought your marriage to an end—divorce, death, or desertion—the result is the same: you're single again. The upside is that you now have memories, experiences, and a wealth of new perspectives about relationships.

The lives we build with our spouses position us differently from our earlier single days. You may have accumulated capital, established a home, or even have children. These factors influence your thoughts about the future, heightening your awareness of life and responsibilities. The familiar saying “To whom much is given, much is required” holds true, especially concerning insight.

Self-Reflection and Life's Cycle

When I found myself single again, significant factors differentiated my current state from my past: I had children, a mortgage to manage, and a career to navigate. Moreover, I had to think intensively and frequently about my identity.

We must consider who we are today versus who we thought we were in our earlier years. Decisions we made twenty years ago aren't necessarily the choices we'd make today. Our viewpoints have evolved because of our experiences, warranting self-examination to be truly honest with ourselves.

At this life stage, we should revisit this book's starting point: healing from the Three Ds and rediscovering single satisfaction. We need to identify our present selves and determine our current desires.

Life may seem like an ever-forward journey, but it can also resemble a giant wheel. Although you might find yourself in familiar situations, those points offer new perspectives—indicative of your life’s momentum.

Personal Anecdote: A Love Story Full Circle

I met my wife over thirty years ago, and she was outstanding. However, my shyness led me to love her from a distance. We sang together in a community gospel choir. Life circumstances kept us apart—births, other relationships, and even my stint in the United States Air Force. Despite these separations, I never missed sending her birthday wishes because we were friends.

Life has a way of bringing us full circle. After my divorce, when I had attained “single and satisfied” status and clarified what I wanted, I reconnected with the woman who would become my wife.

The Choice to Remain Single

However, it’s worth noting that some people opt to stay single after marriage; there’s nothing wrong with that. My grandfather, for example, lived over twenty years after my grandmother’s passing, genuinely single and satisfied. Family and a supportive community surrounded him, and he lived life on his terms.

In Closing

Life is worth living, and regardless of the path you choose, prioritize your relationship with God. Believe that your future will be brighter than your past.

I pray this book assists you in reaching that brighter future. If you haven’t yet established a relationship with God, you should. Repeat this prayer to begin your spiritual journey:

“Dear Lord, I am a sinner. Please forgive me of my sins. I believe you sent your son, Jesus, to die for my sins and that he was raised from the dead. I invite you into my heart. From today forward, my life is yours. Thank you for your saving grace.”

If you genuinely believe, then you are saved. Find a Bible-believing church and deepen your relationship with Jesus.

The Holy Spirit is a gift—believe it and receive it.

I love you all!

Establishing Glory 3

The Marriage Handbook

Dedication

I'd like to dedicate this book, first and foremost, to God. This would not have been possible without His inspiration, leadership, and guidance.

And to my wife: life wouldn't be the same without you. I love you to life!

Preface

When I first began to ponder the Marriage Handbook, I was looking at life retrospectively and considering all the ways I had been a good husband. I started compiling a list of the many disagreements we've had, showing how she was wrong, and I was right. Let me tell you, I have some doozies.

The crazy part about examining your life is that the longer the spotlight shines inward, the more flaws and imperfections within you are revealed. As I delved into the bullet points of my notes, I saw that there were moments when I was entirely right, and my feelings and point of view were justified. But there were also moments when I was being unreasonable and, quite honestly, an idiot.

There are so many self-help books out there that you may ask, "Who needs another one?" But I'm not writing this book for you; I'm writing it for me.

The deeper my introspective search went, the more I found that many of the lessons I failed today were like those I failed yesterday. In speaking with others, I found they are failing many of the same lessons repeatedly, as well.

To give a brief history, I married on August 15, 1994. So, as of today (June 20, 2019), I have been married for twenty-four years, ten months, and five days. The problem is that I've been divorced twice since then and am currently in my third marriage.

My first marriage lasted just over one year; my second, over twenty-one years. My current wife and I are celebrating one year, seven months, and nine days—but who's counting?

In these past twenty-four years, I have been part of two blended families, been a father to almost forty children, experienced five failed or miscarried pregnancies, been laid off three times, owned four businesses, lost my mother and grandmother, attempted suicide, and become an author-publisher, to name a few things. Trust me, the stories I will share will genuinely cause you to think long and hard about this thing called "marriage."

One key to marriage is balance. When I began to pen this manuscript, I knew we needed to start with this question: "Where do we find this balance?"

The answer was simple: The key to balance in marriage starts at the altar. It begins with the commitment we voice to one another in our vows. So, we're going to take an in-depth look at these vows and understand the power that these simple words hold, not only for our lives but also for everyone connected to us.

Let's get started.

Chapter 1: I Take Thee To Be My Wedded

When it comes to critical points in the timeline of relationships that lead to marriage, three come to mind: the proposal, the vows, and the honeymoon.

From a man's perspective, the proposal is important because this is when he officially turns in his "Player's Card." He has made a conscious decision to be with this one woman for the rest of his life and is willing to make this commitment legal.

From a woman's perspective, this special moment occurs when her player's card is played, and she decides to be with this one man for the rest of her life, willing to make this legal commitment. (Sounds familiar, doesn't it?)

What makes this moment critical is not merely the investment in the ring, preparing the "perfect moment," getting down on one knee, or "popping the question." This moment is monumental because he declares that no one else matters except his chosen one.

I could be mistaken, but for the future bride, the monumental moment is likely centered more on the responses to the proposal and the subsequent announcement. The bent knee, the awaited question, and even the ring give her a warm and exciting sense of being special and valued. The announcement to family and friends adds to her sense of worth.

For many men, this is a moment of gravity, one of the most staggering changes they will ever make in their lives. There can be a certain sense of hesitation, if only for a moment or two. Alternatively, this hesitation might come after the proposal, when he experiences a maze of thoughts about the enormity of everything, intertwined with anticipation of the new adventure ahead.

Some men decide to propose only after seriously pondering whom they want to spend their lives with. Before settling on "the one," both men and women have spent time with others, each special in their unique ways. Admittedly, some attractions can be relatively shallow: one might be a better kisser, another looks particularly good in jeans, his complexion is rugged, or her eyes are captivating.

On the other hand, more serious matters require consideration: health issues, children in the package, adult children lingering, work ethic observed, and distance as a factor. Everything about the potential life mate is part of the picture.

Then arise the matters of disagreements in those relationships. Every couple has them, but how intense do the conflicts become? What kinds of issues ignite these conflicts? How long do these disputes last?

One man had two teenage boys, and the special woman in his life had two as well. She claimed he was too soft on his boys, raising them to be weak. Conversely, he felt her boys were too independent because she worked excessively. This disagreement flared up repeatedly, begging many questions.

Another example: both individuals have children but live on opposite sides of the same city. As is the woman, the man is content with his children's progress in their respective schools. Each child has good grades and many friends. She insists they will live on her side of town when they combine households, even though they never discussed marriage. He counters that since he already owns a house, they can merge families there. Neither would budge, prioritizing their children. This discussion lasted weeks and sometimes escalated intensely.

Then there was the couple who worked in separate locations but for the same employer. They would FaceTime each other while preparing for work and while driving to and from work. They would email, text, and instant message each other throughout the workday. They would regularly have lunch together. Their issue arose when the man didn't want to spend time with the woman in the evenings. He figured they'd been together all day and wanted some space. She, however, wanted to spend those evenings together. This disagreement regarding "time spent" continued for several weeks, and this tension was more like a smoldering cigarette threatening to ignite a brush fire!

The point is, each person desires or enjoys something that makes the other uncomfortable. Finding a balance can be a significant challenge.

Here, the pronoun "I" becomes central. This single-letter word is perhaps the most powerful in the commitment ceremony and the entire relationship. Before we can commit, we must know who we truly are!

For men, this self-awareness is challenging. It's easy to focus on what the woman brings: her attributes, likes, needs, dislikes, and expendabilities. We quickly see others' greatness or flaws. However, turning that light onto ourselves is an entirely different matter.

The most significant lies we tell are to ourselves. We're aware of our shortcomings, which we often disregard or conceal. We know our strengths and emphasize them.

But if I don't know who I am, how can I comprehend what becoming a husband means? How can I lead a wife—and possibly a family—when I don't even know where I'm going, let alone how to get there? Should I just wing it, hoping and praying for a good life?

Is it practical to embark on this new journey with some lofty but vague notion of us being a power-couple like Jay-Z and Beyoncé or Alex Rodriguez and Jennifer Lopez, when I haven't taken the time to understand myself through God's guidance?

No, sir, and no, ma'am!

Self-discovery begins with "why" and ends with "what."

Men, ask yourselves why you love this woman and want to propose. Know yourselves well enough to understand what makes you the men you are.

Women, inquire what you see in this man that will make life a memorable journey. What character traits does he bring into the relationship that will help you grow and dream? Again, know yourself well enough to believe you can add value to his life.

Genuine self-assessment is even more crucial than focusing on the other person's attributes or flaws.

I often tell people that I recognize my shortcomings, admit my imperfections, and acknowledge that I can be challenging to deal with. While I can be loving, kind, and caring, I'm fully aware that I can also be a jerk—an understanding my wife shares and for which I've apologized more than once. This book isn't written because I'm a paragon of marital perfection. No, I'm writing this book because I've made mistakes in marriage and have been divorced twice. Our failings weren't solely "her fault."

Before diving into the institution of marriage, it's vital to understand that it starts with "me" and ends with "we."

After completing our self-assessments, we are better positioned to establish mutual goals. What once were individual aspirations now transform into a partnership of purpose. Both parties should seek ways to collaborate in areas of strength and growth, as intentionally as they would for their own personal goals.

Marriage is a partnership. That's why we both utter the same vows.

Chapter 2: To Have And To Hold

Did you know that...

- Every thirteen seconds, a divorce occurs in America.
- Nine divorces take place in the time it takes for a couple to recite their wedding vows (two minutes).
- Almost fifty percent of all marriages in the United States will end in divorce or separation.

Is this crazy information to attach to a book about marriage?

In reality, many people are infatuated with the idea of marriage rather than with the institution itself. When some individuals hear the term "institution," they might think of the film "One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest," starring Jack Nicholson. Given the statistics, it may appear marriage could be compared to mental health—hopefully more in jest than seriously.

However, when we enter marriage with eyes wide open, we stand a better chance of falling on the positive side of these statistics.

As I began contemplating this chapter, I realized I needed to define "have" and "hold." The more I pondered these simple words, the more expansive their meanings became.

To Have

Here are a few definitions for “have”:

- To hold or maintain as a possession, privilege, or entitlement.
- To feel an obligation with regard to.
- To experience, especially by submitting to, undergoing, or suffering.

Most often, when we use the word “have,” we refer to the first definition related to possession. Upon taking our vows, we believe we now possess a spouse: “She is my wife” or “He is my husband.” And to be fair, there’s a level of truth to this perspective.

However, I’d like to shift the focus to the latter definition, emphasizing submission, undergoing experiences, and even enduring suffering. Using this framework, we are not the possessors in the marriage; instead, we are possessed—quite the opposite of the standard view.

Our entitlement mentality leads us to believe we’ve reached the pinnacle of relationship theory simply by getting married. Singles’ events are behind us; dating is over. We now expect invitations to events and socials for married couples. Our “player’s cards” are turned in, and we think we’re on the road to marital bliss. Unfortunately, this is far from the truth.

Take my daily routine, for example. I used to arrive at work at the same time every day. My mornings typically included grabbing coffee and a breakfast sandwich before heading to the elevator en route to my office. I would greet familiar faces in the elevator.

However, one morning, I wore my wedding ring and found only one woman in the elevator. Her reaction stunned me. After my usual greeting, she asked for my name and where I worked, claiming she’d never seen me before. This was odd because I’d ridden the elevator with her many times, even as recently as the day before. The sole difference was the presence of my ring.

Had my wedding ring veiled my persona? Had it rendered me faceless? Had its presence sent her some unspoken message?

Some believe that interacting with people of different marital statuses is taboo—a single woman conversing with a married man must be scandalous. So, even if she engages him daily in elevator small talk, she should pretend not to see him. She should remain entirely detached.

In this specific example, the opposite seems to be true. The woman knowingly interacted with a married man. Did the ring on his finger open doors? Did his marital status function as a green light for a fleeting encounter with no commitment or longevity? Is this how extramarital relationships begin?

Should people of different marital statuses interact with each other?

Before addressing this question, let's examine another example.

A couple experiencing marital challenges sought advice from another couple who appeared to have a successful marriage. The time spent was mutually beneficial. However, the husband from the troubled marriage (Husband A) and the wife from the stable marriage (Wife B) struck up a friendship outside of the couples' therapy. Though nothing inappropriate occurred, Wife A grew suspicious.

This raises a new question: "Should married individuals engage with people of the opposite sex when their spouses aren't present?"

There are culturally and socially acceptable ways for individuals to interact. Conversely, some interactions are deemed inappropriate. For example, married people are considered out-of-bounds when maintaining friendships with people of the opposite sex, particularly when meeting or talking on the phone without their spouse.

The underlying theme remains consistent: the contrast between owning the marriage and being enslaved by it. In the institution of marriage, spouses choose to serve each other's welfare mutually, which demands effort.

Contrary to fairy-tale narratives, marriage is not about riding off into the sunset or living happily ever after. Instead, it is a conscious, purposeful commitment requiring a deliberate and sometimes grueling effort to achieve short-term, even daily, goals for a successful life together.

For example, one of my objectives is to make my wife smile daily through intentional actions. The ultimate goal is her smile. While it may seem rudimentary, life's complexities make a simple smile powerful. Although I am not always successful, failure does not deter my attempts the following day.

To Hold

Here are a few definitions for "hold":

- To grasp, carry, or support with one's arms or hands.
- To remain secure, intact, or in position without breaking or giving way.
- To keep or reserve for someone.

When we contemplate the phrase "to hold," we generally focus on the first definition: mutual support. But the concept extends beyond mere support.

During the dating phase, we gravitate toward the third definition—reserving or keeping for someone—as we anticipate life with our future spouse.

Upon exchanging rings, we commit to a role that we must maintain without fail—that of a husband or wife. Why? Because there are entities wishing to separate "what God hath joined

together,” according to the King James Version of the Bible. The ironic aspect is that often, the enemy threatening the marriage is oneself.

As a survivor of two failed marriages, I understand we can sometimes be our own worst enemies in matrimony. Our habits can foster a climate of self-destruction that only divine intervention and a loving spouse can mitigate.

But what lies at the core of these destructive patterns? Why do they manifest?

How often have we heard or said, “I’m not used to this; we’ve only been married for [insert number of years]?” Or “I’m still learning; give me a chance.”

I know a man who has been married for over thirty years and claims he is “still learning” how to cook. Every time he says this, I can’t help but laugh. It’s far from the truth. Everyone in his circle knows he will never learn to cook; it’s simply not a priority for him. He lacks the requisite interest for change.

Once upon a time, his spouse would criticize him for not contributing to meal preparation. But then she recognized that he was willing to clear the table and wash dishes while he might not be cooking. His contribution differed from her expectations, but it was a contribution nonetheless.

We can perpetuate self-deceptions, convincing ourselves that “someday” we’ll improve. Yet such delusions can spell the end of our marriages.

So, what other habits undermine our marriages?

One area I’m working on is effective communication with my spouse. At face value, you might question how sharing information can be destructive. Well, it’s not the content of the information that’s the issue—it’s the misunderstanding it can cause.

For example, as an author and publisher, my office is in my home. On some days, my wife also works from home. However, sharing a physical space doesn’t mean we are both “at home”; in reality, we are “at work.”

Take today, for instance. Our grandchild is visiting. My wife reminded me that WE are babysitting, even though I had previously told her that today would be focused on work. So, I found myself having to cease work: first for a breakfast she prepared (which was excellent, by the way), then for babysitting, and later for some paperwork she needed. Each interruption led to work stoppages. What’s amusing is that she apologizes for each interruption.

The dilemma arises if I tell her I need space or insist she act like I’m not present. But if I vent through writing—as I’m doing now—I might also create tension. Bottling up emotions usually backfires, surfacing later in unrelated conversations. Failing to communicate isn’t a “them” problem; it’s a “me” problem.

And what does this have to do with “to hold”?

It boils down to feeling—and being—secure in our marriages. When we avoid frank discussions out of fear or discomfort, we forfeit moments of connection and security. We may be undermining our relationships and setting ourselves up for external temptations. Alternatively, pent-up hostilities can prevent us from sharing genuine concerns, further eroding the marital bond.

The truth is, the most significant moments a couple can share occur after we’ve made amends and hashed out our differences. It’s time for “make-up sex.” Can I get an Amen?

That’s when we truly get to hold each other.

But seriously, many children have been conceived in the aftermath of life’s storms. These moments are often among the most pivotal and foundational in our families.

To strengthen our marriages, we must learn how to hold them properly.

Chapter 3: From This Day Forward

Let’s begin with a few definitions of the word “forward”:

- In the direction that one is facing or traveling; toward the front.
- Onward so as to make progress; toward a successful conclusion.
- Toward the future; ahead in time.
- An attacking player in basketball, hockey, or other sports.
- Help to advance something; promote.

As we examine these definitions and explore how each applies to marriage vows, we’ll gain a broader view of the phrase “from this day forward.”

One of the first challenges is achieving clarity about our objectives in our new life as a couple. Beyond being faithful, and as the Bible tells us to “be fruitful and multiply,” what is the purpose of marriage? What is our union’s goal? Why are we doing this?

My question to couples is simple: after the honeymoon phase, why are we getting married, and what does the future genuinely hold for us as a union?

We’ve all known couples who chose to marry but ended up in divorce court. The reasons may vary, but one could be failing to establish shared objectives.

People often get so caught up in the emotional highs of marital bliss that they don’t take the time to consider their plans and purposes for their life together.

The first definition above discusses the direction we are facing or traveling. Critical questions arise: Are you financially secure? Do you own a house? Do you have reliable transportation? Is your bank account balance more than one hundred dollars? Are you racking up overdraft fees? Is your employment stable? Can you support more than just yourself? If you fall short on these, how committed are you to achieving these objectives?

Regrettably, I learned poor money management from my parents. We weren't wealthy, but we were comfortable. Yet, we occasionally dealt with utility shutoff notices. When I began living independently, I repeated the behaviors I'd observed growing up. I would splurge on frivolous items without thinking about my responsibilities.

When I decided to marry, I hadn't considered my poor financial habits, but that was where I was moving and where I would lead my family. I am much better today because I changed directions and looked "forward."

Then, there's the definition that discusses "a successful conclusion." This implies that we need to think not just about our marriage's present state but also about its future. My family has been blessed with longevity—my grandfather lived to be ninety-eight and was self-sufficient until the end. But did he, when deciding to marry, consider what the end of that commitment would look like?

What were his thoughts when he moved from the "holler" in West Virginia to the "big city" of Columbus, Ohio? Did he ever envision that his sons would fight for the country? Could he have imagined that he would see over one hundred direct descendants across four generations from his marriage to one woman?

All these things are verifiably true. But would any of this align with what my grandfather considered the result of a successful marriage?

This leads us to the following definition, which incorporates the phrase "toward the future." This concept differs from the previous one because the future is unending. This is particularly challenging for couples, especially since we often focus on the past. A blend of beliefs, values, and experiences shapes our perspective. What we were taught as children, life experiences, and core values all contribute to who we are and who we will become.

Each day offers new experiences and perspectives that shape us. As we glean lessons from our past, we continue to evolve. Our identity is constantly emerging, even when we resist change or new experiences.

The key to benefiting from our experiences lies in the word "willingness"—a willingness to live in the moment. In a Psychology Today article entitled "The Art of Now: Six Steps to Living in the Moment" by Jay Dixit (Psychology Today Article), we find steps that I firmly believe will strengthen and enhance our marriages:

- To improve your performance, stop thinking about it (unselfconsciousness). We must stop overthinking. Constant rumination on past actions or future possibilities only brings anxiety

and decreases our efficacy. Living in the moment requires setting aside self-consciousness. We need to focus on the present and be aware of our surroundings. Doing so will help reduce anxiety and allow us to savor the moment.

- To avoid worrying about the future, focus on the present (savoring). Dixit writes, “Often, we’re so trapped in thoughts of the future or the past that we forget to experience—let alone enjoy—what’s happening right now.” We compare our current situation with the past, failing to appreciate the present. The quality of today’s coffee doesn’t need to compete with last week’s; it should be enjoyed for what it is.

- If you want a future with your significant other, inhabit the present (breathe). Being mindful of the moment means we must “inhabit the present.” Deep breathing allows us to realize our current state and take control of the moment, rather than being controlled by it. This deep, relaxing breath serves as a psychological “chill pill,” enabling us to truly inhabit the moment.

- To make the most of your time, lose track of it (flow). When I lived in Miami Beach, Florida, tourists were easy to spot because they were always rushing. With limited time, they tried to cram in as much as possible, missing the relaxation that the pace of life in Miami offers.

When you stop looking at your watch and get into the flow, your entire outlook changes. Trying to see everything Miami offers robs you of enjoying what you do see. You have to relax and go with the flow. Let yourself be filled with each moment and let the flow carry you on to the next.

Making the most of each moment allows us to experience the next fully.

- If something bothers you, move toward rather than away from it (acceptance). The fight-or-flight response isn’t the answer to life’s irritations.

The more we focus on or internalize our problems, the greater they become and the less likely we are to resolve them. The battle automatically sways in favor of the problem.

Acceptance says, “Thanks, problem, for coming. I have a guesthouse prepared for you. You can visit for a short while, but you can’t stay.”

Embrace your problem and allow it to flow through you. Ignore a problem, and it will move from the guesthouse and take up residence in your life.

- Know that you don’t know (engagement). Sometimes, my wife says that we discussed something and that I agreed or said this or that. The problem is that I have no recollection of the discussion and, indeed, not what I said. Unfortunately, that is because I may have been there for the conversation, but I was not in the conversation. My mind was nowhere near the moment. I had checked out. The term “engagement” is about being in the moment.

Our thoughts may sometimes wander, but we must consciously rein them back in. Stay focused on anything new or different about those with you and what they are doing or saying. Choose to appreciate and be empathetic with others and their interests. This will be your special tool to keep you in the moment and allow you to stay engaged.

We may miss each day's blessing and value when we cannot stay focused.

"Let the morning bring me word of your unfailing love, for I have put my trust in you. Show me the way I should go, for to you, I entrust my life."

Psalm 143:8 NIV

"It is because of the Lord's loving kindnesses that we are not consumed, because His [tender] compassions never fail. They are new every morning; great and beyond measure is Your faithfulness."

Lamentations 3:22-23 AMP

One way of moving beyond yesterday and the grip of the past is to commit to keeping our focus on the promising expression "from this day forward." We begin focusing our thoughts on God and His love for us every day.

That kind of personal posture of being mindful of how He moves on our behalf will birth within us the flow of His love and care that will frame our responses and our entire relationship with our spouse.

Chapter 4: For Better, For Worse

Let's focus on the message of Ephesians 5:22-33 from The Message Bible for a moment.

Wives, understand and support your husbands in ways that show your support for Christ. The husband provides leadership to his wife the way Christ does to his church, not by domineering but by cherishing. So just as the church submits to Christ as he exercises such leadership, wives should likewise submit to their husbands.

Husbands, go all out in your love for your wives, exactly as Christ did for the church—a love marked by giving, not getting. Christ's love makes the church whole. His words evoke her beauty. Everything he does and says is designed to bring the best out of her, dressing her in dazzling white silk, radiant with holiness. And that is how husbands ought to love their wives. They're really doing themselves a favor—since they're already "one" in marriage.

No one abuses his own body, does he? No, he feeds and pampers it. That's how Christ treats us, the church, since we are part of his body. And this is why a man leaves father and mother and cherishes his wife. No longer two, they become "one flesh." This is a huge mystery, and I don't pretend to understand it all. What is clearest to me is the way Christ treats the church. And this provides a good picture of how each husband is to treat his wife, loving himself in loving her, and how each wife is to honor her husband.

These verses are some of the most misconstrued words in scripture.

So, while I will not start being “preachy,” I want us to take time to look at the background of what the Apostle Paul is saying.

Did you notice words like support, leadership, cherishing, giving, beauty, and, of course, love to describe the nature of our relationship as husband and wife? The tone of this passage is that we are not to “lord it over” one another, but to serve each other. Selflessness is the very essence of loving another.

Often people want to point to the phrase about women “submitting to their husbands” and start shouting “chauvinism!” But nothing could be further from the truth. This is about selflessness, focusing on the husband to serve at his side with the purpose of moving him forward toward the responsibilities that rest on him.

Those responsibilities, if you read on, are focused on treating his wife with the selflessness modeled after Christ, who gave Himself lovingly for His bride, the Church.

We are admonished to focus on each other and selflessly be the conduit of grace and strength that allows the other to grow more and more into the person God wants them to be. We are to live in mutual submission to the needs and well-being of the other, just as Christ does for each of us.

These verses, however, do not specifically raise the question of “when.” When are we supposed to do all this loving, cherishing, and supporting? When are we to submit to each other? When it’s convenient and these things all line up like the stars? When it’s inconvenient, are we still supposed to do all of that?

If we get honest about marriage, we know it isn’t all cotton candy and unicorns. Life is hard enough by itself, but when you combine two lives, things can get quite perplexing, complicated, and even scary.

But the answer to “when” is in the model of Jesus. There is no specific “when.” There is only the constant and unlimited, always present and in place selflessness that showers us with the kind of love we are to have with each other.

For Better

My first business, Anointed Ministries, was a computer company that sold and repaired computers, provided website design and consultation, and offered training for everyone from the novice to the advanced user. It was great!

I was a one-man band. I designed and printed my business cards, and everywhere I went, I would leave a card, hoping that someone would pick it up and use our services. Then, one day, someone did.

I had gone to the doctor for an outpatient procedure and gave one of my cards to the attending physician. His unexpected response was an invitation to lunch.

I told my wife about the doctor wanting to have lunch, and we were both uber-excited! This was finally happening! We were going to finally get a customer!

You see, I started Anointed Ministries because I was laid off. I was the “Corporate Training Manager,” and we had just expanded training from an individual location to multiple locations in several states. We had initiated everything from one-on-one coaching to packed classrooms. We were growing and becoming profitable.

Then, I landed my first big contract for over \$100,000. Life was indeed “For Better.”

During this time, I received a raise, and we were finally getting caught up on all our bills. I started paying my tithes faithfully and even started doing more volunteering at our church.

Then, one day, the owner called a meeting with the entire organization. We had to make some changes, and unfortunately, we had to make some staff changes.

It was a very somber moment for everyone, but while I felt terrible for those who would lose their jobs, I was confident I wouldn’t be. My department was growing like wildfire.

Well, take a wild guess who the first person who was called into the office was.

The company was changing direction and had decided that the training program was no longer needed. So, “thank you for your hard work and dedication. Your services are no longer required.”

I was devastated.

Our life just went from better to worse in one moment. How do I tell my wife? How are we going to get our bills paid? How will we survive?

Then, came the “God questions:” How could He let this happen to us? Why did God leave us hanging? I’m paying tithes and volunteering, and this is how God responds?

We get a little sanctimonious at times, don’t we? We blame God for our troubles and forget that He loves us more than we will ever know. And He has a plan for our lives.

Act 2, stage right: Enter my brand-new company and this lunch with my doctor.

I’m dressed for the occasion in business casual attire. We met at a nice restaurant and had a conversation about my new venture. He loved it, but he felt there was a problem. It wasn’t the services and my sales abilities; it was my company name, “Anointed Ministries.”

He said, “It sounds like ‘Have Bible, Will Travel’ and makes no reference to all of this computer work that you do. You have to change your name to get the business that you’re looking for.”

I took his words to heart, closed Anointed Ministries, and started over with “AM Computer Services, Inc.” (As you may have guessed, “AM” stood for “Anointed Ministries,” but I never told anyone that.)

Making a Change

Making this change meant that my marriage had to endure more money spent on a dream while I was collecting unemployment. Right before the layoff, we had caught up on our mortgage, and now we were in arrears again. We had a humble life, and things were super tight. We had those typical arguments about time, money, and everything else.

“For worse” was happening to us.

When things truly got bad, I started thinking about quitting this fantasy of being my own boss and getting a regular job with a steady income and maybe benefits to help my marriage. Even I thought I would “fall on the sword,” take one for the team, and hopefully, one day, I would try again.

“For worse” was getting even worse.

I tell this story because many, if not most, marriages fail because of financial issues. Today, most of us are only one or two paychecks away from poverty. Having a savings plan or emergency money only covers a bill or two for at best a few weeks.

What happens when we go through such circumstances? What happens when we run out of unemployment benefits? What are we supposed to do when “For worse” isn’t just knocking on the door but has moved in and is in the kitchen making sandwiches or sitting on your bed watching TV?

Husbands, we may be aware of and even struggle with our responsibility to be the protectors of our homes, but we may easily miss the fact that our wives are struggling with us. Not only are things happening to us as a family, but these things affect each of us in very personal ways. We have to be understanding enough to acknowledge the pain that our wives and children are going through.

The most significant attribute needed by everyone in the family is understanding. During times of hardship, each spouse is to be mutually concerned about each other’s stress. Together, they must find solutions to cope, share the search for answers, and avoid the remarks that sound uncaring or even like nagging. To keep harping on bills that need to be paid or that little Johnny still needs braces only wears each other down.

Support is a partnership.

When we take on the roles of husband and wife, we step into a partnership agreement that says, “I’ve got your back, no matter what.” That’s easy when we live in “For Better.” But the real challenge comes with “For worse.”

When we married each other, we truly became partners in life, and that life partnership extends into every aspect of living, and there's nothing we can't overcome together.

Shortly after changing my business's name, we landed our first contract, and things turned around for my business, my marriage, and my life, not just because of the money but because of the commitment my wife and I have for each other in every aspect of our life together.

Chapter 5: For Richer, For Poorer: Beyond Money

When 99% of us think about the phrase “for richer, for poorer,” we usually focus on money and financial well-being. But, as with everything else, there are more layers than we often see.

When defined, “rich” refers not only to “having a great deal of money or assets; wealthy” but also has these other definitions:

- Plentiful; abundant.
- Producing a large quantity of something.
- Interesting because full of diversity or complexity.

Along with having wealth in the form of money and assets, we need to have a mixture of the other riches as well.

What does it mean to have a plentiful and abundant marriage?

Think of a Red Velvet cake with its unique texture, bold color, exquisite icing, and flavor. Now, picture a large piece of that cake sitting in front of you. Your eyes are fixated on the plate, your nose is filling with the aroma, and you can barely control the growing anticipation of that first taste.

And then it happens. You bring that waiting fork to your mouth. The flavor is so rich you can barely stand it. Your taste buds are nearly overwhelmed. And you vow nothing will stop you from devouring the entire piece.

Marriages should be every bit as pleasantly overwhelming. Life together is to overflow with richness that you vow you never want to be without.

I have been living that experience, so I want to share with you one way the aroma of love is evidenced in our family.

I was born in August. So, (hold on to your seats) I celebrate my birth for the entire month!

When I first told my wife about my birth-month celebrations, she didn't believe me. I tried to warn her, but some things you need to experience for yourself. Of course, I wanted to know how she wanted to celebrate her birthday in June.

Her reply: "We can just do dinner with some family and friends."

My reply: "Is that it?"

So, when June rolled around, I did as she requested, and we had a lovely party for her. She enjoyed herself, and her celebration ended the day after her party.

Then came July 31!

We went out to eat, and I proclaimed, "Happy Birth Month, Day Zero!"

Her reaction (classic, but with a puzzled expression): "Day Zero? Your birthday month doesn't start until tomorrow!"

My response (with a twinkle in my eye): "Have you ever heard of Christmas Eve?"

And so began the celebration.

We celebrated every single day of the month! We attended outdoor concerts, went to my favorite restaurants, cooked my favorite meals, and the fun was overwhelmingly exhausting!

But the real fun for me was finding something new to do each day. After the 10th day, it started to become a challenge. What could we do today that we haven't already done? How can today be as exciting or more interesting than any of the other days? How can we keep this thing going?

The trick is that, as a team, we had to make this celebration a priority every day. We had to make it unique. And not making an attempt was not an option!

Celebrating Life Together

It was hard working these celebratory events into our daily lives for an entire month! We still went to work every day, the children started back to school, and we didn't miss church. So, my Birth Month celebrations take a toll on us, but it's worth it.

Now, just in case you're thinking I am a self-serving jerk, I'll let you in on a little secret. The real fun for me is giving my family a special time once a year to enjoy something extraordinary together. Sharing this unusual idea with them will not only be memorable for each of us, but we bond together as a family in a unique way.

Our marriages should be like my Happy Birth Month celebrations. Filled with intentional moments as a couple and a family. All of us share the experience of setting aside the routines of life and simply being in the moment.

And of course, I post the shenanigans during this month-long celebration on social media. My friends good-naturedly razz me every year, but hopefully, we will inspire others to celebrate themselves more creatively!

One time, one of my cousins wanted to join us on our excursions. When we live bountifully, people want to be a part of that.

That is a good thing. If no one wants to hang out with us as a couple, then we might want to ask, “Why not?” What are we not doing?

People are naturally drawn to people and things that excite them, motivate them, and cheer them on. So, if my marriage isn’t doing that, then we’re living in a bubble, or we’re doing something wrong.

We are social beings, and we are made to enjoy life together with those around us, and as a couple, we should inspire others with our examples of joy.

Before my wife and I were married, she used to talk about spending time with married couples, going places and enjoying those relationships. I confess, I found that odd. I had not experienced that. Of course, she had been divorced for 20 years.

On the other hand, I had only been recently divorced after being married for 20 years, and married couples didn’t spend time with someone who was divorced.

After people get married and return from their honeymoon, they live their lives within their own space. The non-married friends get pushed to the side. Some activities that they did when they were single are now shelved, pushed off into the corner of life because they are too busy keeping up with the new routine of their new family life, focusing on having a well-balanced married life. There is a natural tendency to shift their social life to other married couples.

Oddly enough, the first argument my wife and I had was about not spending enough time together. It was a rather heated exchange and is memorable because she paused mid-stream and said, “Oh my God, we’re arguing! Okay, your turn!”

Now, this was more frustrating than the argument itself. And being the stubborn guy that I am, I refused to say anything else. Later we laughed about it, but the underlying concern was never addressed.

But her twist in the moment turned down the temperature on what could have turned into a tempest.

Without proper balance in our social life, married life can usher in, as the chapter title notes, one of the “for poorer” times in our lives. Let’s take a second look at this term “poorer.”

Again, when we think of richer and poorer, our thoughts are toward finances. But when we look at the non-money definitions of poor, we can see deeper into our lives:

- Worse than is usual, expected, or desirable; of a low or inferior standard or quality.
- (of a person) considered to be deserving of pity or sympathy.

Balancing Life in Marriage

Those definitions remind us that balancing life as a married couple needs to focus on more than just our finances. While it is true that when we get married, life begins anew for us, but the lives we were living separately now require a genuine blending of our expectations, including such things as our social life and our together time. Without coming together in our perspectives about our future, our finances, our social life, many issues we will encounter together, we will find ourselves poorer rather than richer.

This is a particular risk when people marry before they have had time to really mature. Today, young people live in an extended state of adolescence. Many people in their 20s still have outlooks on life that extend their teen years, focused on having fun and unfocused on responsibility.

And when they marry before they have left an adolescent mindset behind, they lack the skills to shift from being self-focused to living centered on someone else. All too often, they drink the Disney juice of 'Happily Ever After' just to find out (borrowing words from Spike Lee's film, "Malcolm X"), that "You've been had! Ya been took! Ya been hoodwinked! Bamboozled! Led astray! Run amok!" And sadly, because they are too immature, it's probably all too true.

They go to bed one night with the love of their life, the perfect mate that they have "laid down their life for," and they wake up the next morning with the dread of another day when their spouse irritates the life out of them and with a nagging question about why they married him or her.

The idea of a prosperous and happy marriage has faded, and the fog of "poor" has settled in. Where is the love? What happened?

Most times, the problem is that the "love" they have had to this point has been mostly made up of emotion. They have placed so much weight on feeling, and when the feelings are replaced by a less glamorous part of being together, their motivation to blend and bond has begun to drown in the pool of "poor."

Love is not just something we are to feel, but something we must commit to do.

To be fair, many marriages, even for those who are supposed to be mature, fail because one or both stops doing love. To feel love, you have to do love! When the doing disappears, the feelings do as well, and then we start down the path of separation, divorce, and dissolution.

So, what does 'doing love' look like?

1 Corinthians 13 MSG describes love this way:

- Love never gives up.
- Love cares more for others than for self.

- Love doesn't want what it doesn't have.
- Love doesn't strut,
- Doesn't have a swelled head,
- Doesn't force itself on others,
- Isn't always "me first,"
- Doesn't fly off the handle,
- Doesn't keep score of the sins of others,
- Doesn't revel when others grovel,
- Takes pleasure in the flowering of truth,
- Puts up with anything,
- Trusts God always,
- Always looks for the best,
- Never looks back,
- But keeps going to the end.
- Love never dies.

Doing Love: The Key to a Rich Marriage

That's what doing love looks like. When we stop doing any of those things, we are no longer experiencing the riches of genuine love. If any of those "tasks of love" are missing, then love is being forfeited. This is not a list of options, but a single formula. If one element is missing, this love formula is rendered impotent.

When you give up on the person who you love, you've given up love for that person. We must be vigilant, or we'll lose both! A love-filled marriage requires work!

If my spouse is keeping a running tab of how often I've failed her, how many times I didn't keep my word or upset her, then the rest of the list is meaningless. No matter what I do for her, however good it may be, she's still keeping that other list.

If I'm always getting upset about what my spouse is saying or doing, am I helping or hurting our love connection? My self-focus that feeds my rage is obviously not loving toward her, and the rest of that formula no longer enriches her. They are of no value.

That, my friend, is the work we need to do, the effort we need to put into our marriages.

“Poorer” is a state of being, a mindset, or a spirit. We are by nature “poor” because putting someone else ahead of us is unnatural. But there is a rich, new nature that replaces our self-focus with a genuine love that values someone else as more important than yourself.

If we are to overcome the poverty of a marriage and successfully experience a rich relationship, we have to acknowledge the natural self-centeredness that makes our relationship poorer. And no matter who you are, you will have to face and deal with your own personal poverty that lives so naturally in you.

I once saw an article from Focus on the Family by Mitch Temple called “Ten Secrets to a Successful Marriage”¹. Here is the list of “secrets”:

1. Happiness is not the most important thing.
2. Couples discover the value in just showing up.
3. If you do what you always do, you will get the same result.
4. Your attitude does matter.
5. Change your mind, change your marriage.
6. The grass is greenest where you water it.
7. You can change your marriage by changing yourself.
8. Love is a verb, not just a feeling.
9. Marriage is often about fighting the battle between your ears.
10. A crisis doesn’t mean the marriage is over.

The author has a lot to say about each point, but the most important take-away is that to shift from poorer to richer, you have to realize that it is not about the other person. It’s about me. It’s about you. We must take responsibility for our love, our marriage, our relationship, and fight for them, whether we’re in times of plenty or leanness.

It’s up to me, it’s up to you!

1. <https://www.focusonthefamily.com/marriage/ten-secrets-to-a-successful-marriage/>

Chapter 6: In Sickness and in Health: A Reflection on Marriage Vows

Unlike the other parts of the wedding vows, this chapter is straightforward. There are just a couple of definitions of sickness:

- The state of being ill.
- The feeling or fact of being affected with nausea or vomiting.

Health, on the other hand, is defined as:

- The state of being free from illness or injury.
- A person's mental or physical condition.

The fact that the marriage vows include sickness and health says that sickness and health can influence whether or not a couple stays together.

But why? When you have chosen to be with this special person "from this day forward," doesn't that automatically include their well-being? Or yours?

Health and beauty are two of the most promoted yet elusive topics in our society.

When I was 22, I had just got out of the United States Air Force. I was the picture of health; a tall, sexy, chocolate, 6-foot-3-inch dreamboat (or so I was told), with 20/20 vision, a well-defined six-pack, and I weighed in at a smooth 130. I had a full head of hair (emphasis on had). I was as "healthy as a horse!" There was nothing that hindered me from doing what I wanted and being who I wanted to be. Life was grand!

That was then, and this is now (26 years later). I shrunk an inch. I not only wear glasses, but I have bifocals. That six-pack now looks like I'm 6 months pregnant. And at 230 lbs., I've gained a whole 'nother me!

And about that full head of hair, those beautiful locks have receded so far back that I have a lot in common with a cue ball. And if I were to compare myself to a horse now, they would put me out to pasture with my collection of medications for allergies, vitamin D deficiency, acid reflux, high cholesterol, and let's not forget, diabetes.

How many times have we chosen a mate primarily based on looks, physical features, or the activities that they're involved in? The problem is that as time progresses, our ideas change, so much so that excellent health and matchless beauty are put at the bottom of the list if not removed altogether.

Do you remember when the socially ideal woman was the envied figure 8, 36-24-36? All the parts seemed to fit just right, and the ladies would work to get to this size or close to it. Then, several years later, the bar for "perfection" no longer mentioned measurements. The focus was on sizes, and the perfect size was zero! And if you went by all the popular magazines, any lady who was not a zero was not considered as beautiful. So, the great push was just to decrease dress sizes. Now, there has been another shift. Big wasn't just accepted; it has replaced the old ideal of zero. We started seeing full-figured manikins in stores, and shows like "My 600-lb Life" are mainstream phenomena!

This is a peculiar time because all three shifts are now being displayed and considered as equally acceptable and applauded in today's society. There has been less of a change in what is seen regarding men, but inclusiveness seems less pressing for them.

There are many people who are not satisfied with their health or beauty. So, they buy not only gym memberships, weight-loss programs, and pay for bariatric surgeries, options that are all now common everyday trends.

Balancing Health and Commitment in Marriage

But how does all this play into our marriages? This unreasonable lack of balance in how we think about what is healthy or not can quickly turn what could have been a prosperous and healthy relationship into a poor and unhealthy one.

I know a husband who told his wife she was getting fat; if she didn't fix it, he was leaving. The reason for her weight gain was the medication she took to save her life, but that didn't seem to factor into this man's thinking. And she had only gained ten pounds. Threats of divorce for gaining 10 pounds? Really?

By no means am I advocating obesity or being overweight. I am saying, however, that each of us needs to care for ourselves and exercise healthy self-love. We don't need to compare ourselves to anyone else, but we should take the steps required to be our best.

But we need to focus on other kinds of health, specifically mental and spiritual health.

Let's be honest. Marriage is an institution, and some people jokingly talk about mental health and marriage in the same breath as a kind of oxymoron (something like seriously funny, acting naturally, or deafening silence). Others might light-heartedly compare the institution of marriage with another institution, specifically an insane asylum.

The interesting thing is that as a married couple, you'll experience all those oxymorons within your marriage! After all, the idea of commitment comes up in both cases.

But all joking aside, the institution of marriage involves a commitment that does not fluctuate.

My ex-wife was diagnosed with mental challenges, including depression, multiple personalities, and bipolar disorder. And I loved her very much.

We had our usual marital troubles, like any other couple. But there were those other moments, those times when I watched her change into another person and try to hurt her own teenage child.

Love requires real grit. Sometimes, you have to make tough decisions. You have to love someone enough to do what will make them safe or to ensure that they get the proper help to cope and get well. Other times, you may have to acknowledge that you cannot help. In my case, my ex and I moved forward separately. We didn't give up on each other, but we gave up on the marriage.

While this book is about fixing and keeping marriages together, there are moments when we realize the situation is beyond your ability to change it. When that happens, you may

have to face another side of marriage: how to bring it to an end. I'm not advocating that choice, but as hard as you may want to fix the relationship, both have to be able and willing to work at it.

There are clearly some specific challenges that we cannot change. We can get counseling before we are married, but sometimes, all the good intentions in the world are not enough to fix what is wrong.

Let me assure you that pre-marital counseling is one of the most important steps you can take. Couples considering marriage have eyes clouded with amorous expectations and broad (often somewhat unrealistic) dreams. Counseling helps them look at their plans realistically and consider their decisions and what they involve. The process is not designed to let them stare only at their delightful dreams. Instead, a counselor can help them prepare for some of the unavoidable unpleasantness they will experience.

One of the most significant benefits of pre-marital counseling is the potential to discover who they are and how to be transparent with each other in their relationship, even during their courtship.

All too often, we get married to the person who we each have represented ourselves to be rather than who they really are.

During the courting stage, we should start peeling back those layers of persona and be honest with that potential candidate. For example, I was a horrible money manager. So, I covered my poor money skills with payday loans and credit cards. But that persona has a short lifespan because eventually, the commitment of marriage will unmask the pretension.

Soon after getting married, the frustration of my mounting bills affected our relationship. We had to decide to address these issues together. Otherwise, my poor financial skills would have bankrupted both of us.

In short, I may have been able to avoid most of the drama in my first two marriages if we would have gone through pre-marital counseling.

So now, what about our spiritual health?

In 2 Corinthians 6:14 KJV, we read, "Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness?"

The condensed version: our core beliefs should match or be compatible. As with anything else, there are ample examples of couples whose fundamental beliefs don't match up. There are exceptions, but that is not the rule. I have several friends whose central values are vastly different. For example, one husband is Muslim, and the wife is Catholic. They have a fantastic family and are great friends. But again, they are the exception. We'll talk more about this in Chapter 9.

The question is, how are we to deal with the spectrum of health challenges?

Whether we are dealing with physical, mental, or spiritual illness, our response should always be the same. We are to be conduits of grace and healing. Giving up on our spouse in their times of need is not an option.

My parents are a vivid example of this commitment to their vows.

They lived average lives, raised their children into adulthood, and supported other families within the community by “adopting” children from all over the neighborhood. Every time I turned around, someone else was called son or daughter, and my parents loved and cared for each one.

And then came the stunning interruption of breast cancer in the pleasantness of our lives. My mom was stricken with a very rare form of breast cancer. It was found in only one of her breasts, but it affected the lives of our entire family. We all watched as my dad never left her side. He was at every appointment and active in the decisions that were made. He was a soldier! My mom, being full of faith, told the doctors that God was going to heal her and that they would be amazed by the hand of God in her life. So, she never went through any chemotherapy or radiation. The miracle is that she went in for a follow-up visit, and the doctors couldn’t find the cancerous cells. Yes, God had healed her! And my dad was right there at every turn!

Then we faced a new fight with the dread of breast cancer!

This time, the cancer attacked my mom’s other breast, and it was an altogether different type of breast cancer, again, very rare. This time, my mom went through chemotherapy and radiation. And again, my dad was right there, at every turn, faithfully supporting his wife.

My mom was given the all-clear from the new battle with cancer! Her hands were raised in victory, like the hands of the champion boxer at the end of the match! She was evidence that when God wins a battle, He wins completely! There is no such thing as a partial victory with God. So, this new battle with cancer was met with a new victory. And my dad was right there! But then came the diagnosis of lung cancer, the final fight!

To use the boxing analogy, my mom was Muhammad Ali. Cancer #1 was Sonny Liston, defeated in a major upset. Cancer #2 was “The Rumble in the Jungle” against George Foreman, again defeated by a knockout. Notice that each fight had a different opponent, but the results were still the same. Ali won! My mom won! And my dad was right there in her corner, rooting her on to victory!

My mom’s lung cancer was like Ali’s Parkinson’s disease. It was still a battle, but this fight took her out of the ring - always a champion but no longer fighting. On July 14, 2000, God decided that her battle was over and retired her gloves. And, in championship form, my dad was right there!

I pray often that God would allow me to catch the mantle of my father. If I can have even a portion of this man's faith, a measure of his virtue and faithfulness that he displayed as he journeyed with Mom through those battles and valleys, I will be the husband that I need to be. His example showed that genuine love gives no license to walk away in the face of illness.

When taking the marriage vows, we must recognize the commitment that we are making, vows that truly hold fast in every situation. Faithfulness to those vows is easy when everything works well and everyone is healthy. But there will be moments when we may have to care for our spouse during battles with any number of illnesses. Will you accept the challenge as a champion or wave a white flag and wimp out?

Chapter 7: To Love and To Cherish

Cynthia Hand, the author of "Boundless," says, "Love is a many-splendored thing. But it is also a pain in the a." I wholeheartedly agree with the first half of her statement, and I know there can be some truth to the second sometimes. Love is many things, but to avoid what she calls the pain of it, we need to truly understand the many flavors of love and how they work in our lives.

Have you heard the expression "searching for our soulmate"? Well, this is the epitome of erroneous thinking. Soulmates aren't found. You don't just meet someone, have a 10-minute conversation with them, and suddenly, they're your soulmate.

The Urban Dictionary defines a soulmate like this:

"It's like a best friend, but more. It's the one person in the world that knows you better than anyone else. It's someone who makes you a better person, well, actually they don't make you a better person, you do that yourself because they inspire you. A soulmate is someone who you carry with you forever. It's the one person who knew you, and accepted you, and believed in you before anyone else did or when no one else would. And no matter what happens... you'll always love them."

Does any of that sound like some random person who you met on the street?

Here's a profound truth: Soul mates are not "found," they are created!

Unfortunately, we place so much stock in ideologies that we miss the truth. Truth says that when we open our hearts to people, we are giving them access to something extraordinary. How they treat that access builds or destroys any future relationship with that person or with anyone else.

Let's talk about John and Jane.

While John was going through the divorce process, he met Jane. There was mutual interest between them, and they pursued a relationship.

In full disclosure, John told Jane that he was going through a divorce and gave her the details of what was going on. Unfortunately, Jane didn't believe him.

She had been down this road before with married men (technically; you are married until the divorce decree has been finalized). Other guys had told her they were divorced or getting divorced. They established relationships with her. They dated for extended amounts of time, then one day she finds out that there was no divorce, and there was never a conversation of one. In one instance, Jane found out that her guy and his wife never filed for divorce and announced that they were going to have a child!

So, Jane was more than a little distrustful of John.

This story is relevant because John didn't allow her experiences to deter him from pursuing and eventually marrying Jane. He didn't let up and continued being friends with her. He didn't force himself on her.

He loved her, and his love guided them. He knew she was the desire of his heart.

By no means was this an easy venture. They went through lots of successes and failures. They "broke-up" several times, went over a month without seeing each other, and even saw other people. But when it came down to it, he loved her and wasn't going to allow her to get away.

During those months, they became soulmates. They connected at a deeper level because of everything that they had gone through together. They've been married for a while now. They have their challenges, but through their shared experiences, they grew together: #Soulmates.

This is not to be confused with soulmate's second cousin, Soul Tie.

One of my concerns with today's American society is that, amid John and Jane's story, "they saw other people." Meaning, at some point, John slept with someone other than Jane. And she did the same thing! Neither of them has the "moral high ground" in this instance. Both of them opened up to someone outside of their partnership.

Giving of oneself sexually or even deeply emotionally opens the door to the physical transference of bodily fluids, sweat, saliva, and other juices. It kicks open the door for emotional and spiritual connections beyond the physical act.

When we give ourselves sexually to another, we are exchanging a part of ourselves with them. Again, this is an exchange. They are giving us a part of them as well.

According to a report from HealthLine, Inc., entitled "What's the Average Person's Number of Sexual Partners?" (see link), residents in Louisiana (where the study originated) were found to average 15.7 sexual partners! There is a lot of "exchanging" going on! But how does that affect us overall?

“Soul ties” are powerful because the connection doesn’t just go away. The soul tie can linger for years when a spouse is lost through death or divorce. If you remarry, it is not uncommon for the name of the former spouse to show up unexpectedly when introducing the new spouse to a friend or appear instinctively at a significantly emotional moment. And if the connection or “tie” results from a less structured relationship, the result can be just as instinctive. You may have been upset at something your significant other has said or done, and instinctively, the name of another partner is heard coming out of your mouth!

The apologies and the back-pedaling start immediately, but the soul tie has impacted the moment.

The imprint of a soul tie may be experienced internally as well. Mary walks by, and she’s wearing a particular perfume that so-and-so used to wear, and for the rest of the day, you can’t get so-and-so off your mind. You start down memory lane and must resist the urge to pick up the phone. That’s a “soul tie” diversion.

But the bond of a soul tie can be broken. If you have experienced a soul tie because of an illicit relationship, Sheila Wray Gregoire, author of the article “To Love, Honor, & Vacuum; Soul Ties: How to Break Them and Live in Freedom,”¹ provides clear steps to be free of that bond.

1. Accept Forgiveness
2. Confess
3. Fill your mind with goodness
4. Purge Fantasies
5. Pray and move forward in victory!

To move the discussion on into loving and cherishing, any soul ties need to be broken and discarded.

* * *

Love

According to an article in Psychology Today², these are the seven types of love:

1. Eros is sexual or passionate love, the type most akin to our modern construct of romantic love.
2. The hallmark of Philia, or friendship, is shared goodwill.
3. Storge (‘store-gae’), or familial love, is a kind of Philia pertaining to the love between parents and their children.
4. Agape is universal love, such as the love for strangers, nature, or God.

5. Ludus is playful or uncommitted love.

6. Pragma is a kind of practical love founded on reason or duty and one's longer-term interests.

7. Philautia is self-love, which can be healthy or unhealthy.

Scholars consider Agape to be the highest form of love. While its meaning is centered loosely on "charity," it primarily refers to God's love, the same love that He wants us to experience and express. Some suggest that a child's innocent nature and trust instinct are an expression of agape, which may be true in some measure. But the child also has received from his spiritual heritage the fallen nature that soon is evidenced as he grows and meaningfully functions in a fallen world.

Agape is God's gift to lift us above the lesser perceptions of love. But in our focus on marriage, we cannot deny that, prior to marriage, most relationships display a mix of playfulness without sincere concern for commitment (Philia, mixed with Ludus). Some will shift from the many casual relationships to the eros kind of love. The passion of eros is most often sexual. Unfortunately, our current culture has so idolized sexuality that many people define this lesser form of love as the most desirable and become stuck at that level.

When we get married, while the sexuality (eros) that God created us with is undeniably part of this relationship, a maturing marriage increasingly shifts to a more familial texture. The spiritual bond of marriage calls us to raise the bar from eros and the self-focus of philautia to an ever-maturing expression of agape. The "I" is increasingly replaced with "us," and with agape, our relationships are reflections of His plan for our bond of love.

The kids come along and the familial storge expression of love now blends with agape.

To be true lovers, we must learn the art of balancing each of these forms, always blending them with the love God has enabled us to share.

I was once asked, "Do you love your ex?"

My answer was and is a resounding, "Yes."

That may seem unnatural, but let's look a little deeper. When I married, love was one vow and the sum total of the vows. And when I was divorced, my commitment to love could not be set aside. The responsibility doesn't go away. But the love changes because the nature of the relationship changes.

Understandably, I no longer have an eros connection with her. I haven't seen or spoken to one of my exes in over 30 years, but the agape love that God has enabled me to experience is extended to everyone, and that includes my exes. The love is not reflective of our former relationship but reflects how God cares and sees them. So, I am to let His agape love be extended to everyone.

Think about that for a moment. The human reaction to a broken relationship is often less than amicable. Too many times, it is far less than kind. But agape love is to be our guide, and there is no room for hate or fear.

Remember Cynthia Hand's definition of love at the beginning of this chapter: "Love is a many-splendored thing. But it is also a pain in the a**."

To avoid love from being a pain in the rear, we have to level the playing field continually. All the times we have irritated, disappointed, or even hurt each other must be put away, put out of sight. We must start a new scorecard and reset our love to zero often. We all need a clean slate and a fresh start. I know that this flies in the face of our claim to "love each other more every day," but when we start keeping score and measuring our love by performance levels, we should ask ourselves if what we have is truly love. If we keep a ledger with negatives compared to positives, our focus is no longer on our spouse but on ourselves and what we are getting or missing in the relationship. Keeping a tally is not part of genuine love.

My wife loves me, but I am not always easy to love. I get cranky, too busy or distracted. I have times when I have not been very understanding or even too self-centered. She doesn't love me because I am a perfect husband. Some looking on might even say that I am unlovable. But she never stops loving me.

And from time to time, the roles may be reversed, but I never stop loving her.

We love each other even in challenging times, even when we are not at our best.

But we are not keeping score. Our choice to love when the other is going through unpleasantness and may be "out of sorts" doesn't make us winners. If there is a winner, then there must be a loser.

Keeping score can lead to the habit of pettiness. One of us fixed our plate before the other one. She didn't say "I love you" the last time she left the house. I didn't open the car door for her.

So, does that make either of us less loving? Are we winners and losers?

No!

We both need to hit the reset button, throw away the tired ledgers, and shift our outlook so we can experience the agape-filled relationship that looks beyond each other's weak moments and see each other through God's eyes.

Recently, I had an attack of pettiness. I was looking at my wife's Facebook account and realized that almost all the activity came from me or her friends tagging her in our posts. Then, I looked at her Instagram page and was like, "I don't see any pictures of me!" But when people see my Facebook and Instagram pages, she's all over them!

I realized I had an attitude toward her social media accounts. Why wasn't she posting pictures of me? Do people know that she's married? And I wondered who was sending her messages because her husband wasn't on display.

The more I thought about it, the more bothered I got until I started putting things into perspective. My wife isn't a social media poster. She's a 'stalker.' She is the one who visits other people's pages and sees what they are doing, whereas I am a poster and hardly ever look at other people's pages.

So, am I a better spouse because I post? Is she less of a spouse because she doesn't?

I had to check myself. Marriage isn't a spousal competition. It's not about who can show the world the most posts about their spouse. We must remember that we all display love differently, and that revelation solidifies our growth. There are no individual winners. We win together!

* * *

Cherish

To cherish is to protect and care for someone or something. It is holding something or someone with a sense of expectation or hope, with anticipation or keeping hope or ambition in our minds. Cherishing our spouse should look like a sweet embrace and affection.

Here's an excerpt from the lyrics by Kool & The Gang, who performed a song called "Cherish":

The world is always changing

Nothing stays the same

But love will stand the test of time

The next life that we live in

Remains to be seen

Will you be by my side

I often pray before I lay down by your side

If you receive your calling before I awake

Could I make it through the night

Cherish the love we have

We should cherish the life we live

Cherish the love

Cherish the life

One thing that happens in marriage is that we get consumed with life's challenges. We wake up just to go to work. We work only to pay bills. We eat dinner, then go to bed, just to repeat the cycle over and over. But when we look back on our lives, where are the high points of our marriages? What special moments did we have? Did we create any of these special moments, or did we just pass the time? Let's be intentional in our love for each other.

When my children were young, we gave up on Halloween and Trick-or-Treat. There had been far too many reports of tampering with the candy, and I was done with it.

The sad part is that my children, like others, still wanted to participate in beggar's night. So, I made a deal with them. Instead of going out, we'd do something special, like a party or something.

They were excited at first.

All was good until they saw the other children outside going door to door. We ended up having dinner, watching one of their favorite shows on TV, then off to bed.

While they were sleeping, my wife and I rode to the store. I got a bag of mixed candies for the children for no particular reason, just "because."

Well, I'm not one to do anything small if I can help it. "A" bag of candy was almost \$100 worth of candy!

And I didn't just present the candy to the children. I turned the house into Candyland!

There was candy everywhere! The living room was filled with candy. There was candy covering the pool table. Candy lined the stairs. Their bedroom floors and dressers were layered in candy. We even put candy in their shoes and their beds (while they slept). It was a diabetic nightmare, and it was AWESOME!

We had candy for a YEAR...

When the children woke up and saw all that candy, they put on their Halloween costumes and went crazy!

I genuinely cherish moments like this. It does my heart good to remember all the love moments that we've created in our home.

We have to fight the urge to focus on what's wrong in life. Our lives can be fun and exciting! But again, we have to be intentional about it.

One of the most relaxed moments that my wife and I share is merely lying in bed with my wife's head on my chest. We work so hard that when it's time for bed, we pass out. But holding her in my arms is a fantastic feeling. And from time to time, we remind each other that a cuddle is required.

I cherish those moments. Some moments fill your heart. Are you actively making those moments happen, or are you just waiting for them? Well, don't hold your breath! Life has a way of consuming our energy if we let it!

Make it happen!

1. <https://tolovehonorandvacuum.com/2014/05/breaking-soul-ties/>

2. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/hide-and-seek/201606/these-are-the-7-types-love>

Chapter 8: Till Death Do Us Part

As odd as it may sound, we need to begin this chapter like the others, with a definition of our subject. What is this thing called death?

Death...

- The action or fact of dying or being killed; the end of the life of a person or organism.

When I started thinking about 'till death do us part," my mind went directly to the first definition—someone died, and the marriage is over. But the longer I thought about it, the more intrigued I became with this part of the vows.

Most times, we are primarily focused on the fact of death (see definition #1), and except for physical death, we may often glaze over the why (the second and third definitions). That is particularly true when discussing the end of a relationship and even more so when a marriage dies.

But let's start by affirming that marriage represents life. A marriage that has ended (whatever the reason) no longer has life. The soul tie may linger, but the life of the marriage relationship is lost.

The death of a marriage primarily takes place in three ways: physical death, desertion, or divorce. In any of those causes, people will experience sadness, anger, confusion, grief, or the struggle of being alone. Those are all natural responses in dealing with the fact of death or loss. Acknowledging that loss, however, is not the same as understanding it and grappling with why it occurred.

An enlightening report from a Medical Examiner¹ discusses the why or the cause of a death as well as the manner of the death.

The cause of death is the specific injury or disease that leads to death.

The manner of death is the determination of how the injury or disease leads to death. There are five manners of death (natural, accident, suicide, homicide, and undetermined).

Let's blend those insights with the other two definitions at the beginning of this chapter.

- The destruction or permanent end of something
- A damaging or destructive state of affairs

A marriage dies when it is injured or in response to something that has infected it, when it suffers damage that causes it to permanently and irreparably end.

How important it is for us to be clear about this. Beyond the usual responses to loss, we need to realize that a marriage that has ended has been damaged. The relationship has not been healthy. The union's damage and poor health were allowed to fester beyond curing and finally die.

Recognizing that is necessary to recover and heal. Moving out of the fog and heaviness of loss starts with the realization that what has happened is beyond changing. The past is simply the past.

The healing process, however, also requires us to look honestly at the manner of the death. We should not avoid an honest and often painful look at what brought the marriage to that point. We must grapple with what injury or unhealthiness of the marriage led to its death. The life of the relationship did not just suddenly disappear.

This part of the healing requires reflection. Undoubtedly, you will reflect on how the relationship started: the way you met, the dating, and the experience of love and your marriage ceremony. Look back at the events in your lives and search for those moments when the relationship changed. And it will! But did those changes bring you together or cause some measure of differences that were left unresolved? Did the gaps grow wider, the warmth grow cooler? How did you respond? How did your spouse respond?

Remember, the past is the past. You cannot change it.

But if you can be open and clear about the way the relationship became damaged and unhealthy, you will be better equipped to avoid the hurts and experiences of the past being repeated in any relationships in the future.

Now, let's look a little closer at the medical examiner's statements about the manner of death.

"The manner of death is the determination of how the injury or disease leads to death. There are five manners of death (natural, accident, suicide, homicide, and undetermined)."

Natural death obviously occurs when a spouse dies, bringing the marriage relationship to an end, even though the soul tie lingers.

Accidental death, according to USLegal.com², is defined as referring to "a death resulting from an unusual event that was unanticipated by everyone involved. It should not be intended, expected, or foreseeable,".

“I didn’t mean to do that. It was an accident!” I imagine we have all said that, more than once. I remember a time early in my marriage when that was how I responded when I realized I had done something that really bothered my wife.

My wife and I had social circles filled with friends before we were married. Some of those circles overlapped. When we were around some of my former friends, I enjoyed having a good time, not realizing everybody there didn’t know my wife, and I was not introducing her when I should.

I wasn’t intentionally disregarding my wife. But I was not conscious of how much she felt like an outsider. She already had some self-esteem issues from her past that she had overcome, so when I was not thinking of her in those get-togethers, she really felt hurt.

This caused a bit of unrest in the Smith house! Well, to be honest, it grew into a powder keg, ready to explode!

We talked about it a lot and resolved the problem. I promised to be more considerate of my wife in these situations. And it didn’t matter whether I thought they already knew her; I would introduce her, anyway.

Going through that experience was challenging and enlightening. I didn’t realize it was happening. It was unintentional, an accident; but it was damaging my wife and infecting our marriage. Left to fester, this could have been the kind of thing that could kill the marriage altogether.

When we unintentionally do things that traumatize our union, the key to healing is to address the trauma that has been caused, i.e., operate on it, then come up with a decisive plan for recovery.

Suicide. Merriam-Webster defines suicide as the act or an instance of taking one’s own life voluntarily and intentionally.

Whether intentional or not, it is easy for some of us to end up killing the life we have together, simply by not developing a bond that includes planning for the future.

I am not proud of it, but I have been married three times. Each time I got married, I was optimistic for the future and visions of beautiful things coming our way. There was so much we weren’t going to overcome together. Our love was strong and unbreakable.

But I walked into each marriage with no thought about a plan for our future as a couple or the families we were merging.

Benjamin Franklin once said, “If you fail to plan, you are planning to fail!”

Failing to plan and share a purpose as a couple is a formula for marital suicide. How can we expect these beautiful hopes and dreams to be anything more than fairy tales if we aren’t

actively pursuing the life we want together? How do we know what life is now and what it will be in the future if we don't sit down and set goals?

My wife and I really want to have a healthy and happy home. We don't enjoy arguing, fussing, and tension between us. And when any of those things show up, we have to resolve them, or they will potentially hurt our relationship.

When I failed to introduce my wife to my friends, unintentionally assuming she probably already knew them, she felt very uncomfortable and hurt. I realized I need to be aware of any areas in which she is sensitive. I am responsible for respecting those feelings and doing what I must to avoid causing her any discomfort.

We all have things we are sensitive about, not because we are weak, but just because we are human beings with feelings. Each of us needs to take care not to cause the other any undue pain.

A friend of mine told me of his own experience with this. He had taken his fiancée to his church, and some friends sat on the same pew with him as usual. The person next to him was a lady about his age, and when the music began, he realized she did not have a chorus sheet. He shared his sheet with her.

The fiancée was not happy about that. To her, he was disrespecting her by paying attention to his attractive friend. Was it inadvertent? Yes, but it was also dumb. He realized he needed to avoid any action that his fiancée could misinterpret. She needed to sense that she was his priority.

He could have tried to explain his point of view to her, and even try to tell her not to be so thin-skinned; but wisely, he apologized and realized that he needed to act in ways that communicated to her that their new relationship meant more than other relationships.

We create marital suicide when we don't consider how our actions will be understood by our spouses. My friend needed to be aware of how this situation would look to his fiancée. And had he failed to respond lovingly to her that day, a fuse could have been lit that could have destroyed their relationship. Failure to put your spouse's welfare and needs ahead of your own is a path that can lead to marital suicide.

Homicide is defined as the deliberate and unlawful killing of one person by another; murder. A significant cause of killing a marriage comes from allowing entities outside of your union to damage the health of your marriage. Over time, those outside influences, left unchecked, can kill your marriage.

Often, marital homicides happen because we allow people too much access to our marriages, especially close friends and family.

There's no better hitman in marriage than an unhappy family member. They begin by talking about how your spouse should do such-and-such like daddy used to do it. Then, they

graduate to how your spouse isn't doing this or that. They are planting seeds. You trust them. So, what they're saying must be right.

Then, one day, your spouse does what he or she usually does, and suddenly, "I've been dealing with this for way too long." Everything that they've been planting has surfaced. And the person who you loved is now the focus of THEIR pain!

When my mom and dad got married, some people hated my mom. They treated her like garbage every chance that they had. They scandalized her. Talked down to her and were just mean people. This went on for years!

There were many times that I overheard my parents arguing about how my mom was being treated. Many nights, I heard her crying out to God in her bedroom, asking for relief from the stress she was feeling from this abuse.

This happened so long that those treating her poorly realized they wouldn't break her down by attacking her. They started attacking me.

The rest of the children could play. But I had to go sit down. They bought push-ups and bomb-pops for all the children. But since they didn't have enough money, I had to eat whatever leftover ice cream they had in the freezer.

They were deliberately trying to break up my parents' marriage, and I hated them for it.

So much energy was put into trying to destroy my mom that they didn't see they were strengthening her.

We don't have to allow marital homicide to happen. Sometimes, all that we need to do is weather the allegations, complaints, and the barrage of misinformation. Liars and deceivers will get what they deserve. The Law of Reaping and Sowing (or as some call it, Karma) will always come back to those who have visited it on others.

Unfortunately, not everyone is as secure as my mom. Many give up on marriage because their families or close friends don't think that their spouse is good enough for them.

When I proposed to my wife, it was a total surprise for all of us, including me!

We were longtime friends. We enjoyed each other's company. I could see her as the future Mrs. Smith, and so I popped the question.

Unfortunately, the response from those closest to my wife was bewilderment, disgust, and questioning what she was thinking. The calls got so bad on the day that I proposed that I caught her crying and confused, wondering about her decision to say yes.

Then she spoke to her father, and it no longer mattered what everyone else was saying. He was so excited that his baby was getting married that he rejoiced and cried so hard that we started crying with him! He cried and proclaimed his love for God so much that he hung up without asking whether she had accepted my proposal!

Don't fall prey to the homicidal maniacs out there.

Many people commit marital homicide just because their own life isn't what they wanted, and misery loves company. They bond on the mutual sense of being treated unfairly, the belief that everybody else is against them, that they get no breaks, and everybody else gets a break but them. Their relationship is built on mutual misery. And that foundation is weak. Two miserable people become one miserable union.

And then the cause of some marriages is simply said to be "undetermined." Those looking on seem to have no clue, and often the two whose bond has been broken seem equally at a loss to explain it. The general fallback expressions are "irreconcilable differences" or "things just didn't work out."

What is irreconcilable or what did not work out simply means that neither of the spouses put the work in to reconcile or work at their differences. One or both just wimped out. Life got hard, and they got their coats and, in their self-focused stubbornness, marched off with a vague idea that the next relationship will be the "right one." But as the old adage says, "wherever they go, they take themselves with them."

So, while our relationship is filled with smiles and daisies, we should be focused on getting to know the person sitting across the table from us. What are his or her strengths? Where does he or she need to grow, and what can we do to build him or her up? And while we are at it, it would be wise to be brutally honest about our own strengths and weaknesses. This kind of honesty will either lead you to fight for your marriage or the idea of fight will too easily be replaced by the thoughts of flight.

A threat to our marriage comes from the twisted culture of our times. Our values have been infected with a blinding desire for pleasure. People try to medicate themselves with accumulating things, confusing want with need. They turn to destructive behaviors that lead to damage and even destroy their relationship in a mutual addiction to abandoning social and moral boundaries.

Two areas of this cultural shift that are dangerously addictive. The first of these is the belief that more money and power will fix anything. Greed governs behavior that justifies a lack of ethics and even lawlessness that fosters the idea that anything we want is ours to get or take any way we can.

Couples who embrace this idea destroy their marriages because their self-centeredness will inevitably be the seed of dividing them. Left unchecked, the marriage will not survive.

The second cultural shift is the preoccupation with the deterioration and abandonment of sexual boundaries. I include this topic because the entertainment and marketing worlds have inundated our culture with an increasing and intentional redefining of sexuality, casting off any traditional boundaries.

Pornography is now commonly used and labeled as a private matter that is victimless. Many couples now make use of pornography as a shared experience. Their appetites for this so-called “freedom from restraints” drive them to what they may call “mutual pleasure,” but in reality, it drives them apart into a world of their individual desires rather than mutual welfare.

A spouse may seek more “exciting pleasure” in a relationship outside of his or her marriage. Or one spouse may suggest sharing sex with someone else or another couple, and the appeal of pleasure leads them to set aside any kind of reluctance.

This path leads to devaluing each other and an addiction that will inevitably cheapen their relationship and drive them to disregard every other value in preference to their own. And this abandons the anchor of self-worth.

Such deviation from the moral foundation of valuing each other and mutual respect is mutual suicide waiting to happen.

Marital suicide results from mutually abandoning the promise to love and cherish each other and only each other as long as you live. When a marriage has lost the bond of being “as one,” there is the risk of damage and relational illness that becomes irreversible.

1. https://www.washoecounty.us/coroner/faq/difference_cause_and_manner_of_death.php

2. <https://definitions.uslegal.com/a/accidental-death/>

Chapter 9: According To God’s Holy Ordinance

The institution of marriage isn’t just another trend or fad that can be updated to suit the will and whim of a generation. It is an established covenant between a man and a woman designated, created, and ordained by God.

The social norm of our day applauds the rejection of tradition and traditional values. We are encouraged to make our own way, to follow a path of our own choosing, one that is free from the restraints of outdated thinking. The problem is that we don’t have anything to replace it, except the notion that every person’s set of values is as legitimate as anyone else’s.

The heart and will of each person is left to define what life should look like for them. Being social beings, however, the natural tendency is to advocate for that view of reality and try to impress others to join you. And in today’s social and moral climate, there seems to be an unquenchable desire for the “new” way of thinking.

This mindset takes a toll on marriage.

The definition of marriage has been hijacked by a culture that no longer acknowledges the authority of God and, for all practical purposes, denies His existence entirely. So, the idea of marriage as a “holy ordinance” has no meaning.

Marriage has become a relationship of convenience, and when it is no longer convenient or serves the self-interest of one or both spouses, they move on. In fact, marriage is even defined as an inconvenience and unnecessary.

The cultural definition has changed beyond the union of a man and a woman. Love itself has been redefined to legitimize same sex “marriages.” The Biblical idea of marriage is now being ignored.

Having turned away from God and the values that have held civilization together, the objections to same-sex relationships are called divisive and hate-filled. The cultural drift now includes legitimizing gay marriage by churches who have replaced faithfulness to Truth with the social doctrine of inclusion. Their choice is a twisted declaration that God places His seal of approval on that union.

The Bible is noticeably clear about homosexuality. Leviticus 18:22 NKJV says, “You shall not lie with a male as with a woman. It is an abomination.” And it is equally abominable to act in the name of God in total rejection of His word.

The churches that set aside what God has declared and assert that following Him is about being inclusive have lost their way. Under the guise of spreading love, they mirror political and social correctness as if that is compatible with God’s views. They don the garments of darkened thinking instead of being clothed in God’s likeness. Second Timothy 3:5 KJV speaks of “Having a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof: from such turn away.” The human distortion of truth takes the form of godliness but is empty of the power of true godliness.

What power do we have when we call ungodliness as if it were godliness? When we no longer recognize the God who authors holiness, the words “God’s holy ordinance” no longer have meaning. Since Hebrews 12:14 NIV clearly declares that “without holiness no one will see the Lord,” the idea of ungodliness forfeits any measure of His likeness and blinds us from recognizing God or His truth. The fact that our society has accepted and promotes the LGBTQ+ lifestyle doesn’t mean that it’s right.

I know and have friends who have chosen this lifestyle. The discussion this far is not a form of bashing them. Any act to defy God’s directives or redefine them for convenience is the definition of sin, and sin comes in many forms. As a Christian, I am to value every person just as God does, but I can no more endorse homosexuality than I can any other sin. As God grieves at sinfulness, we, as His children, also have to grieve, but the sin itself must remain offensive. Marriage is by His directives as a holy ordinance or a law established by His grace.

God Himself established the first marriage in Genesis 2 when He brought together the man and the woman He had made in His own likeness. Adam’s response to her is classic. Genesis 2:23 MSG states, “Finally! Bone of my bone, flesh of my flesh! Name her Woman for she was made from Man.” He immediately claimed her and named her.

When a marriage takes place between a man and a woman who embrace the faithfulness those vows declare, God honors that union. Even for those who are not believers, the choice to walk in faithfulness to each other is one He favors.

God said in His act of creation that man was not to live alone, so in Proverbs 18:22 NIV, He makes His view quite clear: "He who finds a wife finds what is good and receives favor from the LORD." To those who seek to make their relationship one that reflects His likeness, He adds in Proverbs 10:22, "The blessing of the Lord, it maketh rich, and he addeth no sorrow with it." God's plan for marriage is that it is to bring us security, stability, and partnership. Those are the things that define the richness He spoke of in that verse.

The security of marriage comes from our mutual trust. A marriage that reflects God's design is one in which both spouses have each other's backs. They would never intentionally hurt each other. We have each other's back.

The stability of marriage is evidence of a holy ordinance. God, who does not change, shares, and as we seek His likeness, we can experience the strength of stability. Each spouse can sense that no matter what comes their way, they are loved, and the commitment of that love is strong. Unlike the roller coaster rides other friendships take us through, they know they can rely on their spouse.

The likeness of God is also seen in the partnership of marriage. Our commitment to be life-mates, to be each other's ride or die. Together, it's us against the world.

These are just a few of the things that make marital blessings rich!

God declares that society is to hold the institution of marriage as sacred.

"Marriage is to be held in honor among all [that is, regarded as something of great value], and the marriage bed undefiled [by immorality or by any sexual sin]; for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterous,"

(Hebrews 13:4 AMP).

The wording of that verse in The Message MSG expresses a parallel between honoring marriage and guarding the sacredness of sexual intimacy between a wife and husband. God draws a firm line against casual and illicit sex.

A marriage lived as a holy ordinance tells us that the sexual union of marriage is to be respected and guarded. That part of the relationship is to be secure and undefiled.

God made us to be intimate, and that intimacy is to be enjoyed within the boundaries of the sacredness of marriage. It is also how we can bear children, extensions of our sacred bond.

In short, the bond we share as a couple is with the God who ordained the institution of marriage. For those who may not marry, and if they have the spiritual giftedness of celibacy, they can enjoy their bond with the Lord. But the Apostle Paul notes in 1 Corinthians 7:2 ESV

that if someone's relationship with God is distracted by the temptation of sexual immorality, it is better for them to marry and adds that "each man should have his own wife and each woman her own husband." While sexuality is normal, it is not to be misused or experienced outside the bonds of marriage. The married couple is to carefully guard that relationship because anything that intrudes or defiles it violates His design for a man and a woman to be one. They are to belong solely to each other as a holy union.

As we discussed in the previous chapter, the world we live in today can easily infect us with a distorted image of sex and love. Those who seek to live in holy matrimony must never allow their bond to include any practice that defiles the union. Multiple partners, the world's enticement to persuade you to respond to such deviancies as "open marriage," together or separately, defiles what God designed for us and allows the enemy to gain a foothold that can lead to the destruction of the marriage.

Again, the Apostle Paul speaks clearly to this matter in 1 Corinthians 7:

Sexual drives are powerful, but marriage is strong enough to contain them and provide a balanced and fulfilling sexual life in a world of sexual disorder.

He then adds,

"The marriage bed must be a place of mutuality—the husband seeking to satisfy his wife, the wife seeking to satisfy her husband. Marriage is not a place to "stand up for your rights." Marriage is a decision to serve the other, whether in bed or out (1 Corinthians 7:2-6 MSG).

Notice that we are to serve each other. This is a term that contains the idea of ministry. The marriage relationship is a sacred ministry dedicated to each other. Our whole relationship is one of meeting the needs of each other "in bed or out." Paul's expression, translated here as "serving" each other, is not to be confused with the twisted cultural use of that term. This is how your intimacy responds to God's plan for us to be one.

Marriage is an image of God's commitment to the Church. Physical intimacy responds to each other's natural desire to be complete. Yet, there is a spiritual intimacy with God that forever completes us. Our willingness to be selfless and passionate about each other's desire to be complete is a human experience that pales in comparison to the selflessness of Christ, whose focus was on our needs rather than His own. As with the Lord, our bond is a connection of our entire self, mind, body, and soul.

But Paul is not finished with his instruction. In 1 Corinthians 7:5, he says:

"Do not deprive each other [of marital rights], except perhaps by mutual consent for a time, so that you may devote yourselves [unhindered] to prayer, but come together again so that Satan will not tempt you [to sin] because of your lack of self-control."

The marriage relationship, this ordinance from God, is to be for mutual benefit. The role of husband and wife is not to be centered on each other only part of the time. We are to meet each other's needs in all aspects of our relationship, including the sexual bond.

However, we are not to allow natural desires to stand in the way of our spiritual roles. A couple living in a holy relationship must recognize that there are times when spiritual purposes take precedence over physical desires.

In the Bible, physical intimacy is expressed as “knowing”: Adam “knew” his wife, for example. Mary, the mother of Jesus, had not “known” Joseph until after the birth of Jesus. There is a real sense that intimacy, sexual or otherwise, is a time of unmasking and allowing ourselves to be vulnerable. We realize the value of our spouse. We discover nuances of who they are or new measures of what we already value in each other.

Paul’s word in 1 Corinthians 7:5 points to physical intimacy, but the principle is that we are not to withhold intimacy from each other. We are to be vulnerable and transparent. Failing to experience mutual intimacy denies the other the privilege of growing closer with us and us to them. As God desires to reveal Himself to us and allow us to grow in our bond with Him, we should reflect the same desire to be transparent in our relationship.

A husband and wife who withhold intimacy will eventually become strangers. They grow apart rather than experience growing strength as one.

Paul, of course, points out that a lack of physical intimacy opens the door to temptation. The enemy will put someone in your path as an invitation to satisfy that desire. The same is true of intimacy of any kind. In its absence, the heart is tempted to seek it somewhere else.

The ministry of marriage is a sacred trust. Jesus said in Matthew 6:22, “seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness.” That is the key to the bond you will have with Him, but it will also ensure that earthly bonds will be viewed through the same lens. This is the key to experiencing the other blessings of God, including a healthy relationship with your spouse.

In Ephesians 5:22-24 MSG, we find that husbands and wives are to experience mutual submission:

Wives, understand and support your husbands in ways that show your support for Christ. The husband provides leadership to his wife the way Christ does to his church, not by domineering but by cherishing. So just as the church submits to Christ as he exercises such leadership, wives should likewise submit to their husbands.

The key to “understanding and supporting” is submitting. If you are not willing to submit, you are choosing to stay self-focused instead of understanding your spouse and affirming his or her value.

Then, for the husbands:

Husbands, go all out in your love for your wives, exactly as Christ did for the church—a love marked by giving, not getting. Christ’s love makes the church whole. His words evoke her beauty. Everything he does and says brings the best out of her, dressing her in dazzling

white silk, radiant with holiness. And that is how husbands ought to love their wives. They're really doing themselves a favor—since they're already “one” in marriage.

The instructions to husbands also point out a posture of submission to the needs of their wives. The husband is to make his wife's need for support, strength, and growth, especially her spiritual growth, his priority in the same way Christ gave Himself for the Church. A husband's love is sacrificial.

The spiritual posture of love is one of giving of yourself. The old claim that marriage is a 50-50 proposition is not Biblical. The formula for a successful marriage relationship is 100-100. Each gives him or herself completely to support and strengthen each other. And in that way, they are making themselves stronger and healthier.

God's desire for marriage is that we provide an earthly example that reminds people of Christ's relationship with His Church.

God's directive to Adam and Eve was to take possession of what He had created. They were to be fruitful and multiplying; because caring for His creation included, by His design, the role of filling the earth by reproduction.

The creative nature of God is evidenced in the nature and instincts of the creation. And Adam and Eve, made explicitly in His likeness, were to be “fruitful” and fill the earth with offspring, who also would bear His likeness.

Just as God made us individually to be reflections of Him, in the same way His holy ordinance of marriage is to reflect His relationship with us as well. This provides a model of love that invites others to want their relationship to be healthy and whole.

Again, using the thought of reproduction, great marriages reproduce great marriages!

I was blessed to have a childhood in which both of my parents were in the home. I saw the challenges and triumphs of marriage. I experienced the greatness of their relationship, and it made me want to have a great marriage someday. My goal was to follow my parents' example.

Some who will read this book may not have had that kind of experience growing up. And if you're still reading, you apparently want to experience something better than what was modeled for you. And let me assure you, that is not beyond reach.

The key is connecting with people and marriages that are successful, and more specifically, those marriage relationships that are grounded in God's holy ordinance. Learn from them. Glean from their experiences with those qualities that you want to have in your own life. This way, you can reproduce what you see in them.

Begin with the holy ordinance that God designed marriage to be, and your life together will be fruitful models for others as well.

The health of society depends on the spiritual health of the family.

Chapter 10: And Thereto I Pledge Myself To You

At the conclusion of the marriage vows, an exchange takes place. The wording may vary in different versions of the vows, but it is stated, the bride and groom pledge themselves to each other.

According to Merriam-Webster, these are the definitions of the word pledge:

- a bailment of a chattel as security for a debt or other obligation without involving the transfer of title
- the state of being held as security or a guaranty
- a token, sign, or earnest of something else
- a gage of battle
- a toast
- a binding promise or agreement to do or forbear

At one time, when a man wanted to take a bride, he or his family had to pay what was called a bride price, sometimes called a bride service, to formalize and legitimize a traditional marriage, and it also allowed that marriage to be held in a church or civil service. The union was considered invalid if the bride price wasn't paid in full at the time of the marriage or at least paid within the agreed time required.

Conversely, in many cultures, the bride would bring a dowry into marriage as an offering to the groom and his family. The dowry could be money, land, or any other asset in exchange for marriage. Just as the purpose of the bride price is not to "purchase" a bride, the dowry is not the price to secure a husband, but both are expressions of respect for the family and a demonstration of how much the bride or groom is valued. And in both cases, these exchanges are a guarantee against divorce.

At least in the United States of America, giving a literal bride price or dowry became illegal as time passed. However, the exchange of worth still takes place when a bride's family traditionally covers the cost of the wedding. The groom is expected to take care of rehearsal dinners and honeymoon expenses.

But in terms of the vows, there was still a need to make an exchange during the marriage ceremony. Then enters the "troth."

"Troth" is an archaic word with two basic definitions:

1. faith or loyalty when pledged in a solemn agreement or undertaking, and

2. truth. These two definitions point in the same direction. A vow to live truthfully certainly includes loyalty and fidelity. A lady once said, "I don't trust women." Then, she continued to describe how other women have made advances toward her husband, where he works.

Even though he had a wedding ring, one lady left her phone number on his final receipt. Another woman gave him her Snapchat account and asked him to snap with her later that night.

Her husband did not respond to either suggestion. He was committed to his vow to love and cherish his wife. But it occurred to me that this is not about trusting other people but about having confidence and trust in your spouse.

The pledge in our vows is a commitment to a covenant. It is a pledge by both the bride and the groom to a relationship of faithfulness and selflessness.

A pledge or covenant is only as binding as the person making it. This is a covenant relationship, a kind of "contract" to which both parties declare their commitment that will bind them to each other. This covenant is about faithfully loving and caring for each other's needs, tending to their growth and care, and being the source of their strength. These words promise to address the other's desires and place their needs even above yours.

Sadly, that sense of covenant in our culture seems to have become as archaic as the word "troth." Almost half of all marriages in our country end in divorce. We have lost the genuine sense that covenant is more than words. It is a commitment that requires deliberate choices to follow. You have to work to have a committed relationship.

This kind of relationship requires work because the enemy will make every effort to derail us. He knows we are not blind and will use any means to entice us. The handsome man or beautiful lady can become his bait.

In such moments, I have had to reaffirm my vow of commitment to my wife. My life has changed, and I am in a covenant relationship with her.

When we waver in our commitment, that choice will have a penalty. Back in another era, that would have required returning a bride price or a dowry. Try marrying someone and receiving 100 acres of land just to give the land back because you don't want to be married anymore!

Today, the price is set by legal requirements and is increasingly costly. The expected 50-50 split often becomes a bit more lopsided than that. While joking about getting a divorce, Eddie Murphy once said, "I've never met a woman who was worth half."

As someone who has been divorced, it isn't just about half of my "stuff." When our pledge and commitment are broken, it costs me a part of myself. I'm not the same person I was before I got married.

When we look at the pledge, we must also look at whom the promise is being given to. Most of us only look at our beautiful, blushing bride or the handsome, caring groom in front of us. But there's much more happening at that moment. The covenant we are sealing is before "God and these witnesses"!

As a witness to the pledge, we become a party to the promise.

There was a time when people would help couples stay together! The older men would help the younger guys with words of wisdom. And the older women would guide the younger ladies.

This support from the community helped build stronger marriages because the witnesses to the marriage took stock in the union's outcome.

God's approval of marriage and His witness give power to the seriousness of this commitment. We say honoring God's union isn't essential when we break the covenant.

We are dishonoring God!

Therefore, marriage shouldn't be entered into lightly.

No one ever said that getting and staying married was an easy venture. No matter who you are or who you are married to, there will be days that are more challenging than others. And even moments when you may feel you don't want to be married at all.

The key is that marriage is worth it!

Whether you have read this book as part of your pre-marital counseling or you've been married to your bride for 90 years, marriage is a noble institution! It requires work. But the benefits of the work far outweigh any challenges you'll face!

On the final page of this book, I have included a special prayer entitled "Prayer for Married Couples." May we embrace this as our own.

Prayer for Married Couples

— Archdiocese of Baltimore, 19901

Lord God, we acknowledge your greatness

and our need for your grace in our marriage.

We thank you now for the gift you have given us in each other,

this opportunity to love and be loved completely.

We accept this beautiful challenge and ask you to bless us.

May our love encourage us to grow to be holier individuals,

bringing out the best in each other.

Following your example, Jesus, may we be quick to forgive,
ready with a healing word or touch.

Teach us to speak to each other with charity and honesty.

Help us avoid the temptation to take each other for granted.

Instead, remind us, day by day, to see each other as you see us.

May we be as patient with each other as you are with us.

May our love be generous,

reaching out beyond ourselves to all we meet.

We pray that they may meet you in us.

Let our life together be a light of hope to those who
fear that a total commitment is not possible today.

Faith gives us courage,

for we believe that the love that comes

from you is freeing and life-giving.

Lord, be a partner with us in our marriage;

with your help, it will be strong and enduring.

We rejoice that you have brought us together.

May we always be one in you.

Amen.

1. <https://www.archbalt.org/marriage-family-life/prayer-married-couple/>

About the Author

Jackie Smith Jr. is a prolific author renowned for his transformative “Establishing Glory” series. Hailing from the vibrant city of Columbus, Ohio, Jackie has led a remarkable life shaped by diverse experiences that have become the cornerstone of his inspirational writing.

With a background as a technical trainer, a successful entrepreneur, a gifted musician, and an ordained elder, Jackie possesses a unique perspective on life’s challenges and triumphs.

His multifaceted journey has equipped him with profound insights into faith, marriage, music, divorce, and modern parenting.

The “Establishing Glory” series is a testament to Jackie’s unwavering commitment to empowering individuals to unlock their full potential. Through his books, he fearlessly delves into the complexities of life, offering practical guidance and steadfast support to readers seeking personal growth and self-improvement.

Jackie’s dedication to helping others shines through each page of his writing, making him a trusted mentor in personal development. His words resonate authentically, offering a guiding light for those navigating life’s challenges.

As the author of the “Establishing Glory” series, Jackie Smith Jr. continues to inspire countless individuals worldwide, leaving an indelible mark on the landscape of self-help literature. His commitment to spreading positivity and empowerment remains at the heart of his literary endeavors, ensuring that his legacy of transformation endures for generations to come.